Compassion: The Brutal Little Mercies We Live For

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/34644163.

Rating:
Explicit

Archive Warning:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra), Adora/Catra (She-Ra), All the canon ships, Catra & Hordak (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Wrong Hordak (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Swift Wind | Spirit, Frosta (She-Ra), Micah (She-Ra), Angella (She-Ra), Castaspella (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Double Trouble (She-Ra), Horde Prime Clones (She-Ra), Star siblings (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Angst, Post-Canon, Post-War, Fluff, Aftermath of Violence, Hurt/Comfort, Damaged People Being Damaged, Light dusting of crack, Catra (She-Ra) Redemption, Hordak Redemption (She-Ra), smattering of smut, [catradora smut ch8]

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English

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Part 4 of Season of the Survivor

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by AintGonnaHauntItself

Summary

Hordak and Catra begin efforts in reconstruction. The princesses juggle the world's problems and try to get a handle on extraterrestrial issues.

Notes

Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization and post-war angle. So uh, expect the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you're dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anyone for anything.
The art is anonymous and meant for sharing.

“Do we have a chance?”

Chapter Summary

> Catra rushes to make the rescue mission happen while keeping it a secret from Glimmer and Micah.

Chapter Notes

> Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization and post-war angle. So uh, expect the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you’re dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anyone for anything.
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See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra’s first instinct was to keep the mission a secret between Entrapta, Hordak, and herself, but as they discussed their options, it became apparent that they’d need to pull more people in. Catra still insisted, however, that they not tell Glimmer and Micah. She just couldn’t stand the idea of getting their hopes up before dashing them. So while Hordak and Entrapta kept talking tech, she used the messenger she’d been given for alliance business to summon Bow and Adora from their work with the clones, and gave them her best impression of the situation as it had been explained to her. Melog had kept her invisible while she stole everything on Entrapta's supply list, but Catra didn't want them anywhere near an interdimensional portal. She'd send them off to pal around with Emily and they'd gone willingly, but the smart-ass extraterrestrial was certainly vocal about their opinions as they sauntered away, tail swishing haughtily. She was really starting to feel the pressure by the time she met Adora on the edge of the rebel encampment after stealing everything on the supply list Entrapta had given her..

“I still don’t understand,” Adora said in a hushed tone as they speed-walked to Entrapta’s tent, Bow trotting along behind them.

“Neither do I,” Catra snapped, “but you try getting those two nerds to talk straight.” She held the long slash she’d left in the tent flap open to show them the entrance, ignoring their questioning looks. “In.”

“Gaaah,” Entrapta warbled distractedly, “you’re here.” She crossed the room on her feet, holding multiple screens and an odd-looking antenna with her hair. “The communicators are working and we’re nearly ready to leave.”

“Leave?” Bow asked faintly, exchanging worried glances with the other two. Entrapta was distressed and agitated at the same time as talking about tech, which was a very bad sign.

“We need to get to the Velvet Glove.” Catra’s blood ran cold and she felt her ears flatten. “All the tech we need to do this fast is there. I don’t know if it’ll be easier to somehow bring it back down here or to somehow re-space-proof a chamber and rig up some kind of airlock thingy.” The other three exchanged terrified glances. “Are we still not telling Glimmer? Because her teleporting would be super useful right now.”

“No,” the other three said in tandem.

“Okay, okay,” she relented. “Adora, we need to take Darla up right away, and we’ll need She-Ra at first to help us clear the way and find what we need.”

“No problem,” Adora said firmly, and Catra could practically see her old salute.

“Bow, I’m going to have to give you instructions to get the whole communication-slash-transport situation down here going remotely, although that’ll also include gathering a bunch of tech from Prime’s ships,”

“Which gives us a good excuse for this trip in the first place,” Catra acknowledged.

“I don’t think I have the kind of know-how to…” Bow began uncertainly.

“Sure you do,” Catra interrupted in a calm tone. “Plus we’ve got a lot of clones on hand that are trained to use all that tech. I’m positive you can figure it out.” He gulped.

“Hordak spoke for the first time from over by Entrapta’s workstation, turning around to face them. “Can the clones spare you two?”

“Swift Wind and Wrong Hordak are crushing the pep-talks and inspiration, and my dad George knows how to get things done in a way they recognize. They’re already doing most of the work now that She-Ra’s done her meet-and-greet, so I think they can manage without us for a while… although I’ll probably need to tell my dad about this so he can help me cover.”

Hordak nodded and turned back to his work.

“Is Hordak wearing fuzzy slippers?” asked Adora, frowning down at Hordak’s feet.

“You should have seen the bathrobe,” Catra muttered, making Adora snort in the dorkiest, most charming way.

Hordak frowned, but didn’t otherwise react. Bow brought their attention back to planning. “When do you think we’ll be able to do this? Because Glimmer’s going to be busy, but she’s going to want progress reports and…” he trailed off, glancing at Adora.

“And not all of us are great with secrets,” she finished sheepishly.

“It could be anywhere from hours to days, but I’m hoping we can find something that’s mostly intact so Hordak and I could adapt it to what we’re trying to do. We might even be able to make the run before the night is over.” Entrapta said.

Everyone but Hordak exchanged determined looks. “What next?” Catra asked.

“Finished,” Hordak announced. “We’re ready when you are.”

Entrapta ran around and grabbed tools to throw into a large bag that Hordak dutifully held open for her. When she looked around herself, harried in the center of the tent, he took his cue to pack what she was forgetting. “Oh!” she picked up a tote in the corner and hefted it into her arms, crossing back to them with a groan. “Here, this one is too heavy for him.” She handed it off into Adora’s grip, who immediately dropped to the floor with the heavy tote. After she transformed into She-Ra, she took the bag that Hordak was carrying as well and put the box that Entrapta was carrying under her free arm.

No one tried to stop them or distract them on their way to Darla, though Catra almost wished they had. She was eager to try and right her wrong against Queen Angella and her family, but the prospect of returning to the Velvet Glove had her heart beating faster and her palms sweating. She glanced at Hordak to try and see if he was nervous too, but as ever he was simply frowning and skulking. Or was he prowling? He might have been prowling, but it was hard to tell with the fuzzy slippers.

They all remained silent as they boarded Darla and set off. It wasn’t until they were well on their way that Adora picked up on Catra’s growing discomfort as they sat on the floor with their backs against the dash. “Are you okay?” she asked gently.

“I don’t want to talk about it.”

“You don’t have to, but I wanted to check. I don’t want to go back either, but I can’t imagine what this is like for you.” Her charitable understanding would have felt like divine grace, if the notion hadn’t been thoroughly spoilt.

“I’m going to get Angella back. That’s what matters to me most right now.”

“Are *you* okay?” Bow asked, looking at Hordak’s back. The others turned to him, but Hordak didn’t reply. Catra knew he’d heard them because her sharp eyes caught his ear twitch. “Hordak?”

Hordak started and turned. “Yes?”

“Are you okay?” Bow repeated kindly.

Hordak looked around himself, as if to check to see if he was really the one being addressed. Entrapta gave him an encouraging smile and a thumbs up. “I, uh,” he said, confused and stalling.

“It’s okay for you guys to not be okay,” Bow said, looking between Hordak and Catra.

She and Hordak exchanged a grim look of understanding, and Catra spoke again. “We’ve got a mission to complete. We can focus on that and be okay later.”

“Your welfare matters,” Adora insisted.

“So does Queen Angella’s,” Hordak said. It wasn’t a remonstration, just a statement.

“You of all people should understand that,” Catra muttered. *Now that was a remonstration* . As the look of hurt crossed Adora’s face, she could have kicked herself. She didn’t have to say that. *Why* did she say that? “Shit, I’m sorry,” she whispered.

Adora wrapped an arm around Catra’s shoulder and sighed. “It’s okay. Everything's going to be okay.”

* * * * *

Later that night, Hordak, Entrapta, and Catra were in a deep compartment on the Velvet Glove when the quiet noise of their working was interrupted by the loud creak Darla created when she docked nearby. As it happened, what Adora had done to the ship was dramatic, but not entirely thorough. Most of the craft was emptied when Prime summoned all clone divisions to the battle, so they were spared any potential carnage, which she knew was a prospect that had been upsetting Adora. There had been only one really awful occurrence.

She had clenched Adora's hand hard while they walked with the aid of the ship's gravitational field, and she'd kept her eyes on her feet, avoiding the sleek white architecture that surrounded them. When they had found a hallway that was all airtight and Catra had removed her helmet for a moment of free breathing, she'd jumped and hissed, all the hair on her body raising on end. The stench on the air was palpable.

"What is it?" Adora had asked her in alarm.

"You don't smell that?" Catra had hissed, trying hard to ignore the alarm bells flooding her with adrenaline.

The other had sniffed hard and grimaced, making Catra's stomach lurch. "Now you mention it…" she'd muttered, looking around at the doors that branched off of the hall they were in.

"Keep moving," Hordak had growled. Entrapta shot him a worried look and Catra had noticed his ears were pinned back.

Catra had replied in a shaking, horrified tone. "What the fuck is that, Hordak?" she choked before replacing her helmet.

"It's coming from the hallway to our right, and it is currently irrelevant to our mission. There's nothing to be done about it right now."

Bow had looked appalled, and she knew he'd sensed their horror. He gave her a questioning look, but Catra had only shuddered hard and was grateful when nobody pressed the subject.

Whatever she and Hordak had smelled, it was dead as shit and there was a whole lot of it.

They'd found a series of rooms in the teleportation part of the ship which they'd repaired and sealed relatively quickly, lucky that Prime's fire and explosion response system consisted of removing the oxygen from any given room at any given time. Catra had convinced Bow and Adora to leave her behind with Entrapta and Hordak to help them, with some difficulty. She wasn't much help with the tech stuff, but she was good for handing off the tools and materials they grunted for as they worked on the portal and Entrapta finished up his armor.

They eventually heard Darla dock on the ship nearby, though it took a while for Bow and Adora to find their way back. Eventually they heard the room just beyond theirs fill with air before the other two walked through the door, taking off their helmets. "You said it's go-time?" Bow asked.

"Nearly done reinforcing the connections here. We're ready to…" Hordak trailed off, looking at Entrapta.

"I'm almost done with the suit," Entrapta said, flipping back her mask and rubbing her eyes wearily. Catra felt a stab of concern as she noted the exhaustion all over her face.

"You finish this," Catra said to Hordak, snapping his attention back to his work. "I'll help Entrapta explain." She got up and crossed to the other two.

"Is Entrapta working on a suit of armor for Hordak?" Bow asked, eyeing her questioningly.

"Yes!"

"Just listen to her," Catra said as the tired scientist came over and offered a bright smile.

"While we are fairly confident in our chances of success, I should mention that what we're doing here is extremely dangerous for

us, the planet, and the rest of the universe," Entrapta said from where she was working.

"Is this ethical to be doing?" Bow asked.

"You going to try and stop us?" Catra asked, and he shook his head, looking worried.

"That's why it's a secret," Entrapta said patiently, "and that's why She-Ra has to stay here." Adora gave Catra a sharp look.

"So She-Ra can use her power to stop any damage we cause from spreading," Catra explained.

"Hopefully!" Entrapta said. "It's difficult to tell what's going on in there, but it seems that the remnants of the moonstone in that temporary universe are reacting with her magic and creating some kind of bubble where she's been able to stay alive, somehow-though we don't know what shape she's in. What we've got to do today is punch a hole through all that collapse, directly into that bubble that's keeping her alive, and keep it open long enough to extract her. Without killing anyone. It'll be fun!" Catra snorted as Bow and Adora exchanged looks of growing concern. "Anyway, there's also a chance…"

"A pretty high one," Catra interjected.

"A pretty high chance that trying to do that will take a turn for the catastrophic, in which case I need to shut it down immediately. But don't worry! I'll leave it on long enough for Catra and Hordak to go through, She-Ra will help me stop it from destroying the universe, and I can tinker a little bit and hopefully open up another portal long enough to get everybody back within a few hours!"

"Everybody?" Adora asked, still looking at Catra. "Who's everybody?"

"That's the other thing," Catra said.

“Sending in a portable stabilizer will increase everybody’s chance of survival, but the field of magic around Angella is shifting so erratically that somebody needs to be there to manually work the thing.”

“Which only Hordak and Entrapta could do. I mean,” she looked at Bow, “You might be up to it, but we need you to keep Glimmer off our trail,” said Catra. “And seeing as Entrapta is the smarter of the two, she’s the one who should stay here to both protect Etheria and retrieve the rescue party. That leaves me to keep Angella from killing Hordak, and seeing as all this is our fault in the first place it may as well be us who go.” Adora was already shaking her head, but Catra cut her off before she could argue. “Adora, you need to let me make peace with what I’ve done wrong.” The other stopped shaking her head and gave Catra a pleading look, big blue eyes shimmering. “If I’ve got a chance to get Glimmer’s mom back, I’m taking it.”

“But why can’t I come with you?” Adora asked in an uncharacteristically whiney voice.

“Seriously, Adora? Of all the dumbass…” Catra rolled her eyes and gave her a half smile. “Because Etheria *needs* you.”

“We all have responsibilities to face,” Hordak interjected unexpectedly as he straightened and sighed, apparently done with his work on the portal. He didn’t meet any of their eyes as he crossed over to Entrapta. “What else can I help you with?” he asked her.

“Oh, nothing really,” she said. “I was just double-checking all the seams. Ready to get dressed?”

“More than,” he replied. For some reason she grabbed the helmet and started off away from him. Catra grinned at the ears Entrapta had put on it without any regard for Hordak’s ego. He gathered the suit in his arms and followed her with a look of vague confusion.

“Why do you guys need to wear spacesuits?” Bow asked.

“Just a precaution,” Catra shrugged, hoping they wouldn’t need them after all.

“I know you have to do this, but I really don’t want you to go,” Adora murmured to Catra as they watched Entrapta lead Hordak to a different part of the room, around a large piece of machinery. She knew as well as he did that they didn’t need privacy for the getting dressed part, and she smirked at Entrapta’s back.

“I know,” she said, turning back to Adora. “But you don’t get to be the hero all the time.”

“That’s not what I meant,” Adora argued, looking frustrated and upset. Bow decided to go inspect the portal as she and Adora drew close to one another.

“I know,” Catra said soothingly. “But it’s going to be okay, like you said.” She smiled as Adora groaned and slipped her arms around Catra’s waist. “Hordak and I almost conquered the planet on a few different occasions. I think we can handle this rescue mission.”

“Without killing each other?”

“Without killing each other.” Catra pressed her lips to Adora’s forehead, but Adora wasn’t having it. She cupped the back of Catra’s head and brought her in for a searing kiss. “Come back to me,” she said fiercely when she pulled her mouth away, breathing slightly heavier than usual. “Come back home to me when this is done. No matter what.”

Catra nuzzled her nose against Adora’s and leaned against her. “You know I will.” They spent a few more moments in each others’ arms before Catra broke away reluctantly to start donning her spacesuit. “And don’t think I haven’t noticed nobody’s teasing Hordak about the ears on his helmet.”

She saw Bow shrug from over by the Portal. “He’s scarier.”

“Wha… I…” Catra sputtered, indignant at the unfairness.

“Sorry Catra, I guess you’re just too cute to be objectively more frightening than the evil warlord Hordak,” Adora said smugly, coming over to steal one last kiss from a frazzled Catra.

* * * * *

Said evil warlord was currently listening to Entrapta ramble off instructions, guesses, variables, warnings, and any other kind of advice that came to mind as she helped him into his new space-worthy armor. He was watching her carefully as she chattered, tallying signs of serious fatigue as she went. “Entrapta,” he finally interrupted. Now that he was wearing armor that stabilized and strengthened him, sinking to his knees before her was no trouble. “Look at me,” he said as she avoided his eyes. She met them with a reluctant frown, and he hated how very worn she looked. “You. Need. To. Rest.”

“We have a mission to focus on right now, remember?” she asked with a half-smile. She held out her hand for the crystal to power his armor.

“I know, but when I come back, you’re taking 24 hours off.” He passed the crystal to her.

“Then promise me you’ll come back.”

“Entrapta,” he said gently, picking her gloved hands up in his own, looking directly into her eyes from his position on his knees.

“Promise!” she demanded, and a tear rolled down her cheek. He hadn’t even realized she was scared. “Promise that no matter what, you’ll do everything in your power to come home.” She pulled her hands from his and placed them on either side of his

face. “Promise me you’ll come home,” she repeated softly as she clicked the crystal into place with a strand of magic hair.

He breathed a relieved sigh as he felt the artificial strength flood back through him. He straightened his back before fixing her with a stern gaze. “Always,” he said.

“And I’ll do everything I can to find you,” she pressed her forehead gently to his, “always.” He brought his freshly plated arms to wrap around her and she brought a hand to his chin. “May I kiss you?” she asked him. As if she wasn’t keeping record of how long he could keep his face between her legs without coming up for air.

Her mouth was only inches from his as his mind flashed to Prime. He focused on her currently dark pink eyes, pushed the intrusive thoughts away, and nodded. He moved one hand to press his palm across her upper back as he felt the gentle press of her lips, and focused on the warmth that passed between them there. They held the kiss, close-mouthed and silent. Somehow, deep within the sterility and oppression of Prime’s sanctuary, Hordak felt a thrill of something he was sure was sacred.

“Ahem.”

Hordak jumped and snapped his arms back to his torso in a flinch. Entrapta, who wasn’t fazed, blinked dazedly.

“I think Adora and Catra are as ready as you are,” Bow muttered, pulling a face and staring pointedly at the wall next to them.

Hordak stared at the floor, trying to collect himself. He felt Entrapta’s hand on his face again and looked up into her eyes. “Let’s do this,” she said with a determined expression. Hordak nodded and stood before he moved to clasp his hands behind his back, but Entrapta had grabbed one of them and didn’t let go. Instead, he let her keep hold of his hand with her own and followed meekly as she led them back toward the portal.

Catra was zipping up her space suit with her own eared helmet under her arm. She didn't acknowledge him as he walked to her side, picking up the large bundle of supplies they had gathered on his way. Entrapta let go of him and crossed to the desk where she had all of her control apparatus set up. She wouldn't meet his eyes as she began typing, but he noted with relief when the scientific significance of Queen Angella's extraordinary situation monopolized her attention and made her grin at her screens.

Mechanical noises began to increase in volume around them and he noticed several flashes of light materialize sporadically in the center of the empty portal. He reluctantly tore his eyes from Entrapta's face and watched their portal activate, flashing and sputtering alarmingly. He and Catra put on their helmets and stared into a scene they did not recognize, waiting for Entrapta's go-ahead.

Pink and purple mists seem to swirl between electrical glitches that seemed to make the scene in the portal change suddenly and unpredictably. "Aaaagh," Entrapta said nervously, "I can't get a steady hold on Angella."

"Do we have a chance?" Hordak asked, looking at her intently.

Entrapta bit her lip and paused a moment before looking up at him. "If you see her, go," she said helplessly, and Catra could tell she was forcing herself to say words she did not want to. He nodded at her and she returned her eyes to her tech.

"I don't see anything," Catra said as the noise of the Portal grew and began to make it difficult to hear her voice. All that appeared in the portal was glitchy fizzling and swirling mist. Finally, it glitched to a scene in which a few dark shapes showed through the mist.



“I’m getting there,” Entrapta said in a strained voice, “but it’s not steady. As soon as you have a chance, you’re going to have to take it.”

He and Catra approached the portal until they were only a few feet away from the snapping arcs of electricity that radiated from it as it glitched and crackled. They sank slightly, bending their knees, ready to jump at any second. Hordak clutched their supplies with a tighter hold under both his arms and stopped breathing.

“Now!” Hordak and Catra shouted in unison when, finally, they saw a scene materialize before them that included a floor and wall. They both leapt forward into the unknown, just as the portal began to snap louder and glitch faster. In a fraction of a second, they were both gone.

“They’re through!” Bow shouted above the racket.

Entrapta nodded and started typing madly, but the activity from the portal didn’t quiet. Instead, the noise and lights intensified,

creating an ominous rumbling that seemed to reverberate throughout the ship.

“Entrapta?” Adora shouted warily before transforming into She-Ra. “Do I need to stop this thing?”

“Aaaagh,” Entrapta warbled, typing frantically and glancing up from her work in uncertainty.

Lines of light seemed to follow fracture lines in the floor and walls and equipment around the portal and She-Ra realized that the fabric of space-time was now involved.

“It’s no good, stop it now!” Entrapta shouted, but She-Ra was already moving forward.

She gave a shout as she leapt into the air, raising her sword high above her head. She brought it down through the center of the portal machine and shut her eyes against the explosion she created. After a few seconds of ringing silence and the occasional fritz of sparks, she opened her eyes and looked at the damage she’d created around herself, which was quite thorough.

“Fuck,” she and Entrapta swore at the same time.

“Fuck,” Bow muttered.

Chapter End Notes

> If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you’ve got. It is very much appreciated.

“Don’t let the evil you’ve done spoil the good you’ve yet to do.”

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Hordak find themselves stranded on their mission to retrieve Angella

Chapter Notes

> Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization and post-war angle. So uh, expect the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you’re dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anyone for anything.

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Catra and Hordak both landed on their feet, though Catra was infinitely more graceful. She caught his arm as he stumbled and they looked around themselves wildly. Flashes of light, noise, and electricity went off around them a few more times, marking the attempted manifestations of Entrapta’s portal. Then silence fell, and after the sounds of their shouting friends and the portal, it was eerily still. Nothing moved in the dim light around them other than the swirling purple mists.

“Where the hell are we?” Catra asked.

Hordak ignored her and set the supplies down, squinting around them with a furrowed brow. There was an elegant design on the floor beneath them, and sections of wall rose around them in a circle, something like the petals of a flower, rising upward and tapering off.

“Uh,” Catra said. He glanced over to see her looking and pointing straight upward.

He looked up and started. The source of light where they were seemed to be innumerable shining fragments of Bright Moon's runestone, clustered together in a loose group and glowing brightly. Between the stone fragments and themselves, however, floated a motionless figure with long hair that seemed to float about her head and shoulders.

He immediately crouched next to the portable stabilizer and set to work, flipping switches, pressing buttons, and typing into his data pad.

"Angella!" Catra cried.

Tense minutes crawled by as Hordak worked and Catra paced, tail swishing in agitation. "Is anything happening?" he finally asked, not bothering to look up.

"I… I think so," she said uncertainly. "I think she's starting to get closer."

Hordak pulled his helmet off and took a deep breath as he looked up at Catra, then Angella. "You should be safe to breathe here, just like Etheria."

Catra pulled her helmet off and threw it aside, growling in frustration as she waited for Angella. When the woman drifted into reach, Catra reached up to catch Angella by her neck and waist, absorbing her weight. The fragments of the moonstone slowly lowered with Angella, casting them in brighter light as they did until they stopped and flattened out into a vague half dome above them. Catra lowered herself and Angella to the floor, supporting her head and placing a hand over her chest, feeling for a heartbeat.



“Do you need help?” Hordak asked, working on the stabilizer and hoping she didn’t.

“I don’t know. She’s warm and her heart is beating, but she’s not waking up.

“The lighter purple bag is a medical kit. Focus on her vitals like you learned as a junior cadet.”

“Really wishing I’d paid more attention in that class right now,” Catra muttered as she dragged the bag to Angella’s side and started rifling through it.

“I’m here if you need,” he said, trying to sound reassuring but wishing he’d paid more attention as well. He’d brushed up on Etherian emergency medicine when he’d realized how accident-prone Entrapta was, but he hadn’t bothered researching beyond what he considered likely to occur in lab accidents.

Time continued to drag in silence as the various sensors and meters before Hordak slowly stabilized. After a while, he heard Angella’s, sleepy voice. “Uhn?... Where am I?”

“You’re alright, your highness, or majesty, or whatever. We’re here to help,” Catra said.

“Who are… wait… you’re…”

“Hello,” the younger woman replied with a relieved chuckle, “Catra here. And I think you know that guy.”

Angella remained silent until Hordak looked up at her. “Lord Hordak,” she said in a low, fierce voice from where she was laying in front of Catra, arm held protectively over the younger woman’s lap.

“Just Hordak,” he corrected drily, and returned his gaze to his datapad.

“He’s changed a lot since you two last talked,” Catra said.

“Didn’t your hair used to be longer?” Angella asked.

“A lot has changed, actually.” Hordak looked up to see her rub the back of her neck. “Maybe I should fill you in.” She made a begrudging face at Hordak, who didn’t know how to react and instead pretended to work on the stabilizer. His heart sank in mild, resigned dread as Catra thought about where to start. Theirs was not a story he liked to hear. “What, uh… what do last remember?”

"I've overheard Adora talking about you, and I've seen you leading enemy troops at Bright Moon," Angella replied warily. "I remember that the horde set off some sort of doomsday weapon that was destroying the fabric of the universe, and I remember saying goodbye to Adora before I removed the sword from the portal so that she didn't have to." He could tell she was fighting back tears by the thickness in her voice. "I remember saying goodbye to my husband, who didn't know he was dead." Hordak's ears lowered in shame. "I remember wishing I could say goodbye to my daughter, or merely see her one last time." Her voice finally broke and a small suppressed sob escaped her.

"Ah, so… hmm," Catra began awkwardly.

"Why did you do it?" Angella asked, voice quavering, "what did we *ever do* to deserve it?"

Hordak turned his head to see Angella looking back and forth between Catra and Himself. "Whoooh," Catra exhaled, "that's a long story."

"Start with the beginning, she'll want to know everything," he said, thinking of his own faux trial.

Catra heaved a huge sigh. "Yeah, yeah I probably should. And… really, Hordak? You've got super-strength but you couldn't bring a camp chair?"

He ignored her as she covered Angella with a blanket and put the bag of medical supplies behind her to lean against. "Alright, so Adora and I grew up together. In the Fright Zone." Hordak pinched the bridge of his nose and tapped randomly at his keyboard with his other hand, pretending to type.

"And you were close?" Angella prompted. "I think I remember her saying…"

"Yeah," Catra sighed. "You could say that." He glanced up at her and caught her eye, confirming that they were both thinking the same thing; they were all in for a long, painfully awkward wait.

* * * * *

A shorter time later than he'd expected, but longer than he'd hoped, Catra had finally explained her way to the day of the portal incident. Hordak had grown more and more agitated as she went, his scowl more and more pronounced. Perhaps it was Angella's loving attitude, or maybe the highly liminal atmosphere of the place, but Catra was now in deep, trying to explain her actions. "I just… I just didn't want it all to go her way again. She was the golden girl, the chosen one for all those years, and despite what *every single fucking person* said, I had clawed my way up to the top." She gulped. "And there she was yet again, and it was all about her yet again. I didn't want her to be right. I didn't want to *fail again*. I just…" he heard Catra struggle with a lump in her throat. "I just couldn't handle the idea of Adora getting rewarded, as ever, for getting everything she ever wanted and leaving me with nothing. So… so I decided to leave everyone with nothing. Scrap the whole stupid mess."

"Catra," Angella said softly. Hordak cringed on Catra's behalf.

"Uh-uh, no. No excuses," Catra, insisted. 'I didn't just ignore Adora. Entrapta could tell it was bad, too. She tried to warn me, but I…" Hordak held his breath and shut his eyes tight, clenching both his fists.

"You're so young. It wasn't your mess to drown in." Angella said. Hordak could feel her glaring at him.

"I made my choices," she grumbled.

"You ignored a scientist to complete your mission," Angella assured gently, "It certainly wouldn't be the first time that's happened. What then?"

Catra drew a shaky breath. "That's not all I did to her."

Hordak stood up suddenly and walked away from them, trying to put as much distance between himself and the other two as possible. He wanted to clamp his hands down over his ears, but instead he leaned against a decorative petal, trying to distract himself with anything.

He couldn't.

Back then, he'd been waiting for the other shoe to drop, for impossible hope to turn to ashes, for Prime to be proven right. So when Catra had confirmed his fears, he'd believed her instead of trusting Entrapta. He'd let her go through untold misery, and then… when he thought he'd let her die... He bowed his head and clenched his fists, his breathing shallow beneath the weight of all that had happened thereafter. All he could think about was how he'd let it all happen instead of using his damned brain. He hunched his shoulders and clenched the fist at his side so hard it began to shake slightly.

"Hordak?" Catra called. He raised his head and turned it to the side slightly. "I'm going to need you to calm down, big guy. You're making Angela nervous," she said. He turned to see that Angella had replaced the protective arm over Catra's lap and she was watching him warily. Catra addressed her in a calm voice. "Chill, queenie. I outrank him now. I can also kick his ass if that makes you feel better."

"Apologies," he mumbled with an awkward nod before turning back around and straightening his posture, clasping his hands behind the small of his back and lifting his chin.

"Don't worry about him," Catra said, "He's fine, it's just… the day of the portal incident was not a good day. Not for anybody." He shut his eyes tight and bowed his head.

He would never be able to make it right with Entrapta, could never apologize enough for how badly he failed her that day. Not just her, but her home as well. Not that he'd cared for it as such. He and Catra had come so close to ending it all before Prime even

showed up. “Catra,” Hordak said in a strained voice before he knew how to continue. “You need to stop talking as if it was only you who did it.”

“Shut the fuck up, Hordak,” Catra said without patience. He heard Angella gasp.

He gripped the section of wall he was leaning against. “You were a teenager,” he said, repeating Castaspella’s argument.

“Uh, okay, Mr. fucking Responsibility. I think I remember you saying something about six months old and…”

“And your friends decided that my culpability during that period of my life had more to do with Horde Prime than personal malice, did they not?” He asked in a cool tone.

“Well, yeah,” she said.

“Then I am to you what Prime was to me,” he explained wearily, replacing his hand on the decorative petal beside him.

“Prime?” Angella’s voice asked, “What’s Prime?”

He heard Catra shudder while making a disgusted sound. “Prime,” she began, “was Hordak’s older brother.”

He dug his claws into the pristine white finish on the wall as Queen Angella reacted. “ *His what?!”*

“Yeah, I know. But Hordak actually turned out to kind of be a ‘best-case-scenario’ type situation, all things considered.”

“Catra,” he growled in warning.

“You never got to meet Hordak’s big brother, but trust me,” she chuckled darkly, “you should be very, very glad we got Hordak instead.”

“That’s enough!” he nearly shouted, before flinching away from the harshness of his own voice and staring determinedly into the mist.

“What?” she asked, sounding genuinely confused. “I haven’t even gotten to the bad stuff yet, why are you freaking out?”

He spun on his heel and bared his fangs, trying and failing to keep his temper in check as he hunched his shoulders and clenched his fists. “When you got me, you *did* get Prime. Everything I was, he made me.”

Catra blinked at him, unfazed. “Hordak, I don’t know what to tell you, but I don’t think you picked up what he was laying down quite as well as you think you did.” He growled and turned away again, digging his claws into the shining finish on the wall. “I know you don’t think you’re a whole person or whatever, but you are *not* the same as he was.” He shook his head roughly, trying to banish the memories that were crowding down on him. “You are better than Prime.”

“Enough!” he repeated, this time fully shouting. He accidentally pushed his hand through the petal-shaped wall it was braced against as his body tensed, and fought to control his breathing while the section of wall above the break teetered and fell away.

“Nope,” Catra said simply, as un-ruffled as ever. “You don’t tell me what to do any more. Those days are over .”

He turned to face her, teeth bared in a snarl. He felt a twinge of regret at the alarm and concern all over Angella’s face, but was far too agitated to do anything about it. “Are you just stupid? Or are you blind, as well?” He hadn’t planned the cruel words, but he meant them all the same.

“Neither, last I checked,” she drawled in a bored tone worthy of Princess Mermista. “That’s just facts.” Catra crossed her feet, leaning back against a wall and regarding him with a cool smirk. “You, Hordak, are better than Prime. And yes, I’ve thought about

it. I've been angry enough to think about it a lot, actually. And stop scowling! Shadow Weaver always said your face would get stuck like that if you scowl too much."

He ignored her words and crossed his arms, frowning harder as Angella spoke up. "I don't understand, Hordak has a brother?"

"You could call him that, yeah," Catra answered, crossing her arms to match Hordak's defensive stance. "And I've never known Hordak to be as bad as him."

"Which is saying something," Angella muttered, raising a curious brow at Hordak, who was too pathetic to meet her gaze.

"You don't even know," Catra said before addressing Hordak again. "Compare how you handled Imp to how he handled you. Imp was a mistake, right?" Hordak didn't answer, but she was undaunted. "When Prime realized there was something wrong with you, he sent you to die and expected you to thank him for it. When you got Imp, you made him a matching outfit and tiny little soldier boots."

"Imp?" Angella asked.

"Yeah he's this horrible little bat baby thing that hangs out on the ceiling. He's the worst, you'll hate him," Catra said dismissively.

"And consider the treatment that *you* received at my hands," he hissed. "I threw you away like nothing."

Catra ignored Angella's grumble. "Yeah and I *definitely* never lashed out at anybody for betraying me," she said sarcastically.

"That wasn't even the last time I tried to kill you," he argued.

"Do you even know how many times I've tried to kill Adora?" He ignored her again, frustration mounting.

"How often have you two tried to kill friends and coworkers?"

Catra and Hordak looked at each other. “It’s a Fright Zone thing. Attempted murder is how we show we care.”

“As in… *kill* kill?”

Catra snorted. “Oh man, correct me if I’m wrong here,” she said to Hordak, “but I have no doubt that if he’d actually gotten his hands on me after he found out what I did to Entrapta, he would have torn me limb from limb.”

“Like Imp with an insect,” he confirmed grimly.

“I thought Entrapta joined your side,” Angella said. “What did you do when she tried to stop you two from opening the portal? I expected she’d stay loyal to whoever had the most tech...” she trailed off, waiting for an explanation.

Catra hung her head in shame and Hordak looked away. “She did stay loyal, even more loyal to her friends than to tech. Showed us more grit than we ever gave her credit for, in the end. She tried to stop me from activating the portal, and I didn’t listen. She was going to tell Hordak and stop him so… I hurt her, instead of listening. I hurt her badly.” Her voice was small now, and Hordak clenched his teeth. She was taking too long to explain, and the memories he was drowning in were stoking the flames of old rage and grief that he’d thought he was mostly over.

“Catra,” Angella said again.

“That’s what she was doing, you know,” Catra said, and he could tell she was looking at him. “I failed her, so she went for you, because she knew you’d listen to her. She knew you wouldn’t do it if you knew what would happen.” Hordak looked up at her against his better judgment. She gave him a hauntingly sad smile. To his absolute horror, his eyes began to sting and he blushed. Worse, Angella had caught it before he looked away.

“I know,” Catra agreed breathily before rolling to lay on her back. Then she folded her arms behind her head and looked up at the

pieces of moonstone above them. “But this is him. This is the boogieman himself, in all his blushing glory.”

“I don’t understand… what happened?” Angela asked, and he could hear the smile in her voice.

“Holy hell, do I have a story for you,” Catra said, rolling onto her stomach and kicking her feet in the air, tail flicking with mischief.

“Catra,” he hissed in warning, “before we discuss past indiscretions, I will remind you that all of yours are on the table as well.”

“*Indiscretions* ?” she cried in glee, completely undaunted. He’d miscalculated again and had little choice but to sit and stare into nothing as she howled with laughter shamelessly. “I knew it! I knew you guys were getting freaky in the Fright Zone!”

“Catra!” he barked, but they both knew any further threats would be empty.

“Would someone please explain how we got here?” Angella demanded impatiently.

Hordak broke in before Catra could. “After Horde Prime was defeated, the Princess Alliance chose to show me mercy. I now live as a servant to Etheria,” he explained in his sternest voice.

“Wow, could you be any less juicy?” Catra asked with disdain.

“What I said was the truth.” Albeit a clinical rundown.

“Like the worst version of it ever,” said Catra. She rolled her eyes as she turned to the queen. “Lord Hordak, commander of the Etherian Horde and… what was it? Terror of all nations? Hordak fell in love, and you’ll never guess with who.”

“No. Never,” Angela gasped, holding eye contact with Catra.

“Want a hint? A tiny Etherian...”

Angela shot a look of growing horror his way. “Please don’t say...”

“Princess Entrapta.”

“Noo,” Angela breathed, visibly paling. “ *Oh no* . We abandoned her there and… and he…” she gave him a disgusted look before she turned back to Catra with an expression of desperation. “We thought she was dead, truly,” she insisted, seeming to beg Catra’s pardon. A thrill of agitation went through him at her words, though not because of her disgust, which he rather sympathized with. It was just… why did people have to keep bringing up that they’d thought Entrapta was dead?

“Woah, chill. Entrapta initiated. And insisted.” Catra said, putting her hands up and shooting an apologetic glance at an annoyed Hordak, who had tried to keep her from saying anything in the first place.

“I… what?” Angela asked in confusion.

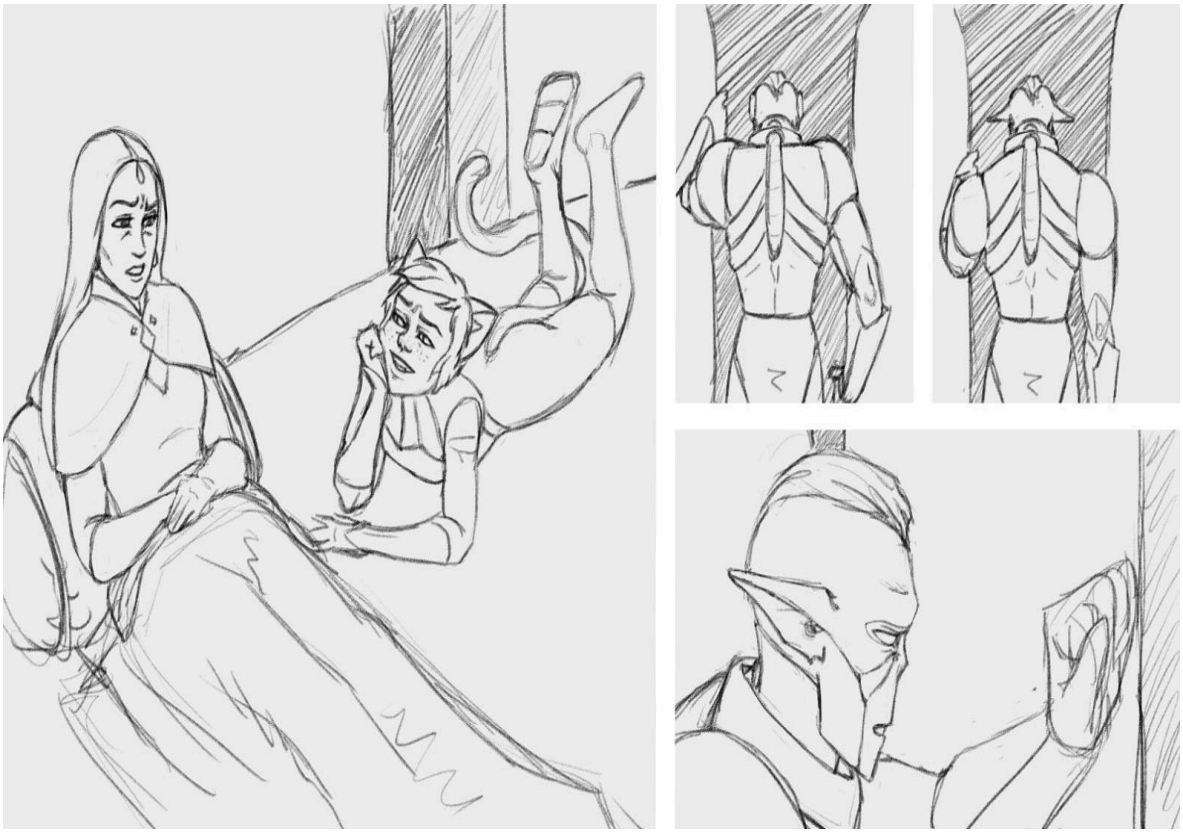
“I know,” Catra said and shrugged. “No accounting for taste.”

“I never imagined,” Angella said vacantly.

“I don’t even think he did. It took everybody off guard, honestly.”

“Wait… I’m so confused. What happened?” Angella asked.

He saw Catra’s ears flick before slowly lowering in shame again. “Yeah… yeah Entrapta was about to stop the portal thing like Adora wanted her to, and on top of that, the two of them were getting closer, like emotionally, and Entrapta was potentially weeks away from getting Hordak to give up the war, so I removed her from the situation. I…” she took a deep breath and he squeezed his eyes shut, “I sent her to Beast Island.” Crushing guilt flooded through him, and he felt like he couldn’t breath beneath it’s weight. He’d known better. He’d known that if he were careless in displaying his attachment it would make her a target. But he’d been arrogant, and stupid, and Entrapta had paid the price.



Shocked silence rang for several seconds. “Oh,” said Queen Angella in a strange voice.

Catra sniffed and said, “Awe fuck. I forgot about the Micah thing.” Hordak kept his eyes closed. “Fuck me, I’m sorry, I didn’t mean to make you cry.”

“No, no,” Angella said in a voice choked with tears. “It’s just… I used to fantasize that he’d one day go through what he put *me* through. But this... this is terrible. This feels *awful*. Oh I’m so sorry, Hordak.”

He snarled without meaning to. “Do *not* apologize to me.”

“I’m still sorry too,” Catra said, and he opened his eyes to glare at her.

“Do. Not. Apologize. To me. Again.,” he said in his deadliest whisper. “I may have never been a child, but even I am starting to realize what inculcation can do to a young mind. I had the power to keep Entrapta safe. I am the one that ultimately failed her.” He

took several deep breaths to calm himself and looked away to martial his voice. When he looked back at them, his tone was more even. "And if you remember correctly, you're not the only one who's destroyed everything around you in a suicidal breakdown. All things considered, I hardly have room to hold a grudge." He screwed up his face against the hollow feeling under his sternum.

"This is real guilt, isn't it?" Angella asked, and he finally met her teary eyes. "Underneath all that self-loathing, there's *actual remorse* ." Hordak and Catra looked at each other, both extremely uncomfortable with the grace they'd been given. "But all that guilt… it's not helping anyone, you know."

"What, Hordak?" Catra deflected. "This guy can work himself into a full-blown disorder in no time, flat. This guilt complex is only days old, if you can believe it."

"Would you say that your regrets are just days old, Catra?" Hordak asked quietly.

She didn't answer him and instead deflected again with "I should probably mention now that both Entrapta and your husband survived Beast Island and the war. They're safe and whole in Bright Moon right now."

* * * * *

Hours of discussion between Angella and Catra and a few naps later, there was still no sign of a way to get out of their temporary universe. All the while, Hordak had sat with his back against a wall or paced restlessly, arms crossed and head bowed as he

stared past his feet and thought. He listened as Catra showed Angella pictures that Bow had loaded onto a data pad. “That’s the day of Glimmer’s coronation, I guess. Holy shit, look at those ice statues.”

“Oh Glimmer,” Angella murmured in a tearful voice. “She looks so beautiful.”

“She does, doesn’t she?” Catra agreed thoughtfully. “Once she accepted the moonstone’s full power, she also got crazy strong. Plus, she’s also a skilled sorcerer now, too.”

“Just like her father,” Angella said, tone now full of pride.

“These pictures were a good idea. I’m going to have to thank Wrong Hordak- He wasn't supposed to know but he's got that crazy hearing and overheard Bow telling his dads. He said they might help with the shock of coming back to a different reality than you left.”

“Wrong Hordak?”

“Another one of Hordak’s brothers.”

“How many brothers does Hordak have?” Angella sounded concerned again.

Hordak didn’t want to think about it and hoped he could get away with stalling. Thankfully, Catra answered for him. “Honestly he might not even know. It’s a slave-clone-army type situation, so I’m guessing at least many thousands.”

“Hmm," Angella murmured in a high-pitched tone, "Are you sure this is real? This doesn’t feel real.”

“Oh yeah, all this crazy shit actually happened. It was insane. Oh! This picture looks like everybody at Bright Moon once they rescued Entrapta from Beast Island. That’s Scorpia, she defected and told them to go get Entrapta, that’s Emily, Entrapta’s pet robot, and that’s…”

“Micah…” Angella whispered. “Just look at you, my love. More beautiful than ever.” Hordak felt a chill down his spine as her words reminded him of Entrapta. “You know, Micah’s part magicat,” she told Catra.

“Very cool,” Catra replied slowly, and he could tell she was just as clueless as to what Angella was talking about as he was.

“Wait… Where’s Glimmer then? And Bow, Adora, and Entrapta?”

Catra hesitated and Hordak felt another, less pleasant chill steal through him. “Yeeaah. Um. About that. She tried to use the heart of Etheria as the weapon the First Ones meant it to be.”

“Oh dear,” Angella murmured.

“Yeah, it went as well as you’d expect. Anyway, before that picture was taken, she’d ended up in the Fright Zone and was in the wrong place at the wrong time when… when she, Hordak, and I got taken.”

“Taken?”

“To the Velvet Glove: Prime’s flagship.”

Catra barely skated over their time with Prime, and he knew that her vagueness had only concerned Angella rather than thrown her off. He was grateful, however, that she mentioned Prime as little as possible, preferring to refer to the horde and clones in general terms. She’d made it all the way to the time when, apparently, Adora had meant to sacrifice herself to save Etheria. The bitterness and pain in her voice was obvious and raw, and he wondered how he’d feel if Entrapta seemed as eager to die as Adora sometimes seemed. He hoped he’d not made her feel like Catra when he’d suggested his own execution to the alliance.

“Hordak, are you sleeping with your eyes open again?” Catra asked quietly, likely seeking an opportunity for uninterrupted gossip.

“He does that?” Angella asked in horror. “Oh that is… just so unsettling.” He couldn’t help a slow smirk spread across his face and caught Angella’s shudder in his periphery.

“Hordak,” Catra said in a shockingly indulgent tone, coming from her. “Do you like being creepy?”

He considered her question for a moment. “You know, I think I might?”

“Tough luck,” Catra said with mock sympathy. “Can’t scare folks like you used to,” she said smugly. He blinked his under-eyelids at her slowly and was satisfied to see her tail bush out.

“Catra,” Angella said softly, “tell me the rest of it. What happened?”

“Ugh,” she groaned. “Adora survived, no thanks to her, and we won, and now we’re here trying to rescue you.”

“Are you being a bit hard on her? On Adora?”

Catra groaned loudly. “Not you, too.”

“I just mean that she wasn’t leaving you, she was trying to leave for you. Do you understand?”

Realization dawned on Catra’s face and she smacked a palm to her forehead. “Shit. I’m sorry, I didn’t mean to say… I mean, nobody blames you. Glimmer doesn’t blame you for leaving instead of Adora. I don’t think.”

“Even if Glimmer does blame me, I don’t regret what I did. Granted, I assumed I’d simply die instead of being trapped alone in limbo for all eternity, but I’d still do it again. I would die for my daughter over and over if that’s what it took to keep her safe.”

“What you’re saying doesn’t make any sense,” Catra growled in frustration. “It’s the time you have together that matters, not how you throw it away.”

“Maybe you’ll understand when you’re older.”

“There’s nothing to understand! It’s just a matter of priorities!” Her tone was growing rougher and angrier.

“To die for love…” he began, hoping to avoid a shrill argument between an incurable mother and an angry young woman who’d never had one because of him. “The universe is a cold, cruel expanse where innocent beings die for no good reason all the time. To have a death so significant, to die for love- it is an honor and a privilege that few are lucky enough to be blessed with.” He decided to stop there and leave off the bit about how the sacrifice purifies a life lived in sin.

“What a lovely thing to say,” Angella said softly.

“That was depressing as shit,” Catra countered.

Hordak snorted. “Prime’s teachings,” he said by way of explanation.

“No. That wasn’t love.” Catra’s reply was immediate, firm, and her voice had ticked up a few notes. He met her eyes warily. “What he did to…” he noticed her chest rising and falling as her breath sped up as well, “that wasn’t love. Prime didn’t love anything.”

“You’re right,” Hordak sighed, closing his eyes and leaning his head against the wall. “My brothers never died for love. They died for absolutely nothing at all.” Heavy silence fell over them and Hordak listened the stabilizer as the minutes crawled on.

“This brother of his you keep mentioning- Horde Prime- he did something to both of you, didn’t he?” Angella’s words were soft but Catra and Hordak exchanged looks of panic. “What... what did he do?”

“Fuck! Can you cut it out with the mom thing for once?” Catra snapped. Angella looked slightly hurt, but not surprised.

“Did he do it to Glimmer?” Her fear was obvious.

Catra gave a frustrated sigh and ran a hand through her hair. “I… I think it was just mind games with her, but we’ve never talked about it. I think maybe… At some point I heard something about him showing her some of his ‘collections?’ Which…” Hordak's head snapped up to look at her and she trailed off. He felt his ears pin back against his head and looked away again quickly. Prime had been a man of fearsome appetites with unlimited time and resources. He desperately hoped Angella wouldn't ask about it.

At what must have been a questioning look from Angella, Catra explained quietly, "He kept Hordak close while he was taking Etheria."

Angella took a deep breath. “Whatever it was that he did to you… it clearly hurt you both terribly.” Catra made an angry noise. “But it’s obvious that you two have compassion for each other, at least in some measure.” Catra and Hordak exchanged scowls before looking back at Angella. “And you both have more compassion for your own victims than I ever imagined you could or would. I hope one day you’ll be able to extend that compassion to yourselves.” Hordak’s chest tightened and he noticed one of Catra’s hands twitch. “For your sakes, but also for the sakes of the people that love you.” He and Catra exchanged guilty expressions now. He knew full well, as Angella apparently did, that both of them were struggling in their new peacetime roles. “You’re good soldiers, but you’re also so much more.”

“You’re right, I’m a pretty great dancer,” Catra laughed nervously, trying to ease the somber feeling that had settled over them. “You, Hordak? I mean, you were a general, dictator and tyrant first, but you seem to be able to keep up with Entrapta in a lab, which is saying something.”

He snorted. “I always was better at reading than conquest,” he said in resignation.

“That’s not a bad thing,” Angella replied quickly. “Although, it seems to me that you were also quite the general.” He looked at her in confusion, feeling more and more unmoored in this ultra-

surreal situation. “You’re a dancer, and you’re loved by good friends and a wonderful woman,” she said to Catra before turning on Hordak. “You’re a scientist, you’re very loved as well, and you have to be at least a bit brilliant. On top of that, you’re both excellent soldiers, and you love hard. I think you’ve got a great start on making good from bad.” She gave them both warm smiles.

When he and Catra exchanged skeptical looks, she put on a stern expression and spoke again. “Don’t let the evil you’ve done spoil the good you’ve yet to do.” She furrowed her brow. “Remember, you two have other people than yourselves to be well for these days.” They all exchanged looks for a beat before looking away again. “You know,” Angella continued in a quieter voice, “the last thing I said- my final request- I asked Adora that they take care of each other. That was my last wish. I think, all things considered, that sentiment now includes you two.”

They both scowled at each other before Catra changed the subject. “By the way, Shadow Weaver’s dead.”

“Oh,” Angella said, somewhat taken-aback.

“Believe it or not, she self-immolated so that Adora could save Etheria. It was definitely the coolest thing she ever did. Probably the only selfless thing she ever did. Although she did still manage to manipulate us one last time to make us go, of course. True to herself until the end, fuckin’ bitch.”

“She caused so much hurt, in her time, didn’t she?” Angella muttered thoughtfully.

Hordak sighed and volunteered information freely for the first time since arriving. “I think, perhaps, she had love for Micah. At least, before she became what she did. She begged for his life when I sent him to Beast Island. I don’t think she ever forgave me for that.”

Angella tilted her head and squinted at Hordak's leg. He checked to see if anything was there as she continued in her soft, thoughtful tone. "It's interesting, you know, how she… how she…" she barely finished her sentence as her voice faltered. She grunted faintly, pressing a hand to her head.

Catra frowned in concern and put a hand on Angella's shoulder, but a beeping sound brought Hordak's head snapping around to the equipment beside them. "Is it them?" Catra asked, leaning forward.

"I'm not sure yet," Hordak said, typing and looking around them at the same time. Electrical charges seemed to be fizzling in and out of existence all around them and Queen Angella suddenly groaned and passed out again.

"What's wrong?" Catra asked, hovering over her in an instant.

"The field around us is destabilizing again, it's her magic that's keeping us alive right now. It's draining her." Catra felt her ears lower and she clutched Angella a little tighter. Hordak did *not* look confident.

Chapter End Notes

> If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you've got. It is very much appreciated.

“did you guys get a freaking baby?!?”

Chapter Summary

> Kyle, Lonnie, Rogelio, and Imp await the returning rescue party. The gang learns the fate of the Etherian Horde.

Chapter Notes

> Heyyy, sorry about the whole organization thing. Two people have asked me to undo it, so that's the reason for all the mess. Sorry, sorry, don't mind me, still new here, sorry.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

“The field around us is destabilizing again, it’s her magic that’s keeping us alive right now. It’s draining her.”

The communicator crackled to life. “…dak?... Hordak are…. there?” It was Entrapta’s voice, and relief flooded him. They’d be fine.

“I’m here, but I can barely hear you.”

Her voice was high and frightened. “…not much time… any chance you have… you’ll have to…”

“We’ll be back through as soon as we can.”

He was up and approaching the other two as Entrapta continued. “… but you… have long… steady fix…”

Catra had one hand on Angella’s chest and the other on her forehead. Hordak heard an electrical pulse materialize above them that lasted longer than usual. A portal began to open, flickering and crackling menacingly. But then it widened, and he saw a glimpse of She-Ra’s glow, and a flash of lilac hair. “Apologies, Catra,” he muttered, making a snap decision. He reached down and grabbed her by the spacesuit above her tail and shoulders,

then bodily threw her upward through the portal before she could do anything about it. He heard it shut as he bent and gathered up the unconscious Angella, keeping her body folded close with one arm and holding her neck stiff with his free hand so her head wouldn't whip about when he took his chance. He heard a promising fizzle behind him and ran to see another Portal materializing below and away from the platform.

"Shit." He wasn't sure he would be able to make that jump. He was not a jumper. Clones were *not* jumpers. He backed up a few steps and hesitated, securing his hold on Angella and trying to stay confident.

Familiar faces appeared in the portal. "Hordak now!" Entrapta called out. He ran and leapt, and as he gazed at his targeted goal he saw Entrapta, Bow, Catra, and Glimmer all reaching out toward him.

His trajectory was iffy and he felt like he was starting to fall too soon. There was nothing to be done. Hordak couldn't help but close his eyes as he began to fall faster, and just when he held Angella forward in the desperate hope they might be able to reach her, he felt a thick rope of hair wrap around his waist and jerk him forward. He gripped Angella while other hands gripped him, and he tumbled in a new direction as gravity lurched sideways.

When he opened his eyes again, still clutching Angella's limp form, he saw that he was in a pile of all the people he'd seen reach for him, and She-Ra was again destroying the dangerous portal. He rolled over, laid Angella out on the ground and moved away as Bow rushed to her side. She was pale and small and utterly still as he checked her pulse.

After a few moments, he heard a small voice from behind him. "Mom?"

"Glimmer?" Angella muttered, stirring slightly. Hordak breathed a sigh of relief and leaned back.

“Mom!” Glimmer sobbed, rushing to her mother and taking her into her arms.

“Hello, sweetheart.”

“Mom, I missed you so much!” Glimmer wailed in a thick, blurred voice. Che to cried openly, running her hands over her mother, checking for damage.

“Angie?” Hordak looked around and saw Micah just a few feet away, tears streaming down his face as well.

“Micah?” she asked, finally setting eyes on him.

The king rushed to fall to the ground with his family, wrapping his arms around wife and child and weeping joyously. Hordak turned away from the intimate scene, walked past a tearful Adora and Bow, and reached Entrapta, who was waiting for him.

He smiled at her tired face and she threw herself into his arms. “That was awful! I kept saying I probably had the situation under control but it was absolutely *not* under control. Oh my gosh we got so lucky, you three were so close to being dead.” He could hear the shaking in her voice now. “You were in there for so long, and I kept having so much trouble with the stupid math!”

“I was never worried. I knew you could do it,” he said, trying to be sensitive through his smug pride.

Entrapta lifted herself to wrap around his torso, settling in to cling there. He held her close and stroked her back, burying his face in her hair and listening to the others.

“I’m so sorry I had to leave you, Glimmer. I’m so very sorry,” Angella repeated again and again.

“It’s okay, Mom. I was so proud of you,” Glimmer murmured against her father's close embrace.

“And Micah, my sweet, brilliant Micah. I was so lost without you. Losing you broke me for so long,” she said in a trembling voice.

“It’s okay, sweetheart. I missed you too. I never stopped looking for a way back, I promise.”

“You’re back. You’re both back,” Glimmer mumbled.

Hordak turned around and looked up over Entrapta’s head to survey the emotional scene. Bow was standing back from the three people on the floor, wiping his eyes and grinning. Catra had attached herself to Adora in much the same way Entrapta had attached herself to him. After a few minutes of sniffling and murmuring, Entrapta loosened her grip on Hordak and lowered herself to the ground, turning around so that she could watch as well.

Angella began to look up and around herself at the smooth, sharp, white architecture around them. “Where are we?” she asked.

“The Velvet Glove," Glimmer answered, still crying, "This is Prime’s flagship. Did they tell you about him?”

In response, Angella clutched her closer and made a face, still looking around. Micah now mirrored her movements, tightening his own hold on the other two. Hordak felt Entrapta slip her hand into his and give it a gentle squeeze.

“Speaking of,” Catra said, hopping down off Adora, who was smiling vacantly. “What are we waiting for? Can we get out of here? This place gives me the creeps.”

The room murmured assent and Micah gathered Angella into his arms. Hordak picked up a few bags and crates as Glimmer made her first round of teleporting onto Darla.

“Entrapta?” Adora called as he checked for any remaining equipment or tools. Then there was a faint poof, then silence.

Hordak was somewhat surprised to find himself suddenly alone. He moved to follow the crowd, but paused. He didn't want to make them wait for him, but he couldn't keep from looking around himself at Prime's design and technology. He touched the port on the back of his neck beneath his armor and sighed.

He'd hoped, on some level, that helping retrieve Angella might ameliorate some of the crushing guilt that was still building inside him. But it didn't. He only felt more guilt for having seen the families' happiness, which he'd left in tatters for so many years. He swallowed a lump in his throat as he touched the horde insignia on his chest. There was no escaping it, he really was Prime's creation, through and through.

"Hey." Hordak jumped and spun around to see a tearful Glimmer smiling up at him. She'd materialized without his notice. "It's okay. You're with us now." She donned a watery grin. "So let's go home."

* * * * *

"Hey, Entrapta," Catra sighed as the lavender haired-princess approached them, more subdued than usual. Bow watched Angella and Micah holding each other on the floor as Entrapta readied Darla for take-off.

"Is everyone ready to go home?" Entrapta asked, and Catra finally saw how exhausted she looked.

"So ready," Bow agreed. He sounded tired, too.

"Entrapta, I just wanted to say you did great, and thank you," Adora said, placing her hand on the princess' shoulder briefly. "I

know you're tired, but you were amazing in there."

"Thanks, Adora!" she answered in a bright, nasally tone as Glimmer appeared with Hordak and the rest of their gear.

"Yes, thank you. Thank you so much, for everything," Micah said from his place on the floor with Angella in his arms, voice brittle but brimming with unbelieving joy. Catra looked over at Adora, who's eyes were overbright.

"Awe, don't mention it!" Entrapta said, turning around fully to look at the happy scene again.

"And you too, Hordak. Thank you," Micah said, looking over at the lowering figure on the edge of the room. Hordak nodded curtly, then cleared his throat and looked away.

As they shuttled back to Bright Moon, Adora explained that the commotion they'd created with the first Portal they'd opened to get to Angella had been impossible to explain away, and they'd had to let Glimmer and Micah in on the mission. Melog rubbed their face and side insistently against Catra, monopolizing most of her attention as Hordak watched them curiously.

Glimmer was too excited to wait for Darla to land, and instead teleported her parents and herself directly to the Moonstone from high above the palace.

"Uh," Bow said, rubbing the back of his head. "Thanks guys, for do…" Glimmer reappeared, grabbed him roughly, beamed at everybody else, then disappeared again.

After Darla landed, Adora, Melog, and Catra led the way out. She heard Hordak and Entrapta talking quietly behind them as they all exited the ship, before Hordak's voice rose in alarm. "Nearly twelve hours? Entrapta, how long has it been since you slept?" Entrapta made a high-pitched noise as she considered and he seemed to stop them in their tracks to do whatever obnoxious scolding, but the other three continued.

As they walked down the ramp, Melog was still next to her, rubbing and meowing. Catra sensed people off to their side and felt her hair raise. She froze and Melog flashed red, growling. Adora heard her stop and turned so that they were both staring at Castaspella, Scorpia, Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio. Then she noticed that Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio all sported fresh, minor injuries, as if they'd been in a fight. She opened her mouth to ask about it, and the entire group save Castaspella reacted instantly, silently hushing her with nothing short of frenzied desperation. Only then did she notice that Castaspella was straining to get a look at a suspiciously sized and shaped bundle in Kyle's arms.

Adora started forward and Catra followed as Adora asked in a stressed, high-pitched whisper; "did you guys get a freaking *baby* ?"

Before anybody could answer, however, they all turned at the sound of feet on the ramp. Hordak and Entrapta were descending side by side, Entrapta droning on about something science-related and rubbing her eyes while Hordak looked down at her with a stern expression.

Entrapta stumbled on the ramp and Hordak only just managed to catch her by the clothing at the scruff of her neck. "Come here," he murmured, lifting her up against himself and cradling her with one arm, fixing her hair with the other so it didn't get snagged on his suit. Before he continued down the ramp, however, he froze. Catra saw his ear turn before he spun to face them, bending his knees, ready to run. When he realized who he was looking at, he assumed his usual posture and scowled at them before he finished his descent. He approached them with narrowed eyes and did not change his one-armed hold on Entrapta, who seemed comfortable as could be reclining in his arms… arm. She smiled and waved cheerily as Hordak clenched his free hand, which had become a fist. "Is that Imp?" Hordak asked, sounding oddly tense.

Before anything else happened, an ear-splitting, extended shriek rent the air and what looked like a leathery little cannonball flew

at Hordak, slamming into his chest at sufficient velocity to send him staggering back a step.

"Hello, little one," he murmured into the top of Imp's head as the gremlin dug his claws into Hordak's dress. Entrapta made ridiculous noises as she joined in doting on the awful little monster.

"Waaagh! What is that thing?!" Castaspella was looking on with wide, horrified eyes. "Oh my… oh goodness… did you and Entrapta…" Castaspella's distress rose noticeably and Hordak stared at them in confusion.

"Create a forbidden love-child while waging war on the planet?" Catra asked, snickering again. "No, but I like your instinct for scandal."

"Absolutely not," Hordak said in a horrified voice. He looked utterly appalled at the very thought. Too appalled, apparently, to notice as Imp looked around at Catra's voice, locked eyes on her, hissed, and launched himself at her face.

"Imp, no!" Lonnie, Kyle, and Hordak all shouted in unison.

Hordak barely managed to hook his claws into the straps between Imp's wings before he hit Catra, teeth bared and claws out. It was still lucky she had the reflexes to dodge back in time to keep both eyes. Hordak held Imp out from himself as the creature struggled wildly, shaking his tiny fists and screeching at her viciously. Melog had enlarged and was bristling red.

"Woah," Lonnie said, glancing over at a wide-eyed Scorpia, "I've never seen him like that." She looked at Rogelio and Kyle, who was folding the heavily worn blanket he'd been carrying Imp in.



“I know about Entrapta,” Imp replayed Hordak’s voice, confronting Catra on that terrible day. Hordak shut his eyes and scowled, and Catra saw him clutch Entrapta a little tighter. The three soldiers from her old squad exchanged glances, before they all gave Catra looks of growing disgust. “Hey there, little guy… you okay? Do you know what happened here? What’s that you’ve got there?” Imp continued in Kyle’s voice, little yellow eyes filling with tears. He kept his mouth open and next it was Lonnie’s words. “Oh man, those are pieces of Hordak’s armor. He really is gone.” Imp chittered angrily at Catra and reached for Hordak and Entrapta again. Hordak set the gremlin on Entrapta and he clung to her, making her wince slightly as he dug his claws into her clothes.

The ex-Horde Lord continued scratching Imp's little tuft of hair lightly, and lifted his eyes back up to them. Now he looked defiant for some reason.

"Hey Imp," it was Catra. Hordak gripped him by his suspenders again to prevent further mishap but turned his torso so Catra could approach them. "I know I did a lot of bad stuff, and I know I hurt the people you love, and I'm very, very sorry." Imp blew a raspberry at her and turned his face away, but Catra figured it was the best she could expect. Her face grew more somber, however, as she turned back toward Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio. She reached her hand out as subtly as possible to take hold of Adora's before continuing. "I did a lot of bad things to you, too. I'm sorry for what I put you through." The three stared back in open shock before she lowered her gaze to stare at the ground between them. "You were my friends, and it's shitty that I never realized how lucky that made me." It was one thing to apologize to Hordak, it had almost felt like an act of charity. But she was too weak to meet the eyes of the soldiers she had abused, whom she respected more than the former warlord.

The other three soldiers didn't seem inclined to reply, and Hordak stepped closer to stand next to Catra, who was surprised that he came so near. "You have my eternal gratitude. Anything I can ever do for you, anything you ever need, please do not hesitate to come to me." The other three soldiers shrank away from him slightly, but nodded. She and Adora exchanged shocked looks.

Scorpia made another high-pitched noise and wrapped all five of the young people in another hug. "Awwwe *guys*, look at us! Learning about friendship," she said in a warm, gushing voice.

Catra allowed the hug for a few seconds before squirming as a signal for Scorpia to let go. Imp chittered contentedly; a sound she'd never heard him make before. She watched Hordak scratch behind his ear before Imp smiled and chirped again. Then he turned around to affectionately gnaw on Hordak's fingers with pointed teeth.

Lonnie cleared her throat to speak as soon as she'd caught her breath from Scorpia's hug. "We're here to take you guys to your new lab." She looked at a point somewhere to Hordak's left. "Scorpia helped us move all of Entrapta's crap for her." Catra couldn't help but smile.

"Really? You guys are the best," Entrapta said sleepily.

"I'm just here to supervise," Castaspella said before clearing her throat and folding her hands in front of her."

"Come on, lovebirds," Catra said, starting the trek to the mountain cavern.

As they walked, Scorpia and Lonnie explained that the Crimson Waste was dangerous when they got there, but the added terror and chaos Prime created was still in full swing as they left. They insisted that they didn't regret taking him in, but by the sounds of it, Imp kept them in constant trouble. Kyle hadn't done well in the harsh climate, and they'd had to fight their way through a fair few people to get back the skiff they'd stolen in the Fright Zone. "Although, I will say Imp is pretty handy in a scrap. It's tough to keep your hands on him," Lonnie said, giving the tiny monster an affectionate smile.

Hordak walked next to Castaspella on the trail, and she seemed to gradually grow more comfortable with his presence as they went. Eventually, Catra was surprised to notice that Hordak kept sneaking sidelong glances at her for some reason. The curious behavior continued until Castaspella caught him looking at her and scowled.

"What?" she asked somewhat aggressively before reeling herself back a bit. "What are you looking at?" she asked in a quieter voice.

He turned away from her and looked straight ahead, coolly. "I like your outfit," he growled solemnly.

She did a double-take and gaped at him as Catra stuffed her fist into her mouth to keep from making sound while she suppressed her laughter. “Uh, th-thank you,” Castaspella stammered eventually.

The cavern wasn’t far from the main palace compound and Catra noticed that the trail up the slope had recently been rejuvenated. Castaspella dropped them off at a fancy entryway carved into a cliff face and the ex-horde soldiers exchanged raised eyebrows at the level of ornate decoration that these abandoned barracks sported. Inside, the walls were rough-hewn stone but the ceilings were lofty, delicate glowing crystals hung above them, and fully functioning doors had been set into the stone walls between different chambers. It was far more aesthetically charming than anything in the Fright Zone had ever been.

“This way,” Kyle said cheerfully.

Adora piped up from Catra’s side. “We’re setting up some barracks for ex-horde refugees over that way, but we put all your lab stuff through here. The walls are thicker, which, considering the explosions that often happen around Entrapta, seemed like the best option.”

“We didn’t try to set anything up, but we got it all from point A to point B,” Lonnie elaborated, and Catra noticed a strange change in her tone, and looked to see that she had pointed her face to the ground and away. They entered a large space that was crowded with the machines and boxes that had packed Entrapta’s tent and the ground around it. “And that door leads to what I think used to be an office, but we put her bed in there…. Is she already asleep?”

Hordak looked down at Entrapta and nodded as she drooled and snored softly, her head resting against him. He carried her and Imp through to the room they’d pointed out, and after a moment’s consideration, Catra followed out of curiosity, jerking her head for Adora to follow. Soon every other person in the cavern was peeking around the doorframe, watching him put her

down on the bare camp mattress fully clothed and draping a blanket over her. Imp stayed in her arms and snuggled closer, and as Hordak reached for a pillow to tuck beneath her head, Kyle lost his balance and had to scrabble at the doorframe to regain it.

This finally bought them Hordak's notice, and he scowled for a few moments, but didn't say anything. He crouched once more and ran a giant hand over Imp's head before he stood, turned, and stalked toward them. Everybody but Catra scrambled out of the way before he closed the door gently behind him and led them back into the center of the new lab. "Why are you still here?" he asked in a frank tone.

"To watch that little display, for one," Catra sniggered as she sat on a box and Adora sat down behind her, wrapping her arms around Catra's middle and pulling her back to lean into her chest. She started purring and began to play with a lock of Adora's hair, which she'd let down on the ride back. The others all took hers and Adora's lead and chose seats as well while Hordak stood a yard or so away and Frowned at them.

Catra propped her feet up on Melog and was smirking at him. "See guys? What have I been telling you for years?" she asked the room. "And you said I was reaching."

"What we *said* was you were jumping to conclusions," Lonnie corrected before leaning back and folding her arms, aiming her own smirk at Hordak. "But I admit it, you were absolutely right. Lord Hordak is thoroughly whipped."

"I bet you're ready for a good night's sleep," Catra said, struggling to make small-talk.

"Oh yeah. And Bright Moon is so fancy! You gotta see the bunks they set up for us on your way out," Kyle said, excitement trickling into his tone.

"I keep forgetting that Ex-horde are going to live here too," Adora said. "That's a lot of people for this space."

“Don’t worry, I’m sure stone walls are about as soundproof as it gets.” Catra waggled her eyebrows and Hordak scowled at her. She sensed the mood of the three cadets across from her change drastically. She looked up and saw that their eyes had gone hollow and none of them were touching each other, but had closed in upon themselves. Kyle's eyes filled with tears. “What?” Catra asked. “What did I say?”

Rogelio roared mournfully before Lonnie spoke again, voice saturated with bitterness. “It wasn’t what you said. It was what Adora said.” She looked up to make brief eye-contact with Catra, who imagined there was accusation in her gaze. “I’m surprised you didn’t realize." The three exchanged looks that filled Catra with dread. "The day Prime came, nearly the entire horde was making your big, final push, remember? The thing is, they were all ambushed by princesses who got giant power-boosts when the rebellion used their ancient superweapon.” Catra suddenly felt like she couldn’t breathe, and the sinking feeling in her chest and stomach was so bad that she had to struggle to keep from shaking. She pulled away from Adora’s arms and felt the other woman put her hands to her own mouth. Lonnie went on, “It’s not like they had much of a chance, you know? But it took a while to realize how bad it was. We kept waiting for the new wave of ex-soldiers to hit the Crimson Waste.” She scoffed. “We were even hoping they might help stabilize things out there. But the wave never came." Catra dug her claws into the crate beneath her. "We don't know how bad it actually is, but we figure a lot of the Etherian horde was gone before the clones even took over.”

Chapter End Notes

If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you’ve got. It is very much appreciated.

"Etheria has become intimately acquainted with the consequences of usury and violence."

Chapter Summary

Hordak and Catra face the mourners at Bright Moon.

Chapter Notes

Heyyy, sorry about the whole organization thing. Two people have asked me to undo it, so that's the reason for all the mess. Sorry, sorry, don't mind me, still new here, sorry.

Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization and post-war angle. So uh, expect the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you're dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anyone for anything.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The cavern chamber seemed to shrink in around them as Catra struggled to absorb what Lonnie had just told her. She'd been so focused on everything that happened afterward that she hadn't even thought about where the troops were. Her whole face began to spill from her eyes. She curled forward to grip her head between her hands and watched her tears fall to the floor, unblinking. In her periphery, she saw Hordak turn his back to them and put his own hands to his forehead, hunching forward slightly. She looked over at him as she heard Adora and Scorpia start sobbing quietly. She knew from their time with Queen Angella that Hordak had been thinking about his brothers that hadn't lived to see freedom, that he felt sorrow over it. But now, his soldiers… their soldiers… They'd been so close… so close. They hadn't deserved to live the lives they had, but it didn't matter.

Hordak was doing a good job of hiding it, but she caught the tremor in his shoulders and ears. For some reason it spurred her crying to grow worse, somehow magnified by the fact that they were both rocked by the same horror. “I’m so sorry,” she whispered, again unable to meet anyone's gaze. “I’m so fucking sorry.” The entire room dissolved into quiet grieving as Catra spiraled, breath and heart rate picking up fast. They’d all been within sight of an end. They’d nearly touched it . But she’d killed them. She and Hordak had killed them.

“I uh,” Lonnie said, standing. “Thank you for actually giving a shit. It’s nice to know you’re still capable of some sympathy… but I have to go,” she said before abruptly standing up and leaving the room.

The others all rose instinctively to leave. “Night guys,” Kyle said morosely as he and Rogelio followed Lonnie to their barracks.

Catra had to get away from Hordak. She needed air. She practically ran the way back through the cavern until she was just outside of the carved entrance. She couldn't think about what he was feeling, not now. She needed to get ahold of herself until she could get some privacy. She heard Scorpia and Adora exit behind her and felt a tentative touch on her shoulder. “Catra?” Adora asked quietly.

She simply shook her head in response and felt the contact disappear. Scorpia then stepped to Catra’s side and said, “I don’t blame you, Wildcat. It was the war.”

“I don’t know what to say,” whispered Adora.

“There’s nothing to say. It just is.” Catra’s tone was muted and flat as she struggled to catch her breath.

They returned to the palace and split off to their bedrooms in silence. As soon as the door closed behind Adora and Catra, she fell to her hands and knees and began to cry hard. Adora sank to her knees in front of her and gathered her into her arms, rocking

her and crying herself. Together they sobbed, loudly and messily, for several hours at least. Until both their faces were swollen and their eyes were bloodshot. A headache began to build between Catra's temples and she let it happen.



She was desperate to shut it out, desperate to avoid the magnitude of the realizations crashing upon her already unbearable guilt. But the heart-breaking, mind-numbing tragedy of what had happened to her fellow soldiers was inescapable. There was nothing for it, she just had to be in the nightmare.

She and Adora were only interrupted once by Glimmer and Bow, who had their own reactions of horror and despair before moving off to spread the word. Throughout the night, the sounds of muffled conversations and of doors opening and closing echoed in the halls outside their room. The noises petered out slowly with the passing hours, however. By the following morning, Bright Moon had fallen completely silent.

Adora and Catra woke with badly swollen eyes and foggy minds. Catra was immediately blinking away fresh tears and noticed

Adora do so soon after. As soon as Adora began to move around the room, Glimmer and Bow knocked and came in. “Hey guys. How you holding up?” Bow asked.

They didn’t answer and Glimmer gave him a gentle, incredulous look. “There’s going to be a memorial this afternoon. I… we think you should both come,” she said to the two women.

Catra shook her head. “I can’t,” she choked.

Adora came back to kneel next to her. “You can’t hide from the people you hurt, remember?”

Catra began sobbing again, quietly now.

“They were your troops, Catra,” Bow said, voice soft and slow. “Come to their memorial. You owe them that much.” After another moment of hesitation, she could only nod.

* * * * *

Catra couldn’t eat. Adora could, of course, but Catra spent the day in their bedroom or on their balcony, watching as Princesses and their entourages came trickling into Bright Moon, intermingled with straggling clones and Etherians, some of whom she recognized as ex-horde. As the day lengthened, Adora hustled in and out, telling her that the start of the memorial kept getting pushed back because people kept flooding into Bright Moon. Melog stayed with her, for which she was grateful. They mostly

napped, but every now and then would wander over to her and bump their nose against her.

Finally, after Adora had been gone again for hours and the sky outside began to grow dark, an exhausted-looking Glimmer appeared in their bedroom with Hordak, who looked nearly as bad as he had the day of the pan-Etherian meeting.

“Okay, we’re finally going to start. Hordak,” she said, holding up a black garment that she’d had slung over her arm, “My Aunt Castaspella and her sorcerer people made you this in case you wanted to do that whole old-fashioned, respecting death thing.” She picked the other one up and held it out toward Catra hesitantly. “And they made this in case you felt weird about Hordak getting one and not you.”

“I’ll take it,” Catra said, faintly. She’d take any chance to channel her contrition.

“Why did they do this for us?” Hordak asked in a tortured whisper.

“She noticed you’re really formal, and wanted you to have every opportunity to show respect,” Glimmer said with a sad smile.

Hordak only shook his head, as if he didn't believe her.

When they’d both taken their turn changing behind the bathtub curtain, Glimmer looked them up and down appreciatively. Catra had gotten a black body-suit type of something with a long black jacket. All very sorcerer-y and foreign to her. Hordak had gotten a high-collared robe/dress looking thing that resembled Castaspella’s robes and hung loosely on his frame. Only then did she notice he was without an external support system. “You’re not wearing armor,” she observed.

He shook his head. “It didn’t feel right to.”

“Ready?” Glimmer asked as Catra nodded in understanding. She placed a hand on each of their arms and without further ado, teleported them directly onto the main stage of the memorial.

Catra had expected that they'd teleport into an over-crowded throne room, but what she saw instead took her breath away. Glimmer had poofed them right into the middle of the other princesses on the top landing of the palace entrance stairway, with other important members of the rebellion arranged along the stairs and around them. Guards held a perimeter away from the steps, but the crowd… the crowd they faced was multitudinous. People of all kinds were packed in together in every direction around them, and the sea of faces stretched onto every open space within view until not an inch of ground was visible between them. Clones politely stood along buildings where they wouldn't block views, and she could see Etherians requesting their way onto clones' shoulders so that they could better see over the teeming masses. There must have been thousands.

"They're going to kill us," Hordak said flatly.

"Probably," she breathed in reply.

Glimmer stepped onto a platform with a podium on it that stood in the middle of the landing, and waited patiently while looking over what must have been a speech, written on the inside of what looked like a large candy bar wrapper. It took a while, but the crowd went silent sooner than Catra expected. Finally, the queen began to speak in a ringing voice that Catra was sure had been magically-magnified somehow. "I welcome you to Bright Moon today, so that we might help each other understand what has happened to us all, and help each other move forward." She paused for a moment and seemed to gather herself before continuing. "Since the fall of Prime, our days have been bittersweet. The things that we lost are gone forever, but we won in the end. We won, and I am so, so grateful. In this spirit of gratitude, I invite you all to rejoice with me for a moment, at the return of the Queen-mother Angella."

When Micah stepped through the entryway carrying Angella, the crowd slowly broke into shocked applause that grew more exuberant as people confirmed that they were seeing right. Soon people were shouting and whooping and some of the princesses

were hugging each other. Catra was shocked to see that neither the Moonstone nor She-Ra had rejuvenated Angella, and worried at the woman's sagging posture and lingering pallor.

Glimmer smiled out at the crowd as the applause slowly died, waiting for quiet before again continuing. "After years of separation by war, I am lucky to have both of my parents back with me. Far luckier than many Etherians, unfortunately." She sighed as she guided the crowd's mood back down. "Many of us that lost loved ones will never see them again. Their absence is a wound in the hearts of us all."

Glimmer waited again for the crowd to go silent, and again it didn't take long. "Now, I want to address the terrible tragedy that has come to the forefront of our attention." A strange kind of ripple swept the crowd and Catra shuddered. On the last day of the lesser war with the Etherian Horde, a massive battle took place and the rebellion won, though at a terrible cost." For a moment Catra was confused. She hadn't realized the rebellion had even suffered casualties when the princesses sprung their trap. Then she realized that Glimmer was counting the horde's losses as Etheria's losses, and she was suddenly choking on air again. "A large section of the Horde's forces perished in the fight, less than a year away from knowing freedom from Prime." Catra began to tear up and Glimmer turned her head to look squarely at them before turning back to the crowd to continue. "To those of us whose decisions helped create the situation that led to such terrible waste, I ask that you kneel to demonstrate your contrition and respect as we move forward."

Catra and Hordak both immediately hit the ground on their knees and she heard him grunt softly. She heard a few people in the crowd make approving noises, but it barely registered. Glimmer fiddled with the speech on her podium for a moment longer before she continued, "Etheria is a wondrous and magical planet. Etherians love life and crave peace and harmony." She saw Scorpia kneel and bow her head before Entrapta sank to her knees. Hordak exchanged a brief look with her before they both bowed their heads and returned their eyes to the ground.

Glimmer paused for a beat as another low murmur swept the crowd, but continued in a clear, strong tone. “But war reached the planet over a thousand years ago when the First Ones colonized here, and since then, Etheria has become intimately acquainted with the consequences of usury and violence."

Glimmer’s voice betrayed mingled pain and pride as she continued. “Horde Prime was a heartless, cruel, centuries old, intergalactic god that ruled by terror and domination. But five days ago, Etheria finally broke his control and She-Ra destroyed him for good. His reign is over now.” A few nearby people in the crowd made noises of heartfelt thanks. "However, his reign was far-reaching and insidious, and the universe will without doubt feel the scars he leaves upon us for generations.” More murmuring from the crowd.

“A lifetime ago, the abandoned clone Hordak landed in a hostile desert in a struggling kingdom, alone, disoriented, and fully indoctrinated. Ever since, the horrific tyranny that afflicted the wider universe has extended through Hordak and unto Etheria. Ever since, we’ve been tearing each other apart." Right beside Catra, Adora sank into a kneeling position. Everyone that could see her reacted with shock and Glimmer immediately fell silent.

“Adora,” Catra murmured, without really knowing what to say.

Adora answered loudly so that the people around them could hear. “I was a part of that system. I grew up in the Fright Zone. I’ve spent most of my life in the horde, unknowingly serving Prime with them. The horde was my family . I won’t be separated from people I loved by the fact that I became She-Ra." She lifted her chin, holding her head high. “And She-Ra was part of making this mess, too. None of us made all the right choices.” Tears streamed down Catra’s face as she gazed at Adora’s expression, blazing with churning emotion. She loved her so much.. so fucking much. Adora turned and leaned to place a chaste kiss on her forehead before returning her gaze to the young queen.

Glimmer waited, but the crowd didn’t go silent again. The sound of sniffling and anguished sighs continued to punctuate the thick air. The queen cleared her throat and when she spoke again, her voice was choked and brittle. “We lived to see the end of those terrible times. Many did not.”

Mermista, who was also crying fiercely, knelt and Glimmer’s voice caught in her throat. Hordak’s head snapped up to stare at Mermista, who’s fists and teeth were clenched. “Princess Mermista?” Glimmer asked in a much quieter voice.

“My decisions helped create the situation that led to such intolerable waste. I wish to show my contrition and respect,” she declared, voice loud and clear.

Catra’s heart pounded and the crowd grew louder as Frosta joined Mermista on her knees.

Glimmer continued, her voice cracking slightly. “Our losses have been brutal, and inexcusable. But lloss is a part of existence. We don't know how or when, but the day comes for all of us when we lose someone we're sure we can't live without. And the pain will feel like the end of everything. But it won't be, because it never is, and we will keep moving forward with loss as well as hope in our hearts. And that's okay. That's part of surviving.” Somber murmurs swept the crowd, punctuated by sniffing.

Angella had been whispering to Micah, and now he knelt so that she was sitting on his knee, her back still supported by his arm. Glimmer was having a hard time staying composed, swiping at her eyes and clearing her throat repeatedly. “Now it is up to us to create a world in which the dead can find a home, and survivors can learn to live with their grief. I know right now that seems like an impossible task, but we’ve done the impossible before.” She smiled down at the podium through her tears and Catra felt a fresh wave of crying wrack her body. “I have faith that together, we can do it, and it will be beautiful.”

Glimmer drew a deep, trembling breath. “So let this day be one of thanksgiving and remembrance. May we be grateful for everything that we carried through the dark night of Prime’s reign. And may we ever remember those that fell before dawn broke.” By the time she was done speaking, everyone on the entry staircase to the palace of Bright Moon was kneeling. Glimmer finished her speech by saying, “I now welcome ex-cadet Lonnie of the Etherian horde to read the list of names of Etheria’s missing as we’ve compiled it thus far.” Then she stepped away to make room for the soldiers and knelt next to Bow, who put an arm around her.

All was silent other than the sound of crying as Lonnie read name after name after name. Catra felt like the sheer weight of the pain in the air would crush her, and noticed that Hordak had begun to tremble where he knelt between Entrapta and Wrong Hordak. Lonnie kept going. And going. And going . She continued for so long that her throat went dry and she had to start taking turns with Kyle. They continued until Catra’s knees were aching and her feet were numb. They continued until Entrapta had curled up in a ball on her step, continued until Hordak was on all fours, mostly supported by Wrong Hordak, who was crying pitifully and clinging to his brother. They continued until they had to start cycling their turns with Scorpia and Adora, and then they continued on.

Finally, hours later, the names stopped and Lonnie finished with a hoarse; "and at least three hundred unnamed clones on Etheria alone."

Catra’s head was pounding, her entire face hurt from all the crying, and she was trembling with grief and exhaustion. Then she realized the crowd, which had not thinned during the hours of endless names, was simply standing in silence. Nobody seemed to know what to do with themselves, but Glimmer soon rose and stepped back to the podium.

All eyes were on her again. “My friends. My fellow survivors. I invite you now to let your pain flow through you, so that you might be able to give thanks for all we have, and remember friends who aren’t here. I wish you all peace and healing.” With

that she stepped away from the podium and crossed the landing to be with her mother and father, towing Bow along by the hand as he motioned for his kneeling fathers to take the platform. There the two historians gave a short statement telling people who to go to in order to start telling their stories, encouraging them to share and listen. It only took a moment, and then nobody was on the platform, and everything was quiet.

It started slowly, but soon applause ripped open the atmosphere around them, so loud that Catra pressed her hands over her ears. She felt Adora wrap her arms around her and she rocked her gently as the sea of people around them clapped and clapped, for what felt like far too long to Catra. The crowd slowly began to shift, however, from clapping to more general good cheer, hugging strangers joyously or holding each other patiently during crying fits. She heard the low tones of clones as they wept together or else as Etherians caught them up in conversations or stories.

When she raised her head back up, Adora let go of her and leaned back to cup her face and peer at her in concern. Her eyes were such a gorgeous shade of blue. She'd paid little attention to her hair and there were lumps and stray pieces sticking out. She looked so tired. Catra reached up and smoothed out the pucker between Adora's brows with the pad of her thumb. Adora reached up to grab her hand, then pulled it to her mouth and kissed it.

When the landing began to clear of rebellion fighters, Adora led Catra back inside. As the crowd slowly began dispersing through Bright Moon, the Rebellion was splitting off into smaller groups to grieve in their own, private ways, having pulled a kind of comfort from the shared grief of the memorial. There was no comfort for Catra, though. The further she got from the memorial, the more her guilt penetrated her conscious, making her chest feel as if it were heavy with bubbling sludge. She and Adora stalled when they reached the main hallway in the front of the palace, unsure of where to go or what to do with themselves.

"If I don't do something about these swollen eyes, pretty soon I won't be able to see," Catra said, trying to fake a light chuckle.

She knew Adora saw through it, but the other smiled anyway before she led them back, deeper into the palace.

While they went to scrounge some in the kitchens, Adora talked about her day splitting her attention between the clones and the gathering mourners, and Catra was extremely glad that for once the tactful thing to do (stay out of sight in their bedroom until the speech) had been easy. Even now she felt like she was barely making it through the hours, feeling like she could fall apart at any moment beneath the crushing reality around her. Adora ran in and out once they got there, just in case they weren't the only ones there, and soon they were lingering awkwardly in a random hallway again.

Adora trailed off in the middle of recalling how Mermista was handling the fact that she'd sunk the entire horde fleet (not well,) and Catra looked at her with one eye, a cloth full of ice pressed over the other one. “Honestly Catra, I think I want to stop talking about this stuff. Just for a little bit." Adora sighed. "It’s so fucking sad, and I’m so tired, and I don’t even want to think about it right now.”

“Yeah, I know what you mean.”

“Want to tell me about Angella’s rescue mission?” Adora said brightly, a lovely smile curling her lips. Then her face fell. “I’m sorry I couldn’t come with you.”

“Don’t be. It would have kept you from protecting Etheria and it all went fine, so whatever.”

“I bet it was a pretty exhausting mission.” She grabbed Catra’s hand and started pulling her along a route she did not recognize.

Catra snorted and turned around to walk backward, watching Adora glance around her anxiously down the straight corridor, as if a piece of furniture might suddenly leap into Catra’s path without her notice. “Not really. I spent almost the entire time lounging and talking. Or napping. Or lounging and napping.”

“What was it like in there?”

Catra heaved a sigh and spun around mid-stride in time to make the next corner. “Actually, it started out pretty creepy. We landed on the platform beneath the Moonstone but that was all there was. Everything around us was just mist. Then I looked up and saw that the stone itself had broken into a gillion little pieces and they were just, like, hanging out above Angella.”

“Above Angella?” Adora asked, quirked her head.

“Yeah, and that was the creepiest part. Angella was unconscious and she was just kind of… floating there. Graceful but really eerie.”

“Wooaah.”

“Hordak did some shit with his machine thing and she slowly lowered. He said the little bubble we were in was zapping her strength or something. She floated down and eventually regained consciousness, and it was kind of intense, I guess. I spent my waking hours explaining the last couple of years, which mostly sucked but sometimes didn’t.”

“How bad was Hordak?” Catra fell back to walk slightly behind her as Adora smirked, trying to lighten the mood.

“About as bad as you’d expect. Emotionally stunted to the point of immaturity. Annoying as always, but he also could have been worse.”

“I don’t know if either of us have much room to talk about being emotionally stunted,” Adora said, still smirking. "Was there any trouble?”

Catra scrunched her face and shook her head. “Nah, it was all pretty chill. He mostly pouted while Angella and I talked.”

They came to a large door that Adora slowly heaved open, revealing the giant room beyond. It looked to be a training space,

filled with mats, punching bags, various equipment and practice-weapons. The entire thing was still lavishly decorated in the soaring arches, shining golds, and the traditional crystalline pinks and purples of Bright Moon. "I figured we needed to clear our heads a little. Maybe blow off some steam before we wind down for the evening?" Adora sounded almost shy.

Catra's tail swishing and she felt an ear turn. A good brawl might just take her mind off of the fact that she'd gotten the closest thing she'd ever had to family killed for nothing. At least for a little while. "Adora… that is an amazing idea," she said before she pounced.

Chapter End Notes

> If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you've got. It is very much appreciated.

“For fuck’s sake, Hordak,”

Chapter Summary

> Catra and Hordak are dragged, kicking and screaming, into some comfort and team-building. Entrapta is convinced she's onto something BIG.

Chapter Notes

> Disclaimer: Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization and post-war angle. So uh, expect the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you’re dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anyone for anything.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When Entrapta fixed the last of Hordak’s armor into place, he couldn’t help a low hiss of relief as the full-body pain he’d been fending off for hours began to ease. Glimmer had been kind enough to teleport Entrapta, Wrong Hordak, and himself back to the lab. He likely wouldn’t have been able to make the walk without support and he’d rather crawl than be carried. The three of them hovered in the small bedroom in awkward silence. His younger brother was still crying, ears low, nose running. On any other day, he might have been annoyed by the protracted weeping. Instead, he sat on the bed and lapsed into silence, observing the horror he’d been wading through since Prime died. Since Hordak had killed him, rather. Something about the memorial had changed the feeling of it all somehow, but he couldn’t imagine *why.*

He’d killed so many people. People that deserved to live just as much as his soldiers. And he hadn’t even seen his troops as fully people, not really. His lifelong denial wasn’t more or less forgivable than it had been before the memorial. The scope of tragedy that his mind could process was no greater or lesser than

it had been. Yet, there was definitely *something* blooming amongst the desolation inside of him.

Entrapta sniffed and he looked up to see her rubbing gloved knuckles at red-rimmed eyes. Only then did he realize that she might be struggling with her own guilt. “It wasn’t your fault,” was all he could think to say. But at least in this statement he could be confident.

“I know,” she said, voice thick with tears and extra nasally. “It’s just sad.” She slowly crawled into his lap and tucked herself into a ball, and he slowly wrapped his arms around her scrunched form.

“I’m sorry,” he whispered, and knew it was a ridiculous thing to say.

Entrapta shook her head and spoke into her thighs. “It’s the same as everything else, Hordak. You served Prime. We blame him, and choose to embrace the man you're learning to be.”

Her mercy turned his stomach and his face crumpled. He tucked his chin to hide his face from Wrong Hordak and gripped Entrapta a little tighter. Wrong Hordak sat down on a crate nearby and slumped forward, bracing his elbows on his knees.

After a while of silence, Entrapta spoke, her voice still muffled by her legs. “I love you Hordak. I’m going to go get some comfort food. We should all eat.” She slowly uncurled in his arms before extricating herself gently. Her hair hung limp as she walked away, the ends of her pigtails trailing on the ground.

When she was gone, Wrong Hordak came to sit on the bed at Hordak’s side, though he left space between them. He’d finally stopped crying and seemed to have collected himself. When he spoke his voice was firm, if quiet. “When I was cut off from the hive mind,” he began slowly, sounding utterly exhausted, “I was immediately taken in by Brother Entrapta and her friends.” He sighed, and Hordak wondered where he was going with his story. “They were kind, and patient. I should have been glad, or...

relieved... I should have woken up and seen an opportunity that I had never imagined nor expected. But all I could think was that there was no more *him* ... and nothing else mattered but him. He was gone, and I was alone. That was all there was." He took a deep breath and looked over at Hordak. “I talked to our brothers. They were the exact same way at first, after the disconnect. What you became here… it could have been any one of us. If what you became means that you are evil by nature, then we all are. But I don’t believe that to be true at all.”

Hordak looked up at him, tears in his eyes, and realized that his brother’s words were actually comforting. He nodded weakly and Wrong Hordak pulled him into a brief, tight hug. “Your kind words are soothing, sweet brother. Thank you,” he whispered, careful to keep his voice quiet enough that nobody else might hear.

Wrong Hordak grasped his shoulder briefly before they lapsed into silence, lost in their own thoughts. Hordak studied his clasped hands, thinking about the endless names. Wrong Hordak stared blankly at the rough stone wall. Hordak heard him gulp and sniff, and tried to prepare himself to offer comfort. Thankfully, however, a soft scrabbling sound turned their attention to an upper corner of the carved room just before Imp glided down at them. He lighted on the end of the bed and crept toward Hordak on all fours, sniffing cautiously.

“It’s alright, little one. I think most of today’s crying is over,” Hordak said gently, lowering an arm toward him. Imp hopped forward and skittered up and over to the shoulder nearest Wrong Hordak. His brother was apparently quite taken with Imp, and doted on the spoiled monster as much as Entrapta did, readily engaging in her habit of buying his affections with treats.

Hordak settled into lightly running his claws through Imp’s little tuft of hair while Wrong Hordak scooted up close to scratch him between his wings. Feet in his hands, Imp sat happily on Hordak’s shoulder- a broad seat due to the armor. For a long while, he closed his eyes and purred in his odd, high-pitched clicking way.

Eventually he got bored and chirped at them before flying off. Wrong Hordak watched him go before he spoke softly. “I am glad you are my brother, Hordak.”

“I am glad you are mine.”

* * * * *

Catra snorted and the rest of the group laughed while Lonnie talked. “And do you guys remember using Kyle as bait to lure out the squads we competed with in training? But they always thought it was a ruse, because 'golly gee, who would sacrifice their own teammate like that!' ” The little group of ex-horde soldiers broke out in renewed laughter, clutching at their pink drinks and rocking in place.

Catra looked around herself at the soldiers she'd served with in the horde, a deep ache gnawing her chest. After she'd sparred with Adora until they'd both been pouring sweat, she and Catra had showered quickly. Not knowing what else to do and still too sad to fuck, they'd wandered back out into the palace, where Scorpia had spotted them and invited them to drink with friends in the Dining Hall. Now, as they talked and drank, Adora, Scorpia, Kyle, Lonnie, Rogelio and Catra clustered at the end of Bright Moon’s gigantic formal dining table.

“Uh-huh, uh-huh, and do you remember who got to be best of all of us at dodging fazers?” Kyle retorted, nose in the air but smiling good-naturedly as he held his mug with both hands. The group laughed again and Rogelio patted Kyle on the back with a brief roar.

“Ro’s right,” Lonnie sighed. “We were a mess, but we had our moments.”

“Hey, regardless of our methods, we were still one of the best squads in the Horde,pa” Adora added.

“It’s true,” Scorpia agreed. “Everyone knew Shadow Weaver only took on the best.”

Catra couldn’t bring herself to participate in conversation; she felt too hollow. The other ex Horde soldiers in the palace welcomed her company though, and she was deeply grateful for it. Listening to them reminiscing helped sooth the ragged edges around the emptiness in her chest. Glimmer and Bow were of course as positive and supportive as ever, but they offered the grieving soldiers their space, which was probably a good thing. Thinking of Bow and Glimmer, she began to feel restless, and thought it might be time to switch settings for a while. Maybe she’d go find Melog.

As Catra rose, however, she heard Kyle say her name. “Huh?” She turned to look at him.

“I just wanted to tell you to take care of yourself,” he smiled gently and her ears flattened in discomfort. “I don’t blame you, and I don'twant you to blame you either.”

Catra tried to think of what to say, rubbing her arm and swishing her tail. “Honestly Catra? Me neither.” This time it was Lonnie, which surprised her. She looked up to meet her stern gaze. “I want somebody to blame- believe me, I do- but there’s no one person at fault. The war was part of something that started way before we were born. I’m mad at the whole, stupid mess.”

Rogelio growled and roared for a moment, but seemed to agree.

“You didn’t invent the game. You were just really good at it,” Kyle said, looking older than she'd ever seen him.

Catra hovered awkwardly for another moment before sighing. “Thanks guys. I really appreciate it. I’m just going to go take a

walk, uh, if you don't mind," she said haltingly. She shrugged, turned, and made her escape.

The fastest way out of the palace was via the kitchens, but on her way through she ran into Bow and Glimmer as they bickered lovingly. Fucking Ew. "Catra!" Glimmer called once she spotted her. "Help us settle this argument."

She rolled eyes, but approached them.

"You know how Scorpia's been helping Perfuma figure out her new, amped-up powers because she's so crazy strong?" Glimmer asked.

"And now has powers of her own, yeah," added Catra.

"Right. Well, I was thinking it might be a good thing for the princesses to start training together!" she said, exuberantly.

"Which is *insanity* , because we only just got the power-up, and using powers on people would be incredibly dangerous," Bow argued.

Catra raised an eyebrow and regarded them both. Then she shrugged. "I'm with Sparkles on this one," she said in a bored tone. "The better we get at fighting with eachother, the better prepared we are to defend Etheria against whoever comes to fuck shit up next."

Bow clutched his face and moaned, but Glimmer hissed, "Yesss!" Catra made to pass them but Glimmer held out her hand to stop her. "Wait, that's not all we have to say."

Catra sighed but waited and listened.

"We just wanted to remind you that you're young and you can overcome the darkness of your past," Bow said warmly.

"And that we want you and love you because you're our friend," Glimmer finished.

Catra stared back at them and blinked. “That... means a lot,” she said quietly, hoping very much that her well-meaning friends would be through with the mushy sentiments, soon. “Thank you.”

They both advanced on her without warning and trapped her in a tight hug. From between their heads she saw a thick strand of purple hair pop a grate off a large span of ducting. “Hey, Entrapta,” she said, and realized she was smiling.

“Hiii, Catra,” the other shouted cheerfully as she dropped to the floor before turning to rummage noisily.

“Oh hi, Entrapta,” Bow said brightly, releasing Catra and turning around. “How are you feeling?”

The scientist paused, then squinted and made a high-pitched sound while she considered. “I’m pretty sure the reawakened bio-mechanical monstrosities that the First Ones created offer a highly promising channel for research into the potential in integrating magic and technology, which has me feeling *very* excited. But I’m also feeling very sad from the memorial. Buuuut I’m also glad that Hordak is eating Etherian food now, and hopeful that he’ll be able to gain some weight, which would free me to focus on pain management. So I guess I’m feeling quite a lot right now.” She smiled and went back to rifling through barrels and boxes as Catra and Glimmer exchanged confused looks. She reached for an empty sack, hair full of fruit from Plumeria, but hesitated. Then she shrugged and grabbed one of the crates of fruit instead. When she turned back toward the others though, she froze and stared. "I should not have said that."

Catra spoke first, frowning. “What do you mean, now that he’s eating Etherian food he might be able to gain weight? I thought he was scrawny because of the defect.”

“What, was he too good for Etherian food, before?” Adora asked as she appeared next to Catra.

“Ugh, is that why we had to eat those foul-ass ration bars?” Catra asked, curling her lip.

“No! No, no…” Entrapta said hurriedly, then flipped down her mask. “I, uh, I shouldn't... I should be careful what I reveal, but a lot of his weight issues seem to have been diet- related, rather than wasting or degenerative. He already seems to be doing a lot better now than he was in the Fright Zone.”

“What do you mean, diet?” asked Glimmer, who had crossed her arms and was frowning now as well. “Like he didn’t eat right?” She cast an ominous look at Bow, who's face hardened. Catra could tell they were thinking about the clones.

Entrapta began twisting her hands and Catra imagined she might know what was coming. “Technically he didn't really eat at all. He came up with an imitation of that fluid Prime had them on. Hordak didn't realize... uh... never figured out how prime made the real stuff, but his was enough to keep him upright and working.”

Glimmer spoke again. “Why didn't he just eat the Etherian food he eats now?”

Entrapta whined and took a step back. “Guys, he’s really, *really* private. I'm pretty sure he’d hate that I’m talking about this with you.”

“Sorry, Entrapta,” Bow said gently. “We just want to know if there’s something more we should be watching out for in the clones.”

Entrapta made another agitated noise, but relented. “For the clones.” She sighed heavily, still talking from behind her bug mask. “He said some nonsense about unearned foreign delicacies or whatever, but ultimately, he didn’t eat it because he liked it.”

“Oh no,” Glimmer said. Her face fell as she exchanged another significant look with Bow.

Entrapta groaned, wringing her hands. “I shouldn’t have said that.”

“I don’t get it,” Adora said. “So what if he liked it?”

“Um…” Entrapta stalled, “something about not not indulging in what he hadn't yet conquered? Please don't make me say anymore.”

“But I still don’t…” Adora began, even as Catra tried to elbow her into silence.

“Hordak didn't eat because he didn't think he deserved it,” Glimmer told her gently.

“For fuck’s sake, Hordak,” Catra sighed as she pinched the bridge of her nose. "How does it keep getting worse with you?” A thought struck Catra and she asked Entrapta without thinking, “Wait, you had him banging you, but not eating?”

“I uh... wasn't as aware of his beliefs and preferences as I should have been.” Entrapta fell into nervous rambling. “I assumed his weight had to do with his physical health rather than mental or emotional priblems. I even assumed that he didn't act on his feelings toward me because he was mostly unaware of them. After all, I know how difficult it can be to maintain emotional awareness while trying to work. I just... never imagined his reasoning had been so badly twisted. I could have, but I didn't look hard enough.”

“It’s okay, Entrapta,” Adora broke in. “You noticed a lot more than anybody else ever did. It’s not like any of us could have been prepared for what the clones have been through. And you wanted to save him when nobody else had it in them to even help him.”

“I told you I didn’t save anyone.”

“You’re right, you’re right,” Adora amended. “But you did show him he could save himself in a way that got through. Nobody else

did that. You should give yourself some credit, instead of beating yourself up over what you missed."

"Glimmer!" They all paused and looked up as the sound of Queen Angella's call filtered in through the kitchen door. "We're ready to go now."

Glimmer sighed. "Speaking of, Mom wants to visit Hordak and she's making dad come." Catra and Adora cringed.

"We could go with," Bow suggested.

Glimmer nodded, grabbed his arm, and they disappeared. Entrapta was still wringing her hands. "Don't worry," Catra said, stepping forward and putting a hand on her shoulder. "None of us are going to say anything about it. And you're doing a great job at being a girlfriend."

"Girlfriend…" Entrapta repeated softly, her hands finally slowing. "You're not the first person to say so. He's my lab partner first, but I suppose Hordak is also my boyfriend, isn't he?"

She and Adora exchanged looks before Catra answered. "I mean, he's kind of your bitch, but 'boyfriend' works too."

* * * * *

It surprised Hordak when his ears pricked up at the sound of faint voices approaching through the caverns toward the lab, too soon to be Entrapta. At first they were too faint to make out what they were saying, so he rose to meet them in the lab, followed by Wrong Hordak. Soon he could tell it was four people, two of whom were speaking to one another in hushed tones, and his hearts sank when he realized who the voices belonged to. Queen Angella and King Micah were two people he definitely did not want to talk to today.

He heard Micah grumble something under his breath before Angella cut him off, a note of finality in her tone. “Sweetheart, you don’t have to forgive him for what he did to feel compassion for him. You’re a grown man, you can feel both those things at the same time. Life isn’t simple enough to do otherwise.” Hordak thought he heard the man sigh. “Now please let me down, I don’t want to be carried in.” A moment later, a soft knock sounded on the lab door.

“Enter,” he called, bracing himself.

King Micah held the door for Queen Angella, who leaned heavily on an elegant cane as she entered the large space, wearing her now-familiar gentle smile. After them came Queen Glimmer and Bow. Four people, then. Wonderful.

“Hi Hordak,” said Glimmer, who sounded tired, but happy.

“Hey big guy,” said Bow in his warm, friendly way. “Before I forget, my dad George sent a note for you,” he put a folded piece of paper on a nearby desk before stepping back in with the group and continuing. “We thought we’d swing by and see how you were holding up.”

“And to remind you of the things I’ve already told you to do,” Angella gave him a softly stern look. “We still need you to help us face the future. There are others to be well for.” He clenched his jaw, but nobody commented on her pointed reiteration.

Hordak had no idea what to say. All he could think was that he was too miserable to be dealing with them, and he very much hoped that this whole ‘visiting’ affair wouldn’t become a habit.

“Allow me to arrange seating for us!” Wrong Hordak said cheerfully before bustling off around the lab to rummage. Once he was gone, the others turned to look at Hordak expectantly. He gazed back with a blank stare.

Then he panicked, turned around and walked away, back into the bedroom. He grabbed a few blankets as an excuse and returned

to where Hordak had stacked several boxes to offer Angella something to rest her back against. He handed over the blankets, one of which Wrong Hordak folded and laid over the crates, the other he offered to the Queen as she approached.

“I apologize for neglecting to make better provisions for visitors,” Hordak said as he stepped back and let them choose their seats.

“Nonsense, this is quite enough for me,” Angella said as she settled herself in and Micah spread the blanket over her.

“Queen Mother Angella… please correct me if I overstep, I do not mean to presume,” Hordak continued, hesitantly, “but I regret that you still appear to feel unwell.”

“Not at all, it’s kind of you to inquire.” She waved a hand dismissively. “But the Moonstone’s power is no longer split between my daughter and myself. As reigning sovereign, the power belongs to her, and I wouldn’t have it any other way.”

Hordak frowned but nodded.

“However, I do feel a bit better today. I think I’ve got a good chance at recovering one day,” she smiled. “It just may take a long while."

The group fell into the usual awkward silence, but it was broken when Bow’s communicator beeped. When he looked at the screen and read something, his face fell into a deep frown. Then he nudged Glimmer and handed the pad over, muttering ‘Entrapta’ as he did. Hordak’s attention was immediately focused on them, though they didn’t offer the group any explanation.

Just as Hordak realized he was the only one standing, Wrong Hordak turned and addressed him. “Brother, Etherians usually seem more comfortable when we mimic their stance in social settings,” he said in a stage whisper, patting the crate next to him.

“Of course,” he exhaled as he obeyed.

More stagnant silence.

"How interesting, that your eyes are turning back to red and your hair is coming in blue again," offered Angella.

He hadn't noticed. "Indeed."

Uncomfortable silence.

Hordak knew they were waiting for him to speak more, but could not bring himself to broach the subject of his guilt. When Wrong Hordak began to hum to himself vacantly, however, Hordak had to break the silence. “Thank you, Queen Glimmer,” he said, looking up at her with a slightly lowered head, “for honoring my fallen brothers today. You cannot know how much that means to us.”

“Don't mention it,” she replied. “Today was about sharing grief.” When he looked up at her in confusion, she smiled. “Sharing grief makes it easier to bear, trust me.”

Hordak jumped when he felt Wrong Hordak’s hand on his shoulder. He waited for the brief gesture to end, which it didn't, but eventually managed to relax into the casual touch.

“You don’t have to talk about how you feel if you don’t want to,” Bow said, “but you’re one of us now, and we want to make sure you’re okay.” Hordak nearly asked about the message he appeared to have received from Entrapta, but he knew it wasn’t his place. Instead, he nodded and hoped it was enough of a reply to make them stop.

“Our friend has a point, brother. Have you tried identifying and expressing your individual feelings? It is incredibly difficult but very rewarding. I really do recommend it.”

“I believed I expressed my emotions quite thoroughly at my hearing, did I not?” he asked with an edge in his voice.

“Yeah, I guess that’s why we’re worried.” He made an incredulous face as Glimmer used the word ‘worried’ before he could catch

himself. “We figured you’d be feeling pretty bad, after today. We all feel pretty bad.”

Hordak raised a brow. “You want to know how I feel,” he repeated slowly.

King Micah rolled his eyes but Bow nodded. Wrong Hordak winked rather aggressively.



Was it worth souring relations to simply demand they leave? What if he just kept saying no? Hordak came very near to refusing them point blank when he thought of what Entrapta might have said. She’d probably want him to be friendly and honest toward them. He sighed heavily as he tried to recall the virtues of humility. And besides, he reasoned, if they really wanted to know, that was their own damned fault. “It’s not that I treasured them, or that they were mine,” he began. “In truth, I am as horrified by the

deaths of others that I've murdered as those of my own troops. And I have been a mass murderer of innocents my whole life." He heard one of them gulp loudly. "That I killed that many more is one incomprehensible evil on top of countless others." He looked away and his mouth twisted in bitterness. "I suppose I imagined, after all the damage I'd done to my soldiers, that I might yet be able to do right by the ones I sent to fight and die in my name. But I'm too late. Far, far too late." He scoffed and closed his eyes briefly. "The lives and deaths I gave them were so cruel… so very *unfair* , that it's almost ridiculous." He shook his head in disgust. Now that he was stringing his disjointed thoughts together out loud, they made sense. A thrill of rage shot up his spine. "And *that* is the most unbearable part of it," he spat, "the absurdity of it all. The scope of destruction and pain, and that it was completely and utterly meaningless! It's absurd." He looked back at them, his breathing picking up. They stared back blankly, but their shoulders were all tense and rigid, and their eyes were a little too wide. "I was programmed to believe that suffering is a transformative burden or... or a test of faith," he snorted derisively, wrinkling his nasal ridge and narrowing his eyes. "But it's not. It's just absurdity."

As he finished his rant, Hordak began to regret the outburst. He knew he should have kept his composure, but level-headedness and subtlety had never exactly been strong suits of his. Heavy silence settled on the group as seconds ticked past. Eventually Glimmer spoke to him gently with sorrow in her eyes. "We'll figure it out together. It'll be okay, Hordak."

His anger quickly dissolved into shame. He stared back at her, then looked at the others who all nodded in agreement. That they were here, after everything that they'd learned about him, after everything that he'd done… it didn't make any sense. It didn't make *any* sense. Yet, here they were, giving him more mercy. And wretchedly, pitifully, desperately, he wanted it.

* * * * *

Catra was casting about for a tactful way to get Entrapta talking about science so as to cheer her up when the pig-tailed princess received a call. “Frosta!” she shouted as she opened the feed. “Tell me everything!”

They heard Frosta sigh before launching in. “So we found the drilling base, it’s under a bunch of arctic foliage, but it’s there and we think the worms are, too. But… so is other stuff.” The princess’ tone was ominous.

“Ooh, other stuff?” Entrapta asked, grinning in delight.

“There’s just a lot of sounds going on. And you know how creepy the Northern Reach can get.” The young teen sighed again. “Anyway, you should also know that my scientists have also identified at least one anomalous area where the plants are like, messed up and look weird, and they think it has something to do with magic. As far as new animals go, they can’t tell if they’re just plain giant creatures, magic creatures, First Ones’ tech, or whatever kind of mashup between those things. My people have recorded a bunch of super boring stuff for you.” Entrapta shook her fists and squealed before Frosta continued. “But they also found this weird red and pink piece of First Ones’ tech with, like, not really a triangle, but with three points? It’s like a three-pointed star.”

Entrapta’s face fell and the three of them exchanged worried looks. Catra leaned forward and addressed the screen loudly. “Frosta. Do not, under any circumstances, let anyone tinker with that thing. It’s extremely dangerous.”

“Uh… okay, I’ll pass that on,” Frosta said, confused.

“As in right now,” Catra insisted. “ASAP. Immediately.”

“Alright, alright. Sheesh.” No sooner had Frosta ended the communication than Entrapta was tapping at the screen furiously.

“Entrapta?” Adora asked slowly. “What are you planning?”

Entrapta’s hair curled at the ends and she was practically vibrating with excitement. “I always knew that piece of tech might be the key. I’ve got the team, the resources, and the know-how. It won’t be long now!”

“Entrapta I really don’t think you should be messing with that virus anymore.” Adora argued.

Entrapta seemed to wilt before them. “But we’ve always figured it out before,” she whined, “and there’s so much to learn!”

Catra was already shaking her head. “No way. Not worth it.”

Entrapta began bouncing around the room, collecting fruit and baked goods in one of the baskets off the wall. “What if we don’t repair it? It won’t infect anything if it stays broken, right?”

Adora made a face like she had to agree. “No!” Catra insisted, alarmed that Adora would cave so easily.

“I don’t know, Catra. If anyone could figure it out, it’s Entrapta. And she said they’d keep it broken.”

“Adora!” Catra cried, stunned and unsure of what to say.

“Walk and talk,” Entrapta commanded, holding the door outside open. “Wrong Hordak gets grumpy when he’s hungry.” As Catra passed, she spoke again. “Also, I *kiiind* of already sent out the messages to gather the crew to go there immediately. Sorry, Catra.”

* * * * *

“So what *is* an Imp?” Angella asked politely.

“Literally no one has been able to answer that question for me,” Micah grumbled from where he was slumped on his crate, arms crossed.

Hordak felt his ears pull back slightly and hastily corrected them. Queen Angella seemed absolutely determined to establish easy relations between the royal family and himself, and he was nearly squirming in discomfort. Queen Glimmer had, frustratingly, disappeared with her archer after the cryptic excuse of ‘gathering the right clones for Entrapta’s thing,’ which left him burning with curiosity, but trapped in a social call with two of his most notable victims. “Imp is one of my many scientific failures.”

“He is a delight!” Wrong Horak declared. “Imp is my brother’s… um…” he looked at Hordak and faltered, unsure of exactly what their relationship might be called. “Pe… so…. he is… Imp.”

“Ah,” Angella said softly, nodding as if she weren’t confused.

“Imp!” Hordak called in a gruff voice. He waited for a beat, but there was no reply.

“I-i-imp,” Wrong Hordak called in an obnoxious sing-song voice.

The flapping gremlin immediately swooped down from the shadow ceiling with a dead rat between his pointed teeth and landed on Hordak’s knee. He turned around to look at Angella and Micah before he spat the rodent corpse out into Hordak's lap. The King and Queen wore strained expressions, but kept their composure.

“Thank you, Imp,” he sighed, scratching the little beast’s tuft of hair.

Wrong Hordak clasped his hands, fingers woven, up next to his face as he gushed, “Isn’t he precious?”

The two visitors exchanged looks before Angella answered, “Quite.”

Imp spread his wings and hissed at them before he scampered over to search the doting clone's pockets for treats. Hordak gingerly placed the dead rat on a nearby table and brushed off his skirt, raising a brow and waiting for the next painful stretch of small-talk.

It was a relief, then, when he heard Entrapta's voice filtering through the stone rooms. She was with others, and she seemed to be having an animated discussion. Or was she arguing with someone? He frowned and adjusted his ears, listening hard.

"We're talking about the cutting edge of science in this *universe* , people. This is bigger than us… bigger than anything! And we want to be ahead of the game, don't we?" she asked.

"You're a genius, Entrapta, we already are ahead of the game." Hordak now recognized Catra's voice. "Like I keep telling Adora, if we've got you and She-Ra, then we're set. We don't need to be messing with this thing!"

"Aside from that," Adora cut in as they drew nearer, "if the First Ones were doing something with it, there's a good chance we're going to encounter something like this again, eventually. Shouldn't we try to understand that?"

"Exactly!" Entrapta cried from the other side of the door. It suddenly banged open as she burst into the room. "Hordak!"

"Yes? he asked politely.

"I brought food, but I've got to go to the Northern Reach. I'll be back tonight, though." She was grinning.

He was a bit taken aback by the sudden declaration, but not at all surprised. Entrapta's work was one of her more erratic features. "What are you on to?" he asked, intensely curious.

"Oh, Hordak!" she squealed. She shook her fists and bounded toward him, leaping onto him and hugging tightly. "It's so exciting! I really think we've got something good with this one!

Magic and tech and Etheria and everything!" She paused. "There's a dead rat on the table," she mentioned casually. Then she let him go and turned to the king and queen. "Okay! So I know our first priority is travel and communication, but all this wild magic has been making the science *extremely* challenging. Crucial to moving forward with developing tech on Etheria is understanding the intersection between science and magic and tech! Luckily for us, there's a whole bunch of current manifestations of this very interplay all over Etheria, both in the residents and the natural environment!" She petered off and dragged in a huge breath before continuing. "I still believe we can learn a lot from the First Ones on that; they knew how to make magic and tech work together after all, which is more than even Prime knew. I've observed creatures which I believe have integrated magic and tech in their physical makeup. I don't know where others are, but I know where at least two are up in the Northern Reach, which means I can study them without a bunch of other Etherians getting in the way!"

"The virus, Entrapta, don't forget the murder virus," Catra muttered darkly.

"Murder... virus?"

"It…" Entrapta only got out a word before Glimmer appeared with Bow and three clones in tow.

"Good," Catra grunted. "Maybe they can talk some sense into you." Hordak realized she was addressing Entrapta and cocked his head. His instinct was toward Entrapta, but Catra's rejection of whatever this 'murder virus' was seemed like an option to entertain.

"Huh? What?" Glimmer asked, looking around herself. The three clones she'd brought betrayed their hesitation in their tense shoulders and close proximity as they pressed inward and away from the rest of the group.

"We brought the clones," Bow said, pointing out the obvious.

“What is this murder virus?” Wrong Hordak asked.

“Don’t forget the sword isn’t an actual thing anymore, outside of the magic,” Adora said to Catra.

“Quiet,” Angella said. The room fell silent. “Someone explain, but only one of you.”

Catra jumped in before anybody else could. She was scowling and her tail bristled. “Entrapta wants to study an extremely dangerous murder virus. I say fuck no, we’re better off without it.”

Many people nodded or shrugged at the summation.

“Entrapta says it won’t be a danger if we keep it broken,” Glimmer added. Entrapta nodded.

Catra made an exasperated gesture and looked around. “Am I the only person here that thinks this is a terrible idea?” Nobody answered. “Fucking seriously?”

“What do you think, Hordak?”

Hordak looked back at Angella in shock. “Me?” She nodded. He looked at Catra, who rolled her eyes and looked away. He wanted to agree with her, but he was no fool. “Entrapta has my full faith. I would follow her lead in all things scientific, and trust her judgement.” Catra made a disgusted noise and her tail swished in agitation. “I only request thorough testing,” he added. Entrapta beamed at him and he felt the corners of his own mouth lift.

“What if we postponed the mission until tomorrow morning?” Glimmer suggested. “While Hordak and Catra go to Salineas with Double Trouble and Mermista, the rest of the crew can go with Entrapta to make sure she gets set up safely. How does that sound?” She looked around at the others, waiting for assent.

Catra didn’t seem at all impressed. “Whatever,” she muttered.

“Does that work for you?” Glimmer asked Entrapta.

The small woman looked disappointed at having to wait the night, but soon brightened. "I suppose we can do that. But can I keep the brothers tonight? I have *so* much to learn when it comes to techno-organics."

"If they want," the Queen replied, looking over at the clones who nodded in reply.

Hordak spoke up then. "Entrapta, you need rest. I'm sure my brothers will be happy to work with you after you've slept."

Entrapta cackled and he sighed in frustration. "Science never sleeps! You know that, Hordak. I'll go to bed after I get a crash-course in techno-organics from the clones, I promise," she assured him before she turned to talk to his huddled-up brethren. Micah stood to help Angella to her feet and Catra started arguing with Adora again while Glimmer stretched and Bow rolled his neck.

The room of people paused, however, when the three new clones approached Hordak cautiously. He couldn't help but frown at them in confusion before the clone nearest him first addressed the room. "Our brothers and ourselves wish to express our deepest gratitude to the Alliance. Both for their charity and kindness, and for their respect at today's memorial," he said in a deep, measured voice.

"No problem," Glimmer said.

"Brother Hordak?" the same clone asked.

"Yes?" he was growing more and more weary of being forced into conversation.

"We also wanted to share our condolences with you." Hordak scowled and felt his ears lower in embarrassment. "We…" he paused and looked at his brothers, whose expressions were vaguely grim, "we all have guilt over the evil we did for Prime, especially to Etheria. We are sorry for what you might be feeling now."

His brother's words hit Hordak's chest like a physical blow, his throat tightened and his eyes immediately filled. Several people were kind enough to avert their gaze. "Yes, I… I have much to feel guilty for." He offered a tired smile, avoiding the eyes of others in the lab. He hated it with every atom in his body, but he knew he had to be gentle, despite the audience. "Thank you. That you would care for me as brothers is a great comfort."

His brothers looked at each other uncertainly before nodding. Then they turned to Entrapta, who was still bouncing with excitement. "How might we be of service?" the talker asked with a stiff little bow.

Entrapta squealed. "Tell me everything!"

Hordak rose and sighed heavily. As the large room began to empty, he made his way back to his bedroom. He was about to shut the door behind him when he remembered the note from George. He swept through the stragglers in the lab with his head down and eyes on the floor to retrieve the folded piece of paper, and successfully avoided conversation.

This time when he made to close the bedroom door, however, he was met with Wrong Hordak's anxious face. He clasped his hands before him, ears low. "Brother?"

"Yes?"

"I've been sleeping with our brothers in the camp," he said, "but… just tonight, may I stay with you?" Hordak opened his mouth to say no, but hesitated.

He was utterly exhausted, but the dark thoughts of the day waited in the shadowy corners of his mind. Hordak dreaded his nightmares. To his dismay, tears threatened again and he turned his face away. To be fair, he thought in resignation, he *could* use some help getting out of his armor, and he knew Entrapta would be happy to curl up with them both. He sighed and stood back to gesture Wrong Hordak into the bedroom. "Just tonight."

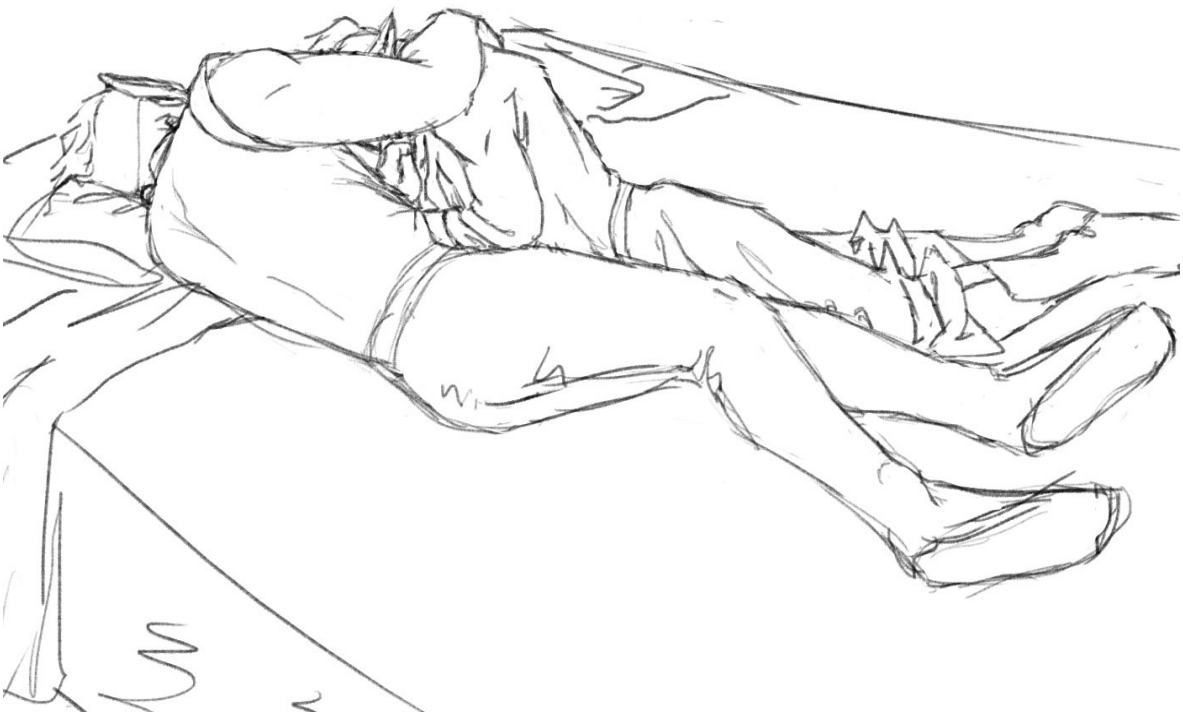
He clenched his jaw and shut his eyes at the burn in his ports as his armor was disengaged, piece by piece. When the worst of it on his torso was done, he unfolded the note from George and read the brief message:

- We must all live with the ghosts we've created, but one day we will find a way to give them peace. Even yours. We owe them that kindness. -

Despair welled up within Hordak so strong and fast that it took his breath away. He clenched his teeth and shut his eyes tight against the tears that spilled regardless. Holding his breath, he managed to keep from making sound as Wrong Hordak finished removing his armor. But when his brother noticed his distress and gently turned his tearful face toward him, sobs forced through his control and he crumbled.

Hordak collapsed onto the bed with his face in his hands and felt Wrong Hordak sit beside him. He didn't have it in him to fight it when his younger brother to pull him into a tight embrace, instead surrendering to the overpowering sobs that wracked his tired, broken body. When the crying only intensified rather than faded, he grabbed fistfuls of the robes on Wrong Hordak's chest and buried his face in them to muffle the sound of his weakness.

It took a very long time, but eventually Hordak wore himself out and began to quiet, in too much physical pain for further dramatics. Wrong Hordak stroked his head over an ear all the while, waiting patiently without saying a word. Hordak didn't even bother extricating himself from the younger clone's firm hug before he finally passed out, and neither did his brother.



They were both fast asleep by the time Entrapta finally made it to bed in the wee hours of the morning, but the sight struck her as so adorable that she had to retrieve a her datapad for a snapshot. The picture also gave her yet another exciting new idea, and she whispered a note to her recorder before worming her way between the hulking clones and falling asleep herself.

Chapter End Notes

> Just FYI, I'm basing Hordak's medical issues on my own for the sake of ease and relatability. I didn't want to just throw a bunch of shitty symptoms around, cause something about that feels a tiny bit icky to me? Anyway, EDS (connective tissue disorder), POTS (crappy heart) and, back in the day, some mental illness-related undereating. If you feel like I'm missing or misunderstanding important aspects of more severe disability, please let me know so I can learn :)

If it's convenient and you happen to have a thought or opinion, I humbly request any feedback you've got. It is very much appreciated.

“You never asked about the hair, did you?”

Chapter Summary

> The star siblings show up and the group learns more about events outside their orbit. They also learn a few things about Entrapta as they prepare to face the day's missions.

Chapter Notes

> In my imagination, Etherians turn out to be big spacebat fans because that's cute as shit.
>
> Disclaimer: Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization and post-war angle. So uh, expect the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you’re dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anyone for anything.

Catra laughed cruelly and smirked. “Really Adora, I thought we’d gotten past this,” she drawled as she danced away from Adora’s clumsy lunges with ease. “I would have thought you’d trained harder than this.”

Adora growled and clenched her fists. “You can try to manipulate me all you want…” Catra was able to dodge Adora’s first two swings, but she’d gotten faster. “...but we both know how this ends.”

Catra had to block her next jab, and nearly didn’t catch her arm when she’d ducked another. But she did, and the next second she’d thrown Adora’s entire body over her head in a wide arc. Adora hit the ground hard on her back and grunted as the breath left her. As she struggled up onto her elbows, Catra crouched over her, trying to act like she wasn’t worried. “Give up yet?”

Adora glared at her as a mischievous smile slowly took her mouth, though she was still fighting to get her breath back. Catra leaned closer unintentionally, staring. She realized her mistake too late,

and although she lunged backward from Adora's head-butt, Adora managed to clip her jaw hard, sending her twisting backward. "Agh, crap," Adora wheezed, "I didn't mean to hit you that hard. Are you okay?"

Catra raised a feeble thumb's up from where she was crumpled on the ground. They both took their time getting back up. "Alright, maybe just a quick time-out," Catra conceded, shaking her head slightly.

"Where were we before you started being a shit?" Adora asked, hands on her knees.

"Myriad unknowable threats that await us in the outside universe," Catra reminded her.

"Right, right," Adora nodded.

"Have we gotten any messages from space yet? I haven't asked Entrapta."

Adora shook her head. "Not yet. I'm sure everybody's got their own problems, but I don't like radio silence." She took one last big breath and smiled over at Catra. "Time-in?" she asked, still a little breathless.

"Time-in," Catra smiled as they began to circle nearer. She waited for Adora to make the first move and fell into blocking blow after blow. She laughed when Adora snarled in frustration.

"Are you freaking kidding me?" she grunted before losing her patience and lunging.

Catra leapt up and sprang off of Adora's shoulder, kicking her forward so she sprawled onto the floor and laughing as she landed gracefully nearby. "Still falling for that one," she giggled.

Adora did some kind of spin on the ground that was admittedly very cool, and succeeded in kicking Catra's feet out from under her. She landed hard on her ass and they both clambered back up

to face each other at the same time. They put their fists up and began circling again, breathing hard.

Catra watched a lock of hair slip out of Adora's stupid poof thing and fall into her beautiful face, She smiled harder when Adora blew it up off it forehead, and it fell right back to where it'd been. "The princesses are getting nervous, aren't they?" Catra asked, her voice now free of sarcasm.

Adora sighed before making a few half-hearted jabs. "I think everybody's nervous, honestly." Catra threw an elbow, but Adora spun away from it. "I mean, it's not like we don't have enough to worry about here on Etheria without adding extraterrestrial issues to the list."

"Are *you* nervous?"

"I don't know, kind of," Adora scowled as she threw more fists that Catra had to block, though she was able to parry Catra's strikes in turn. "It's not like we're any readier for intergalactic bad guys than we were when Prime hit."

"Do you really think?" Catra asked as she ducked another blow and landed a punch square in Adora's gut. The other grunted and staggered back, wheezing again.

"Don't you?" she choked.

"Nah," Catra dismissed easily. "We've got Prime's old shit, we've got Entrapta, and we've got She-Ra. Etheria's going to be *just fine.* "

Adora smiled back as she doubled over, hand on a knee, lifting a finger to signal she needed another moment to catch her breath. "By the way," she wheezed, "I knew you weren't really trying last time we fought on the Velvet Glove, but how the heck did you get so freaking good at hand-to-hand combat? I can't beat you in a fight anymore without She-Ra."

Catra smiled wryly. “Hadn’t you realized? All that time you spent learning to beat opponents with a sword and superstrength, I spent learning to defeat enemies by any means necessary.”

Adora sobered, but Catra elbowed her playfully. “Calm down. It just means I can kick anybody’s ass on Etheria. That’s not such a bad trait in a girlfriend, is it?”

“Speaking of Hordak,” Adora said, smiling mischievously.

“Nobody mentioned Hordak,” she frowned.

“Catra,” Adora began, trying to hold back a stupid grin as her eyes sparkled with mischief. “You were thrown. By Hordak. Hordak picked you up and *tossed* you.”

“Shut up,” she mumbled.

“Honestly it’s probably what I would have done,” Adora said warmly. “Anything to bring you home safe.”

First, Catra paused at the word “home,” still finding it an uneasy, if attractive term to use in reference to herself and Adora. Then she imagined She-Ra tossing her like Hordak had, and to her own surprise an eyebrow quirked. “Actually, that gives me an idea,” she muttered, giving Adora a sly smile.

“Huh?” Adora asked, puzzled again.

“Just imagine it!” Catra said, growing increasingly excited the more she considered. “A whole encampment of enemies, settling down after dinner then- Waaagh! Catra! I come flying out of nowhere and take them by surprise!”

Adora began laughing. “Wait, that actually sounds kind of amazing.”

“Or landing on a super high wall so I can trip the mechanism for letting down a drawbridge, or… or if we needed to enter a high-tower room in secret, or… or…” She had her claws out, flexing her

fingers, tail swishing in excitement. “Holy shit I just remembered Melog can make us invisible.”

“Alright alright, I’m convinced!”

Catra grinned. “How far do you think She-Ra could throw me?”

Adora’s excitement waned as she thought about it. “Uh… far enough that we should probably have Glimmer around when we try it. She used to snatch people out of the air when I got a little carried away so they didn’t die upon impact,” she chuckled nervously.

“Fucking awesome.”

Adora laughed out loud, mouth open and face alight. She was so beautiful in that instant that it distracted Catra. She stared like a fool until Adora had quieted. “What?” she asked, wiping a tear from the corner of her eye.

“Nothing,” she answered, looking at the ground. On second thought, she added “you’re just really pretty is all.”

“Stop being a dork,” Adora chuckled shyly.

“I’m a dork? *I’m.* A dork?” Catra asked indignantly. She pounced without warning and Adora let her pin her down, gripping her wrists and kneeling on her legs. Catra laughed, smiled, and asked again, “Do you give up?”

Adora’s smile went softer. “If I do, can I keep touching you?”

Catra lowered herself flush against her and they kissed on the sparring mat. After a while, she tried cracking another joke. “So, when are you going to say ‘I told you so’?” Adora looked confused. “All those years, telling me you’d figured it out and the horde was evil? You were right, I was wrong. So when are you going to say I told you so?”

Adora sat up, pushing Catra back on her knees. She wasn’t laughing, but frowning darkly. “I can't say I told you so when I was wrong too.”

Catra shrugged. “Well, the Horde was doing evil and helping the princesses was the right thing to do, just like you said.”

“Yeah, sure, I was right about them and the war, but it blinded me to what you were going through."

Catra shrugged again and said, "I think that's a pretty common thing among teenagers."

Adora shook her head, frowning. "I never should have treated you like you weren't worth saving. Staying with the Horde was morally wrong, but you were hurting... I hurt you." She paused, but Catra didn't know what to say. Silence lengthened as Adora swallowed hard and her eyes grew glassy. "I can't imagine what it was like for you, after all those years, that I only realized the Horde was fucked up after I met Glimmer and Bow, even though I grew up watching how Shadow Weaver treated you."

Catra put her hands down and stood straighter, staring at Adora. "It made me angry. Really fucking angry." She hesitated for a second before continuing, "But the Horde was still... home. The only home we'd ever known. We had plans, Adora. I'd worked too hard to survive to just... pretend it didn't matter to me. The whole situation was confusing and fucked up and all the pressure from Shadow Weaver... and all the self-centered anger... I'm not sure if you could have reached me." She kept her face lowered but she looked up at Adora from underneath furrowed brows, trying to gage her thoughts.

"You were trying to find your own path make sense of things. And all you kept hearing from me was how everything you'd ever known was wrong, and that you needed to change everything about your life before you could matter in the new life I left you for." A stab of old grief and bitterness echoed through Catra's chest, but she ignored the feeling. "I did nothing to help you find

truth.” Adora pulled a face and looked away. “All I did was keep insisting I was right, which didn't help anyone. Sure, I told you so, but that doesn't make me feel any better about how things happened.”

Catra wasn't sure how to respond, so she stalled by slipping back into a fighting stance, which Adora matched. They bounced and circled for a few moments before Catra tried a jab. Adora blocked her but Catra grabbed her arm, jerked her back past her, then landed a knee in Adora’s back, sending her stumbling forward. “It wasn’t your job to make me see the light,” she finally said.

She tried kicking Adora’s legs out from under her but she managed to land in a kneel. Before Catra could strike again, however, Adora grabbed her ankles and yanked upward. Catra was knocked backward, falling fast, but Adora caught her before she hit the floor. She looked at her, holding Catra up with one arm and her knee. “It shouldn’t have had to be my job for me to want to help my best friend.”

Catra’s eyes watered. “Thank you.”

Adora helped her up and they stood close together. She decided to change the subject. “Are you going to visit me in Salineas?”

“Of course. Glimmer says she’ll take me to see you every day until Entrapta finishes the portal circuit between princesses.” Catra smiled to herself, pleased. “I really wanted to go with you, you know. To Salineas.” She waited for Catra to meet her gaze before continuing. “I know it’s been eating you, going there and facing what you did. I should be with you.”

“Go take care of Entrapta in the Northern Reach,” she told Adora. “I’ll be fine. All I have to do is show up, it’s not like I have to retake the city.” Even as she said it, her insides clenched with anxiety.

“Come on,” Adora said, starting to lead Catra away from the sparring mat. “I want a shower before lunch, but let’s stop by the

kitchens first. I'm hungry now."

"You're always hungry," Catra teased.

Just before they reached the door, however, Glimmer appeared in front of them with a burst of sparkles. Catra, who was still unused to this habit of hers, jumped back and hissed. "Entrapta says the star siblings are here, come on!" Then Glimmer grabbed them by their arms and all three were gone.

* * * * *

All is dark and quiet and warm. All except… are those muffled voices in the distance? There is something happening just beyond the clone's range of hearing, he's sure of it. But then something moves nearby, and his attention is pulled back to the voice in his ear. "My beloved little brother. So fresh. So pure. Completely up-to-date on all my core teachings." The clone feels the warmth that accompanies the touch of another living thing and resists the urge to lean into it. A gentle brush of knuckles along his cheekbone and the clone inhales deeply, slowly. He is laser-focused on the sound of the Exalted One's delicate footsteps and the barely-audibly rhythm of their Beloved's measured breathing. Then a pair of large palms cup his face, the points of two metal talons resting feather-light behind his ears. "I made you in my image, *I bestowed* myself upon you. I made you a fitting vessel for my glory, brother. You are perfection. You are beautiful."

A shrill screech rent the air and snapped Hordak violently back to consciousness. He bolted upright in bed with a strained grunt and raised his hands, but saw that he and Imp were alone in the small cavern bedroom. His winged beastie was beside himself, however, screeching and pointing toward the lab.

"Entrapta?" Hordak asked breathlessly as he forced himself to stand on aching joints. He grabbed his supervision cuff to make sure he hadn't missed messages and saw that it was barely dawn.

"No, stupid," Imp replayed Lonnie's voice as he flew on ahead of Hordak. He released the breath he'd been holding, but didn't stop or slow as he followed Imp through the empty lab. An ominous humming began to make itself apparent the nearer he drew to the barracks entrance.

The morning was only beginning to grow light, but the source of the noise and Imp's distress was immediately apparent. A small spacecraft was stabilizing on the air as it descended, sending concentric waves of energy flattening the grass beneath it as it did so. His first instinct was to reach for a weapon. Then he realized he was disarmed and swore. *Then* he realized that he also had no person or machine to help him into his accursed armor anyway, and he swore a bit louder. He was reduced to typing at his cuff to call Entrapta, but to his mild surprise and immense relief, she answered immediately.

"Hi Hordak! Don't worry, I recognize the ship, they're our friends! But also I have to go make sure nothing terrible is about to happen okay talk to you later byyyeee!" The screen cut and he looked back up at the ship, squinting as it landed. It was difficult to tell from his vantage point, but it looked like Queen Glimmer, Bow, Adora, Catra, and Entrapta had all approached the ship from the direction of the palace entrance. Their stances and mannerisms were slow and easy, however, and even when he heard the hiss of a door opening on the ship, the shouts that were exchanged sounded joyous rather than hostile.

After one last deep breath of fresh air and final confirmation that Bright Moon wasn't facing the threat of immediate invasion, he hurried back into the caves' entry hall to get out of the morning chill. His way forward was blocked, however, by Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio. They rubbed at bleary eyes and seemed to doubt whether or not they were actually seeing him standing there in the morning light. Their eyes wandered and he glanced down at himself to realize that he hadn't donned anything over his usual sleeveless dress.

Hordak looked back up at the three soldiers and took a deep breath to explain, but he couldn't think of a summary that fit into a sentence or two. He nearly said as much, changing tac as they continued to stare. But then he shut his mouth and pinched the bridge of his nose instead, realizing that he simply didn't care enough to waste time and effort on explanations. He grunted, waved a hand at them dismissively, then retreated to his bedroom. He would have stomped, but it was too early.

* * * * *

The first out of the ship was Starla and the siblings' owl, swooping above her. She offered a strained smile and waved at Adora, Bow, Gimmer, Entrapta, and Catra, who smiled and waved back in welcome. "Etherians!" she cried, not looking entirely overjoyed.

"Starla!" Glimmer shouted back, glad to see her regardless.

Their pet bird called as it circled. "Hi bird!" Entrapta called happily, producing a notebook and squinting up at the star siblings' flying companion.

Tallstar and Jewelstar were next to appear, however, and their manner was very different. They rushed Starla forward and down the ramp, Tallstar already calling. “You’ve got an incoming horde vessel!”

Jewelstar shouted next. “They aren’t answering calls and I have a bad feeling about this. We got here just in time to spot them and warn you.”

Adora transformed and Glimmer held up shimmering fists as the entire group looked up. A sharp, sleek, white vessel was lowering toward them, completely silent as it descended.

“What are you going to do?” Starla asked anxiously.

“Wait for them to make the first move,” Glimmer replied as other princesses gathered, read their mood, and prepared for a fight.

Adrenaline-flooded waits like these had always been something Catra hated. She flexed her claws nervously and felt others fidget around her. Then Wrong Hordak moved between them and walked to the front of the group, standing directly between the landing ship and the assembled Etherians. The horde ship was enormous compared to Darla or the star siblings’ vessel, and appeared featureless until landing-gear descended.

As the ramp lowered, a large hologram of an exhausted looking old woman with large eyes and long fingers in a gray robe appeared. “We managed to force them back and corner them on this ship. If you care so much about the clones, you can have ours.” The hologram ended abruptly after the unexpectedly terse message. As it winked out of sight and they could finally see into the darkened hull, however, they were met with a small crowd of calm, collected, and very angry-looking clones- all of whom had raised and glowing arm cannons pointed directly at them. Nearly everyone gasped and flinched, but Wrong Hordak flung out his arms and cried, “Hold your fire, General!”

The clone at the point of the clones' V-formation lowered his weapon slightly and glared at Wrong Hordak. Several tense moments passed as they regarded each other. The other clones kept their weapons raised. "Why is the hive-mind down?" the apparent leader asked.

Wrong Hordak took a few nervous breaths before loudly declaring, "Horde Prime is dead, and so is the hive mind, but we are safe here." The general visibly recoiled, ears dipping low and eyes popping wide. The others looked no less horrified. "Here we go again," Bow muttered wearily.

"Many of our brothers already live well here, and we can help you," Wrong Hordak continued hopefully. "Please, disarm yourselves and come with me."

It took what felt like minutes for the general to finally lower his weapon completely and take a deep breath. Catra recognized the surrender and began to calm, as did the others. The clones descended the ramp, detaching their cannons into a pile at Wrong Hordak's feet.

"Is this all of you?" Wrong Hordak asked, already somber.

"We fought to the last," answered the leader. The look of wide-eyed confusion on his face was making Catra feel nauseous. Wrong Hordak clasped the clone's shoulder in an expression of comfort. "If… if our exalted brother is gone, what shall we do with our dead?"

Bow walked forward then, slowly and cautiously, and stood beside Wrong Hordak, looking up at the towering predator and smiling kindly. "We bury fallen brothers with our dead. The grave is well cared-for."

The general seemed stunned into silence, but several other clones bowed and muttered their thanks.

"Aaaand crisis-averted!" Glimmer declared brightly, straightening up and clapping her hands as the newcomers followed Wrong

Hordak away meekly, still watching their surroundings with alert, darting eyes..

The star siblings exchanged their own stunned looks before turning back to the princesses. Tallstar again spoke first. “So, are your guys’ clones just, like, hanging out?”

Glimmer, Adora and Catra looked at each other before looking back at the confused siblings. “Um, yeah. What else would they be doing?” Adora asked.

“What everybody else is doing?” Jewelstar suggested. “Most are trying to wrestle the clones Prime left behind into detention camps, and we heard that some worlds executed theirs."

Catra heard several noises of distress around her and snorted derisively. "And create another bureaucratic hellscape for ourselves? No thank you, we’ll pass on organizing and manning bunch of camps." Several people sent her disapproving frowns, which she ignored.

"Well, now that you’ve taken these guys in, my guess is you’ll be getting a lot more,” Jewelstar said.

Glimmer clenched her jaw. “Etheria is committed to helping any victims of Prime’s, however we can,” she said firmly.

The star siblings exchanged another round of looks before Tallstar raised an incredulous eyebrow at Catra.

“They’re all this bad, yeah,” she replied with a half-smile. “Most Etherians have decided they love them, if you can believe it. Entrapta’s even fucking hers.”

Tallstar and Jewelstar both let their mouths fall open, but Starla clapped and squealed, “ *You found him* ?! Oh I’m so happy for you, Entrapta!”

“Like you don’t think they’re cute,” Adora muttered at her from the side of her mouth.

“Fuck off.”

“But they’re just so…” Tallstar hesitated, cringing slightly, “so creepy.”

Glimmer gasped loudly and covered Bow’s ears as both of them scowled, appalled. Glimmer hissed at them from next to Bow’s shoulder, “ *They. Are. Adorable* .”

“Right,” Tallstar said, unconvinced.

“Well it's wonderful to see you guys!” Adora said, changing the subject. “What brings you to Etheria?”

“Now that people are on top of things back home,” Starla said, smiling and stroking their owl, “we thought maybe you guys could use some inside information on your space neighbors.”

* * * * *

Adora didn’t have time to get her pre-lunch snack. They were all too busy discussing other worlds with the star siblings. All of the princesses had eventually filtered into the War Room, eager to assess threat levels. Glimmer had even insisted on retrieving Hordak, who was now skulking in the shadowy-est corner in the room, scowling as he listened intently. They learned of planets in Prime’s empire that were erupting into civil wars because of the power vacuum created by Prime’s death, many of whom blamed Etheria for destroying the peace they’d known under Prime’s distant rule. Some planets were beginning to register signs of

environmental or structural decay now that they'd lost Prime's technological support. Some planets were still in the middle of putting down combative clone cells, or else an economic crash or societal breakdown. Some planets had gone dark completely, and nobody seemed to know what was happening on their surfaces. But there were also many worlds who looked upon Etheria as heroes, and were overwhelmed with joy and gratitude for the end of Prime's tyranny. They had ready allies, should they need them.

Overall, it seemed to Catra that the news was good. Assholes would be a factor in life no matter what, but at least they had friends off-planet who were ready and willing to help them navigate their new dimension. What was far less assuring was how they'd moved from information about intergalactic peers to stressing the more immediate dangers their world faced. Much to Catra's frustration, the star siblings stressed again and again that every power on Etheria needed to be hyper-vigilant of threats like spies, predatory trade agreements, and of-fucking-course, viruses. Naturally, their dire warnings only reinforced the general opinion that they needed to develop anything they could learn from, including the stupid ass murder virus. She hated it, but even Catra had to admit they might be better off knowing than not.

Catra also began to strategize in her own imagination. Potentially belligerent powers striking in secret would naturally target their most important players- which at this point were Adora and Entrapta. They needed contingency plans, which meant building taskforces and delegation systems. They would also need to prioritize access to healthcare and disaster-response teams, to be on the safe side of things. A standing military seemed like a no-brainer, but something told her the princesses might not agree with her on this point.

They'd nearly made it to the point where they could break for lunch when Hordak had to pipe up. "Someone ought to remind you all that civil conflict is also a risk here on Etheria," he growled from the corner during a pause in their concluding conversation.

Mermista groaned loudly. “It’s like you consider it your hallowed duty to be a fucking buzzkill.”

Hordak didn’t react. “Most of the horde joined of their own free will. Many of your people are discontent with current paradigms of power.”

“What’s that supposed to mean?” Glimmer asked defensively.

Hordak raised a brow and looked around the room. “Do you really think the princess system is universally adored around Etheria? I assumed the overtly visible differences between kingdoms and staggering wealth inequality would be obvious.”

Glimmer began to sputter in indignation, but Mermista spoke up again, rolling her eyes heavily. “Hordak you’re a bitch and I hate you but *guys* ,” she rattled off her caveat of hating him like a mandatory disclaimer, “he has a point.”

“What do you mean? Surveys suggest that my people are very happy and content,” Perfuma protested.

“Yeah, but they’re also a pretty homogenous group, aren’t they?” Mermista replied. “You’re telling me that none of you have noticed how heavily aesthetics play into social stratification?” Nobody said anything. “Etheria is such a diverse planet, but you wouldn’t know it looking at the people of Bright Moon or Plumeria.”

Glimmer and Perfuma both looked stricken. Scorpia looked at them apologetically, but didn’t disagree with Mermista. “Now that we’re talking about it,” Swift Wind said, “monarchies definitely don’t work for everyone.”

“But Mermista is the princess of her kingdom,” Frosta said, sounding somewhat hurt and confused.

“Yeah, but Salineas is a city-state, plus it’s constitutional,” Swift Wind said.

“The freaking seas are run by pirates. They’re like, kind of built into the coastal economy. The entire financial structure of Salineas is grounded in small-time manufacturers of luxury goods and merchants, so yeah, we had to give them a say in how their city is run. And the only reason the monarchy has worked for as long as it has is because the royals of my line have literal magic powers over water, and because of it we’re the only ones that have to be tied to our social position. For the most part, everybody else does whatever they want.”

A few more quiet moments passed before Hordak spoke again. “There is a reason that I, with my power system that promised value in return for effort and loyalty and placed no value upon beauty, was able to keep a planet-wide civil war popular enough to remain active for decades.”

“I mean, free food, the best non-royal healthcare in Etheria, and the ever-present possibility for advancement *were* pretty nice, if not actual freedom,” Adora offered.

“Okay kids,” Catra broke in, “these are all great points, but is now really the time for a discussion on government ethics? I mean, a bunch of us are about to launch the reconstruction of the coast and other kingdoms, and the rest of us are going on a mission for science bullshit into the Northern Reach.”

“And is nobody else hungry?” Adora asked. “Seriously?”

Glimmer broke in and wrangled the group’s attention. “Alright, alright, Catra’s right. Lunch. I think we could all do with some lunch.” A general murmur of assent swept the room as chairs scraped and people stretched.

* * * * *

Food was served in the war room, Mermista had gone to prepare for the arrival of war criminals and Swift Wind had gone off to find Wrong Hordak. Entrapta had managed to convince Hordak to stay, however, and join in the meal. The scientist was now excitedly debriefing a table full of people who were struggling to keep up, while Hordak occasionally translated points that had gone over the rest of their heads.

"We have communication points rapidly becoming hubs in every kingdom around Etheria and I'm working on setting up a portal in every kingdom to set up a fast-travel network between political centers. Our scientists and engineers can expand outward from there to provide wider access around Etheria, and it's a complete *blast* working with them already. We're learning so much from the techy clones and everybody's learning to work together firmly rooted in lingual communication so that we have an easier time crossing behavioral differences! It's so exciting!"

Bow interjected with an excited smile. "We're nearly ready to start doing the same thing in various settlements around Etheria, studying what's there to start compiling global data. It'll be a great way to build relationships between various scientific communities, which will be useful for tackling all this weird new stuff happening with wild magic. That stuff is making science… extremely challenging." His face fell into a frown.

"We still have no idea what we're messing with and it's absolutely *thrilling* ." Entrapta enthused.

"So what's the goal you're working toward?" Micah asked politely.

"For the most part, I'm just trying to get us to a point where they can do without me so I can move on to *space things* !" She ducked behind raised fists and suppressed a squeal of delight before popping back up to continue. "Which I am much more excited about."

"Yeah we're excited for you to work on space stuff, too," Adora chimed in. Catra recalled what she'd said about the princesses getting worried about extra-terrestrial crises.

"Aaaah I can't wait! The only thing is all this magic is complicating the science a little bit, like Bow said. We can't figure out any of the new rules and it's quite a challenge. I have a feeling we can learn more from the First Ones on that; they knew how to make magic and tech work together. And now that I've figured out what's happening with the runestones and the heart, I can devote more attention to new possibilities in techno-organics!" She shook her fists and wiggled in place, utterly ecstatic. Hordak's ears flicked back. "Between Hordak and Adora and me, I've already got *lots* of subject material to work with."

"What do you mean, Adora and you?" Glimmer asked. "Do you have body upgrades or something?"

"Oh I don't actually have a clue how it works, but something about the magic in my line has to do with tech. The family legend says something about getting it from the First Ones ages ago and I'm guessing that has something to do with it because it's certainly not wild magic."

Everybody around the table stared. "You have magic in your line?" Micah asked.

"You never asked about the hair, did you?" Hordak asked the assembled Etherians, sounding distinctly annoyed.

Catra looked around at Scorpia and Adora nodding, but otherwise guilty faces. "I just thought that it was only princesses with magic powers that had access to Etheria's magic," Bow said.

"Not at all!" Entrapta said cheerfully. "How do you think Double Trouble shape-shifts?"

There was a round of thoughtful nodding and murmuring. "So your hair is magic?" Micah asked.

“I’m not sure what it is. It’s certainly unique to my family line, but it’s difficult to pin down exactly what’s going on with us. I've been trying to understand it forever, especially after Hordak’s armor. And not just my hair, it’s my whole system.”

“Like what else?” Perfuma asked, curious.

“Well, we have unusually long lifespans, for one.”

“Hang on, how old are you?” asked Glimmer.

“You don’t know how old she is?” growled Hordak, crossing his arms, lip curling. More sheepish glances were exchanged between princesses, and this time Catra even felt a little bad. He waited. When nobody answered and Entrapta looked somewhat crestfallen, he continued. “Entrapta is thirty three.”

“No way,” said princess Netossa, joining in for the first time. I thought you were in the same generation as… I don’t know, maybe Scorpia, if not Glimmer and the others. How do you look so young?”

She shrugged. “It’s hereditary, I suppose. Also I didn’t get a lot of sun growing up. Or ever.”

“She’s also extremely durable,” Hordak said, arms still crossed. “Did any of you ever bother to ask why she records everything she does?”

“Ooh, ooh, I know this one,” Scorpia said as if they were students in a classroom. “It’s so that when she blows herself up and loses her memory of the day’s work, she still has a record of it!”

“She does weather sizeable electric shocks pretty often,” Catra said thoughtfully.

“And she does support her full body weight with just half of her scalp all the time,” Spinnerella added.

Hordak grunted.

“Wait, but I thought you weren’t into biology,” Scorpia said, looking over at Entrapta with a cocked head.

“Oh! I’m not! Or at least I never was before. But I’m *definitely* into xenobiology.” Catra caught Hordak blush slightly. “And besides- I’m a scientist! I needed to get a handle on the concrete before I get more theoretical with the magic stuff.

The group fell into a comfortable silence as they ate, until Micah spoke again. “So, I know it hasn’t been very long and we’re all really busy, but has anybody found any fun postwar hobbies yet?”

For the most part, people offered derisive snorts and incredulous head-shaking. “I have,” Catra said.

“Oh yeah?” Adora looked at her, puzzled.

Catra nodded and wiped her mouth, making an affirmative noise. “My new hobby is scandalizing Hordak.”

Several people laughed and Perfuma smiled a gentle, “hey!”

“Relax, it’s nothing mean-spirited.” This time several eyebrows raised, waiting for an explanation. “Here, watch this,” she said, pulling Bow’s datapad toward herself.” She continued talking breezily as she tapped at the screen. “Plus it’s so easy these days. All you have to do is mention something about him that’s not negative. It doesn’t even have to be direct.” An idea hit her, and she searched ‘cute bat’. She tapped on the first link that popped up and opened an article on bats’ role as pollinators. She froze, however, when a giant cover picture took up the screen of the datapad. It depicted a bat in flight, extending a tongue that was more than half its body-length into a purple flower. Hordak gasped and snatched the pad away from her with his long reach, scrolling frantically. “Instant regret,” she muttered, trying to blink the image away.

“Serves you right,” Hordak hissed at her under his breath.

“Ooh, what is it?” Glimmer asked, craning her neck to see the screen in Hordak’s hands.

“Clones like flowers,” he said hurriedly, and held up a different picture on the screen. This one was of a bat covered in pollen and looking for all the world like it was grinning.

Catra could tell most of the people there were suspicious, but Perfuma cried out in delight before anything else could be said. “Oh my goodness! That is so cute!”

“You like flowers?” Catra sneered, finally recovering some composure.

Hordak scowled and replied in a defensive grumble while Entrapta beamed up at him. “Clones’ senses are constantly battered by conflicting stimuli,” she began to explain, looking back down at her small-portioned lunch. “It offers added perception when they have access to enough adrenaline to focus, and contributes impetus to establish quiet, orderly conditions.” She selected a miniature quiche and took a bite, chewing thoughtfully.

Hordak continued, “Sensory attractions, such as flowers, overwhelm the senses in pleasant ways, which provides a reprieve from the constant sensory input.”

“Hordak,” Catra said suspiciously. “Do you get high on flowers?”

“No,” he said loudly.

Perfuma clapped her hands. “I can’t wait to take my group of clones to Plumeria! Oh, it’s going to be so fun! Scorpia, oh my goodness my people are going to just *adore* them! Once they get used to them.”

Perfuma and Scorpia lapsed into animated discussion about the clones and Catra tucked into her meal. She focused on the flavors as she chewed and tried not to think of going to Salineas or Adora going after the virus up north.

"Don't blow it up."

Chapter Summary

> Catra, Hordak, and Double Trouble are taken to Salineas as war criminals and the gang meets what awaits them in the Northern Reach.

Chapter Notes

> Disclaimer: Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization and post-war angle. So uh, expect the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you're dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anyone for anything.

Catra breathed in the sea air and scowled, hunching in on herself and eyeing the water around them warily.

Before they'd left, Adora had pulled her aside to check on her yet again, but she'd grabbed the blonde's face and fixed her with a stern glare instead. "I want you guys to *be fucking careful* up there," she'd said gravely. "That virus is no fucking joke, and we have no idea how the magic blast might have affected it. You and the whole team, watch your backs."

"Okay, okay," Adora had said, soothingly.

" *Promise* , Adora."

"I promise." She'd said, smiling and pressing their foreheads together.

Now Catra waited with Double Trouble and Hordak on the top deck of Mermista's royal ship, where Glimmer had dropped them off. Mermista talked seriously with her advisors a few yards away, but the ocean was too loud for her to eavesdrop. Instead, she stalked over to Horak, tail puffed out and arms crossed tight.

“Can you hear what they’re saying?”

He shook his head.

Catra squinted at his face and realized the corners of his mouth were slightly tighter than usual. “You’re almost smiling. What’s up?”

“It was gratifying to see Entrapta so excited about her work,” he answered freely, surprising her with his openness. “I look forward to hearing about her scientific exploration in the Northern Reach.”

Catra frowned. “You never saw that virus.”

He frowned, too. “No, I didn’t. Your worry is concerning.”

“Yeah well it should be.” She huffed and flexed her crossed arms. “When that thing had hold of Adora, she had absolutely no control. Like, none. It was like she became evil She-Ra or some shit. Legitimately scary.”

He grunted in a low tone and continued frowning.

“But,” she conceded with a sigh, “I also get the whole ‘not crossing the girlfriend’ thing.” That made him almost-smile again.

After a few minutes of silence, Hordak spoke without looking at her. “You are also agitated by this journey, are you not?”

It was way too weird that he was asking about her feelings. But then again, maybe he was as desperate as she was not to fixate on confronting some of the worst of their crimes. “I guess I don’t handle crowds as well as I used to.” He looked down at her, and from his expression she could tell he already knew what she was talking about. “Like the crowd at the memorial was fucking terrible at first, but we were also with the entire squad and nobody was acting violent toward us. I have a hunch it might be a little different at Salineas.” She paused for a moment, thinking. “At least they won’t be clones. No offense.”

"None taken. I understand being a bit raw. Mirrors have been difficult for me at times."

"Yikes. I didn't think about that."

He shrugged. "I'd imagine it's more difficult for clones who have not yet begun to individualize."

"Individualize?"

"They are beginning to develop their own unique physical characteristics, not unlike my eyes and hair. Entrapta hypothesizes that it has something to do with wild magic."

Catra nodded and looked away. "That's… actually really cool. It'll be nice when they've got new outfits, too."

Hordak looked over at her and tilted his head slightly. "You fought well against groups of clones at the end of the war. Did crowds start bothering you come peacetime?

"Yeah, I guess so." She said. After a few heavy moments, she spotted Double Trouble lounging luxuriously on a railing across the deck and watched them pose for the crew's stolen glances as she continued. "Plus, I mean, we were fighting for our lives, you know?" He nodded. "And I've never had a problem fighting for my life. But now… now there's just *no* fighting. So… it's just supposed to be my new normal?" She shuddered. "Whatever. I just have to hold my shit together long enough for Mermista's speech and to officially accept her offer for reconciliation."

"Speaking of the memorial," Hordak began. Catra felt her ears draw back in trepidation. "I hope you are recovering well enough."

Oh. That wasn't so bad. "I mean, any time I'm not sparring or fucking I kind of just want to die. But all things considered that seems pretty normal." He nodded vacantly.

They shared a comfortable silence for the remainder of the ride, listening to the ocean and muddled sounds of Mermista's

conversation with her advisers, then her guards. When she was finished, she raised her arms at her sides and Hordak felt the boat lift several feet and gain significant speed. Catra was torn between being thrilled by the speed and being agitated by the ocean, and clung tight to the woodwork.

They dropped their speed as soon as Salineas came into view from around a rocky cliff. The gate had been hastily repaired with She-Ra's help, but most of the city still lay in ruins. Catra's gut twisted and her heart began to beat faster as the devastated city grew clear. After observing how badly damaged they'd left the beautiful old capitol, she noticed the predictable crowd waiting on the docs. Hordak and her stared, listening to the sound of chanting grow louder. It was difficult to tell, but from a distance she could make out a sign that said 'No Horde in Salineas!' and another that read 'Hang Hordak'. She wasn't surprised, but felt a massive surge of adrenaline regardless. She gripped at the ship's railing and began to breath heavily, willing herself to stay calm.

At that moment, Mermista walked over to them, royal airs in place. "Alright you three, below deck," she commanded.

* * * * *

The three war-criminals obeyed, and Hordak heard Catra mutter something about other ex-horde not having to be there for the hard part. He glanced at the back of her head as she walked ahead of him and noticed that her shoulders were hunched and her tail was bushed out. Double Trouble voiced his observation. "Are you alright honey? You don't look too good."

Catra crossed to a porthole and gazed at the part of the crowd she could see from their vantage point. "I'm gonna be fucking fine." There was a barely-audible quaver in her voice. "It's just

that the last experience I had with a chanting crowd was kind of shitty."

Double Trouble made a strained noise of sympathy. "Are you two gonna be okay with this?" they asked. They could hear Mermista start some kind of speech from outside.

"Of course," Hordak dismissed, trying to keep his distress from showing. Catra didn't answer. He looked over at her and saw that Catra was clutching the sill of the porthole and breathing hard. "Catra, what is the matter?"

"There's too many of them," she hissed. "I can't… I couldn't… I don't want to be surrounded. I couldn't, I," she made a choking sound. "I don't think I can do this," she whispered, voice shaking.

Hordak stared at her, considering their options. He was having a hard time focusing, however. He couldn't stop picturing what he could remember of what had happened to her. He hadn't been present for her reconditioning, but he was one of the clones chanting at her purification ceremony. Of course, *of course* two guards had to stomp down to their level just then. "Princess Mermista is ready to receive you into Salineas. Come with us."

Hordak and Double Trouble looked between Catra, who was wild-eyed and sweating hard, and the guards, who didn't look pleased. "We beg pardon," Hordak said, "Catra just needs a moment…"

"Silence!" Commanded a guard. "I will not hear your voice, murderer."

Hordak closed his mouth and clenched his jaw, but Double Trouble spoke up. "It's the crowd. After what Prime did to her, she…"

The guards ignored them. "You will answer the Princess' summons voluntarily or by force," one said. They began to advance.

Hordak stepped between the two opposing sides and stood as tall as he could, narrowing his eyes and baring his teeth. The guards

stopped in their tracks. “You will not touch her,” he said in a silky, threatening tone.

“Wha… What are we supposed to do? The princess…”

“I do not have a device to contact Queen Glimmer, so you two will return to Princess Mermista and tell her we need Adora on this ship right now. When she arrives, Double Trouble will pose as Catra and enter Salineas with the Princess and I in her stead. Understood?”

The guards looked at eachother and Double Trouble stepped to stand beside Hordak, hands on their hips. “Alright, don’t cause any trouble,” one warned lamely as they turned and ascended to the main deck.

Hordak turned back to Catra, who had her hands fisted in her hair. “It’s fine. I’m gonna be fine… I just… there’s too many of them. Too many eyes on me.”

“I understand,” he said.

Her head snapped up and she opened her mouth with an angry expression, no doubt to tell him that no, he did not understand. Her words died on her lips and she closed her mouth. After a moment, she simply nodded and curled up on the ground.

“Catra?” He heard Adora’s voice from above them.

“Down here!” Double Trouble called back.

Adora ran down to them so fast that Hordak thought she’d tripped and automatically raised an arm to catch her, but she didn’t need it. She was on her knees next to Catra in a second, hands hovering over Catra. “What’s wrong?” She turned sharply to stare down Hordak. “Prime?” He nodded and she swore. “Catra, can I touch you?”

Catra reached forward with such meekness that it made Hordak feel as if he were intruding upon something indecent, and Adora

wrapped her up in a tight embrace without hesitation. As soon as she was folded against Adora, she burst out into heaving, broken sobs. Hordak startled when Glimmer walked past him, and he heard the two guards descend behind her.

"Come on guys, let's get out of here," Glimmer said gently before teleporting them away.

Hordak turned to Double Trouble, who had already become Catra. Together they followed the guards up onto deck, into full view of a large crowd with signs and livid expressions. They'd stopped chanting, but they booed and hissed as Hordak and Fake Catra approached Mermista, who was standing with a stoic expression and folded arms.

Fake Catra fell in behind Hordak as two more guards stepped forward to flank Mermista with their spears held at a threatening angle. Mermista lifted her chin and spoke to him loudly. "Lord Hordak, I have allowed you to return to this place, unwelcome as you are, so that you might yet contribute to our mission of undoing the terrible damage you have done. You work for us. Got it?" He nodded before she turned to a guard. "'Kay, give it to me." The guard produced a feather duster and handed it off. She turned back to face him and continued. "Kneel, Lord Hordak, Scourge of Etheria." He obeyed, and she touched the feather duster to both of his shoulders. "Rise, Just Hordak, Servant of Salineas!"

Hordak stood slowly and bowed to her, stooping low and bearing the back of his neck before straightening back up "Not bad, not bad. You do have presence," Double Trouble murmured from behind him. It started slowly, but the crowd awarded Mermista with a loud applause as she continued to look between Hordak and Fake Catra.

After a while, Mermista heaved a huge sigh and motioned them to follow her. They walked behind her, book-ended by guards, all the way up to the palace. When they were inside, out of public view, Mermista dismissed the two guards and lead the other two down

a spacious hall before speaking. “Alright, horde scum, listen up. Hordak, you’re going to work with my engineers, architects, urban planners, and community representatives. You’re going to deal with aaalll their bullshit and make them work together, and you’re going to do it without being an asshole. Catra,” she paused, “I don’t really know what you can do. But be helpful, or else I’m going to make you do something shitty.”

“I’m actually Double Trouble,” they said, turning back into themselves.

“Oh yeah, well the same instructions go for you too.”

“Can do.”

“Hordak, I put a lab in the basement for you. Don’t blow it up. There’s a bedroom of some kind down there too, I guess. Catra, you’re going to-”

“Double Trouble,” they reminded gently.

“Double Trouble, you get a guest room, but it’s the smallest one,” she said, making a face at them. She stopped near an inconspicuous door and opened it, gesturing vaguely between Double Trouble and the room. “Got it? ‘Kay, great. Go figure your shit out, I’m going to dump Hordak off in the basement.”

The cellars were an enormous, cavernous space. They seemed to be carved into primordial sea caves, and were filled with pillars cut from the solid rock, natural trickles of water flowing down spots of the raw stone walks, or creating dripping sounds in the shadows as they fell from cracks above. Criss-crossing in a dense web above them were large pipes and ducts of various purpose, occasionally rattling or hissing. It was all a bit dim and dank, and he rather liked the place.

The lab part of things was mostly empty space with a some basic equipment to start with, and included a large table for meetings. He walked over to the table to look at the teetering stacks of files

and paperworks already set out there. Unfolded on top was a proposed diagram for a new city-wide sewage system.

“We’re working on the sewers right now, so look over that first. I’ll bring my engineers in for a meeting in a couple of hours.” He laughed softly and shook his head. “What?” she asked aggressively.

“Impressive,” he said.

“What, your own sewer system?” she asked in a snide tone.

“This is your sewer system.”

“That we based off yours.”

“I can see that,” he confirmed, back to frowning. “What impressed me about it was that you’ve made several improvements upon my own innovations.”

She rolled her eyes. “My engineers did the work.”

“And who gave them the suggestions they worked from? Did you have AWOL horde engineers stowed away in Salineas I was unaware of?”

She huffed and crossed her arms at him. “Yeah well, our system was really outdated and we were having problems, so like, I knew what to spot or whatever.”

He tried a small smile again. At least this time she didn’t scowl back. He thought to himself that maybe, just maybe, he was starting to develop a sense of this whole ‘decency’ thing. “Thank you for giving me this opportunity to participate in reconstruction,” he said solemnly.

She raised an eyebrow. “Like I said, don’t blow anything up. And remember I’m watching you on your cuff thing.” With that, she turned around and left him alone in the lab. “Don’t fuck it up,” she called before she was out of sight.

* * * * *

Catra was already starting to calm down by the time they regained their bearings on the landing of Bright Moon Palace. She began to take deep, consciously measured breaths and did her best to resist the shame that burned through her veins once the panic had abated. She patted Adora's arm to show that she was ready to take some space, and looked up to see that Glimmer was kneeling to make sure she was fine. Melog appeared next to the queen, offering their strange echoing mewles in concern.

"There you are," Catra said, throwing her arms around them to hug the alien beast tightly. "Where the hell have you been?" They answered with a round of meowing. Apparently, they'd been exploring Etherian magic and making friends with a strange old woman named Razz.

"What happened?" Glimmer asked.

"Crowds," Catra answered simply. The other two women left it at that.

"Okay, well, I have to get back to the northern reach, Frosta's sciency people said something crazy happened when they tried to get that chip… disc.. virus thing. I'll get you if I need you Adora, okay?

"Wait!" Catra blurted out. Glimmer looked at her, puzzled. "Can we come with you?" The other two looked at each other, exchanging their 'what should we do as friends?' look. "Please don't make me stay here and be useless."

Glimmer deflated. “Alright. Let’s go.”

Catra popped up and helped Adora and Glimmer to their feet. They exchanged one last look, nodded, and then they were off again.

The first place they landed was the catwalk above the drilling pit. They looked around to see a lot of white nothing, before several heads in fur-trimmed hoods popped up over a snow berm.

“At the bottom of the pit!” One of them called. Immediately afterward, they heard Entrapta’s warbling scream drift up from below them. Without further ado, glimmer teleported them there. The three of them materialized on an icy floor and looked around just in time to see a gigantic black tentacle swiping through the air at them. They screamed and teleported just in time to avoid it, and Catra roused herself to see they were ducked behind some wreckage at the bottom of the mining pit. She looked up and saw the distant circle of light that marked the top of the pit and registered the sounds of fighting around them. Once she’d got her bearings, she looked up over the torn metal that was their shelter to finally see what Entrapta and Bow were so busy dodging.

“What the fuck is that thing?!” Glimmer screamed. Catra wondered the same. In the middle of the circular space squatted a huge, living, angry *something* . The first thing it made her think of was the monster the First One’s had left guarding the heart. The one that had almost killed Adora. But this thing was definitely different. It was jet black and looked… slimey. It didn’t have a single head in the center, either, but many upon long necks that whipped and thrashed in among a sea of thick tentacles. The ground around it looked like a kind of swamp of red goo, sprouting small versions of its giant black tentacles. Something about it seemed plantlike, but she’d never seen a plant like this, not even in the Crimson Waste.

It was difficult for Catra to be sure because everything was moving so fast, but it looked like there were more than five heads and all of them had multiple red eyes and very large teeth. It was

an animal, then, which meant she knew its hypothetical weak spots. She watched as Bow somehow landed a shot at one of the waving heads and a net burst to wrap around it. Within moments, the snapping jaws had torn through the filament and the shreds fell usefully into the sticky-looking soup below. Melog was red and bristling, growing as large as they could before charging. Catra took her chance and sprinted across the space, behind Bow, up off the wall, and launched into the thick of the creature's waving appendages. She managed to grab onto the back of a head, sinking her claws into it's thick skin to secure her grip. It barely seemed to notice her, but that didn't last long. When she slashed out it's three eyes with one swipe, the head shrieked and thrashed in agony, slinging thick gobs of glowing red blood as it did so.

The head finally managed to throw Catra and sent her bouncing across the floor. She tried to tuck and roll, but she still landed hard. She looked up to see Glimmer sending her ridiculous glittery blasts from the staff she carried and Bow shooting arrow after arrow, few of which did lasting damage. Adora dodged tentacles, slashing at them with a combat knife instead of She-Ra's sword, becoming a blood-covered mess as she did so. Then Catra's wild gaze was drawn to Entrapta as she was lifted into the air by a foot, shouting at the monster all the while. She held more or less still as she was brought near a yawning mouth and Catra stifled an urge to scream, but then Entrapta thrust a pigtail wrapped around her circular saw into the head's mouth. She flinched away from the burst of gore she created, teeth and chunks of flesh bouncing off her along with a dense spray of blood. She was finally dropped and fell straight into the eerie red goop with a viscous splash and a sickening 'bloop' sound.

As Catra ran for another attack, Adora was picked up in a similar manner. "Adora!" she shouted, but she needn't have worried. When the head that focused on her opened its mouth wide, she caught its jaws in both hands and forced it wider. Before it could gather its bearings, Adora gave a grunting cry and forced her hands apart, breaking the heads lower jaw with a loud pop. The bottom half of its mouth dropped and swung limply, and Adora fell

into the gooey red fluid just as Entrapta was making her way back to dry land.

Melog snapped and slashed at the tentacles that targeted them, holding their portion of the beast's attention while she tried to pinpoint a head to target. Then a hollow pang of anxiety made her stomach flip. There were definitely more functioning heads than when she'd arrived. It must've been regrowing them. "Glimmer!" she shouted as she dodged a whipping tentacle. "We need backup!"

The Queen swore vociferously but disappeared. Catra dodged another tentacle just as one caught Bow square in his side, knocking him across the room so that he hit the ice wall hard. He crumpled to the floor, and after a few seconds she was relieved to see him stir feebly. Then Catra felt a tentacle wrap around her arm and was jerked forward. Her head snapped back and she grunted in pain as she was lifted into the air. She slashed desperately at the slick black limb wrapped around her arm, digging through flesh until she was dropped. She sputtered and whined as she splashed into the mysterious slime below.

Catra stayed down for a moment and squinted at the base of the creature rather than its heads. What might have been it's chest/stomach was glowing red and see-through, appropriately gross for the circumstances. What drew her nearer was the dark triangular shape that was suspended within. She wondered if Bow still had an exploding arrow, but before she could dash to see, the entire beast froze in motion, encased in glowing pink energy. Catra turned as fast as she could in the red syrup and saw Glimmer and Micah working magic together, expressions strained and worried.

"Hold it a little longer," Catra shouted as she turned and started slashing viciously toward the shape in the glowing center of the monster. It took a minute of frenzied shredding and fighting through tough gelatinous matter, but before Micah and Glimmer lost control, she was able to thrust her arm deep into its body,

seize the triangular tech in her fist, and rip it out with a final snarl.

Looking at it, she could see that it was the broken pieces of the virus star, held together with what looked like organic sinew. She snapped back to attention when the beast in front of her groaned and shuddered in its death throes, then began to slowly collapse. She struggled backward through the mysterious swamp and managed to avoid being crushed as the massive body fell, and was relieved to see that nobody else was seriously hurt, either. Glimmer went to Bow, who was gripping his shoulder, and Entrapta helped pull Adora and Catra back to solid ground. The three women struggling in goo were so covered in gore and slime that they appeared to have been dunked in crimson paints, and they continuously spat and wiped at their eyes.

Once her feet were free, Catra didn't hesitate to cross to a chunk of ice on the floor and tilted the tech up against it. Then she stomped, snapping it in two with her heel, and breathed a sigh of relief. "So the engineers that found this virus just… forgot to mention the giant monster?" She asked, still breathing hard.

"Apparently what they thought were messed up plants *became* a giant monster when they tried to retrieve the disc," Entrapta replied merrily.

"Need me to heal your shoulder?" Adora asked Bow.

"Nah, I just got a bad knock, that's all."

Catra picked up the pieces of tech and walked them over to Entrapta, who took them eagerly. Then she planted her hands on her hips and sighed with satisfaction. "Good fight, team."

* * * * *

After the tense meeting with visibly terrified and hateful engineers, Hordak had been left to study and plan. He couldn't help but hope that he'd see Entrapta before the next day, but knowing her, she may well be working on her virus through the night. For his part, he'd poured over diagrams and blueprints for hours, until the evening grew late. Eventually he set the work aside and took a moment to rub his temples and clear his mind. He wasn't yet done for the day though, and crossed to the main workstation before he could relax and lose initiative.

Earlier in the day, he'd overheard a couple of the engineers at the end of the meeting, talking about the international initiative to collect and record memories. One of them had volunteered for her own interview, and apparently they were starting to become available for public review. Hordak tapped at the large screen before him until he was looking at a long list of recorded interviews. Some were only audio, most were visual recordings. He reached out to select one, but hesitated.

He didn't want to watch any of them. He didn't want to hear the voices of his victims. He didn't want to come face to face with the consequences of his choices as expressed in personal terms. But he knew he must. How could he ever complete his contrition if he didn't even know what he was sorry for? No, unpleasant as the learning process may be, he needed to know what had happened, and he was done being a coward. So he selected a recording, started it, and settled into soldering an experimental circuit board while he listened.

“All wars that last long enough become childrens’ wars."

Chapter Summary

> The BFS take Catra back to Salineas and get ready to take on their next challenges. (Catradora smut ahead)

Chapter Notes

> Disclaimer: Story continuation, but like, definitely from a post-cult/post-victimization and post-war angle. So uh, expect the horrible shit that goes with those themes, and be careful if you’re dealing with stuff. Take care of yourselves and remember that you don't have to forgive anyone for anything.

The best friend squad sans Entrapta lounged in Adora’s room at Bright Moon, bathed and fed and enjoying each other’s company. Melog was laying on the floor, rolled over onto their back with their feet in the air, purring to match Catra while Bow scratched their belly. Adora was slouching in her seat and scratching lazily at her side with one hand, and scratching lazily at Catra’s scalp with the other. Catra, for her part, was content to lay across Adora’s lap and purr gently, listening to Glimmer describe big ideas for their postponed road trip. She’d gotten so excited that she was now standing up, gesturing grandly as she rhapsodized at them.

“It’s annoying that we’ve got to do all this work before we travel, but we’re learning so much! Imagine what it’ll be like for people to be able to return to their ruined home planets, watch She-Ra heal everything, then on top of that we can help them plan to get back on their feet?!” Glimmer exclaimed, holding her fists before her in a vague reflection of the heroics she was scheming.

“Actually, though,” Catra agreed. “This reconstruction shit is where the real work is. Well,” she glanced up at Adora, "for most of us, I mean.”

“No I’m with you,” Adora interjected. "I'm the only fix-it-quick person we've got and I've never used the sword more."

“I’m so excited! It’s going to feel so great to be able to help new people, and once the universe sees what we’re about, maybe they won’t be mad at us anymore,” Bow suggested optimistically. Catra kept her doubts to herself.

Glimmer was still reveling in her excitement. “And Entrapta can learn about space things and teach people how to make cool robots and prosthetics and stuff, and Bow can help them learn new tech if they need it, and I…” her words and expression faltered for a moment before she continued, “I can teach them about punching things! Super hard!”

“You’re also a good queen, Glimmer,” Bow said. “You’ve got a lot to offer when it comes to leadership.”

“And learning how to channel magic,” Adora offered. “We can both help with that.”

“And Catra…”

Glimmer paused for a second and Catra broke in, “I can teach them how to be conniving bastards.”

Glimmer suppressed a snort and Bow gave her a reproachful look, but Adora spoke gently, looking down at Catra. “You can teach people about persisting against tall odds, and being strong enough to change.”

Catra smiled up at Adora and squeezed her thigh before Bow spoke up. “We should also bring someone to represent the clones, since we’re already going to be doing the whole diplomacy thing.”

“Do you think Wrong Hordak would want to come? He did well with us last time we were out there,” Catra offered.

“I bet he would,” said Glimmer.

"I think he would, too, but he'd be so homesick" Bow added. "He and Swift Wind are *hardcore* best friends."

"Entrapta's going to want Hordak to come," Adora said. Conversation stalled as they considered the notion.

"Honestly? I think I'd be fine with it," Glimmer finally said. Bow shrugged and nodded.

"It'd be nice to have more than one scientist, and a second diplomat- grim as he is," Catra suggested. "Plus with that armor, he's pretty good in a fight. I'm not sure I could've beat him when we fought if I hadn't torn the crystal out both times." She noticed a frown cross Adora's face above and immediately felt a flush of shame. The next second, frustration joined the shame because she didn't regret what she'd done at all, just that she'd said it in front of Adora. Melog gave an annoyed, short meow from the ground.

Bow let out a huge yawn, which passed to Glimmer, which made Adora and Catra yawn too. "I need sleep," he groaned.

"Come on," Glimmer said, getting up to hoist him to his feet. "You're working with Entrapta tomorrow, you're going to need a fully rested brain. Are you guys still going to spend the night in Salineas?"

Catra sat up and nodded, feeling Adora hoist herself onto her feet behind her. Melog rolled over and shook out their mane before walking over to lean against her. Adora's hand slipped into Catra's and they looked to Glimmer, who reached for them with Bow's arm slung over her shoulders before they all teleported.

They landed in a darkened Throne Room, and for a moment Catra thought it was empty. "Mermista?" Adora called.

"Here," came a miserable-sounding reply from the throne.

"What's up?" Bow asked as they slowly approached her. She was slumped in her seat and rubbing at her eyes wearily.

“Ugh, nothing. It’s just been a fucking day,” she groaned, looking up and pulling a face while she blinked hard and refocused her eyes. Melog walked over and bumped their nose against her knee, and she stroked their head half-heartedly.

“You mentioned you were worried about how your people would handle this,” Glimmer said.

“Did you do the feather duster thing?” Catra asked.

Mermista sighed. “Yeah, they definitely loved that. And to give credit where it’s due, Hordak and Double Trouble played their parts well with the kneeling and the bowing. Flamboyant bitches.”

“Buuut…” Bow prompted.

“But…” she stalled, looking a little lost. She rubbed her hands over her face and sighed, and when she spoke again her voice was much softer. “My people are so, *so* angry... How could they not be?” She shook her head sadly before her eyes shined over and she squeezed them shut.

“Should I be worried about assassins in the closet?” Catra offered a nervous laugh, but she was only half joking.

Mermista shook her head and started rubbing at her eyes again. “No, they’re way more focused on Hordak than you, and I think I’ve gotten them to trust me for the time being. But I still spent the rest of my day listening to fucking *awful* stories and teling my distrought subjects why I’ve welcomed their worst nightmare to stay in my freaking palace. Although, most of them weren’t at the memorial, so I could just kind of rip off your speech, Glimmer. Thanks for that.”

Glimmer nodded and smiled. "Happy to help."

“Where’s Sea Hawk?” Bow asked.

She rolled her eyes but Catra caught a muscle in her neck twitch as she clenched her teeth. ”He’s been so, like… I don’t know.

Hollow?" She swallowed and her eyes grew overbright again before she blinked the excess moisture away. "It's way too weird for him to be so quiet. The memorial really messed him… messed us up. I told him he shouldn't sit through my people's complaints and testimonies if he wasn't feeling up to it, so he didn't. I'm sure he's waiting in my rooms with fucking bells on, though."

"So your people don't even want Hordak's help with reconstruction?" Adora asked.

"Not. At. All." Mermista stated slowly. "Honestly I… wait, where's Entrapta?"

"She's up north doing science shit," Catra said.

"Good," she tried again, "Honestly, I wouldn't be surprised if I still end up having to save him from, like, getting torn apart in the streets or something."

" *Fuck* ," Catra blurted in alarm.

"Well, okay. I might be getting a little hyperbolic there. But… ugh. Whatever. It's just been a fucking day," she repeated, wilting slightly. Bow walked forward to place his hand on her shoulder and she covered it with her own, giving it a grateful squeeze. Melog meowed in encouragement. Then she looked up at the others and offered a tired smile. "I guess it's bedtime."

She got up and hugged Bow and Glimmer before they teleported back to Bright Moon, then led Adora, Melog and Catra through darkened hallways to a different part of her palace. It wasn't a long walk and Catra was still deep in thought when they stopped next to a plain door and Mermista gestured toward it.

Adora went through before Catra, but as she made to follow, Mermista opened her mouth to speak. She paused to listen, but Mermista shut her mouth again and shook her head. "Night, Mermista," Catra said.

She heard the door close softly behind Melog and looked around while the extraterrestrial feline shrank down and began inspecting the room, leaping between furniture lightly.

The room was small and plain, with white walls and a little round window with colored glass in the traditional blue hues of Salineas. But it was dry and warm, and to Catra, it was still luxuriously private space. She sighed as she looked around, then she turned to Adora, who was already sitting on the bottom edge of the narrow bed, looking up at her with a soft smile. "Long day, huh?" she asked.

Catra snorted and looked away. "I'm kind of tired, yeah."

"Is there something specific bothering you?" Adora asked as she began to strip down.

"Nothing out of the ordinary." Catra took most of her own clothes off before grabbing a couple of shirts from the bag Adora had packed. She threw them at the little table next to the bed.

"I'm over here," said Adora, smiling.

"You're not going to need clothes for a little while. That thing kicked my ass today, but that's not about to keep me out of your pants." Adora giggled and the tinkling sound made Catra smile too. She left her underthings on like Adora did and crawled into the bed with a grateful groan. It wasn't spacious, but it was soft and felt incredible against the sore spots from the day's fighting.

Adora climbed in next to her and scooted up close. Neither spoke at first, content to simply relax for a moment. Catra turned to stare at the window's colored glass and remembered that, comfortable as she might be, she was still in Salineas. At least she was already used to living in a place where everyone hated her, not that she looked forward to a return to such circumstances.

She wondered how she would fill her time, seeing as it didn't seem like duties had been planned for either her or Double Trouble. She doubted she could do much to help with whatever

they had Hordak doing, and she had no practical skills outside the arena of warfare. She was great at getting shit done, but that didn't count for anything unless she had a mission to complete.

"I can feel it when you leave," Adora murmured quietly.

"Huh?"

"You're very good at disappearing while you're still in the room."

Catra turned her face partway into her pillow and groaned instead of answering directly. After a moment, Catra spoke, voice muffled. "I don't… I'm trying not to."

She felt a warm hand rest lightly on her shoulder. "Would you tell me about it?"

Catra groaned again but decided to pull herself into a sitting position to face Adora. "Thing is, anytime I have a moment to think, I get drawn right back. Either back to the Velvet Glove or to the shit I did to Etheria." She heaved a shuddering breath. She hadn't realized how bad she felt when she'd mentioned it to Hordak, but saying it aloud to Adora was painful. "The second I'm not fucking or fighting, I get pulled back in. And you know, I can think positive thoughts, practice gratitude, try to stay present or any of the bullshit Perfuma talks about, but fighting it doesn't help."

"Is there anything I can do?"

Catra let out a frustrated sigh. "You've already been a great distraction, Adora. I'm not trying to ask for even more attention from you."

"You know it's not like that," Adora protested.

"Whatever. There's nothing you could do anyway." Catra felt the tip of her tail flick under the covers.

Adora flashed a smile. She took her hair down from it's ponytail and shook it out. "I thought I was good at distracting you," Adora said with her goofy version of a seductive glare. "Speaking of..."

She moved to reach for her, but Catra stopped her with an upheld hand. "Hang on, what's the deal here?" she asked, touching Adora's side lightly. The skin there looked red and raw.

Adora looked down at her side. "Ah, that's my bad. I've been itching at it."

"Why?"

Adora shrugged. "I don't know." She tilted her head and jutted her chin as she scratched her jaw absent-mindedly. "I've been kind of itchy since that monster thing."

Catra grabbed her wrist and pulled her hand away while leaning back to look Adora up and down where she sat in her underwear. "Is it all over? Or is it your scars?"

"My scars?" Adora asked in confusion, looking down at herself as well. She shifted a few times and seemed to take stock of sensations. "Huh, yeah I guess it is my scars. Maybe that gunk irritated them or something."

Catra ran her hands over herself now, over her bare sides and legs. "I haven't been itchy, she observed."

"You know my skin can be sensitive. Remember when I got that rash from trying the new deodorant?" Adora recalled dismissively. "And when they changed the soap? And the fabric in our uniforms?"

Catra ran her hand over Adora's side again. "Does it just feel weird, or does touching it make it itch?"

This time Adora grabbed Catra's wrist and held it fast. "You don't exactly make me itchy, but having your hands on me makes me feel some other things."

“Oh yeah?” Catra asked, grinning.

“Melog,” Adora called, grinning back at her as she backed off the bed. “Time to go exploring,” she said and opened the door for them. When Melog was gone, she shut the door and locked it before turning back to Catra. The way she was looking at her, with such brazen hunger… she felt thrills of heat spiral through her stomach and bit her lip as she watched her approach. When Adora came to stand in front of her, Catra grabbed her hips and leaned backward, pulling Adora down with her.

They moved back on the bed to where they had more room before laying down together, then they intertwined their legs and pulled each other close. Adora slid an arm beneath Catra’s neck and began stroking her hair, then she placed her free hand on her hip. They held still like that for a while, letting their breathing slow and synchronize, feeling the cares of the day slowly dull and blur into the background.

When Catra felt a pur start up in her throat, she tucked her face against Adora’s neck and nuzzled in there. She giggled and squirmed, Catra’s breath tickling her neck, and Catra held her a bit tighter. Adora wiggled until she managed to roll Catra onto her back, Catra still grinning playfully. “Catra, that tickles!”

“Oh nooo,” she whispered a sarcastic lament back at Adora, who stuck her tongue out at her in reply. Then she buried her own face in Catra’s neck and nipped at the thin skin there.

“Adora!” Catra squawked, shoving her backward hard and pouncing on top of her. “No fair!”

“Oh, now we’re fair? Is that what we are?” the blonde smiled up, eyes glittering with mischief. Catra pressed a brief, hard kiss against her mouth to shut her up.

Their kiss was joyful and easy, and Catra felt the cares of the world began to slide from her like one of Shadow Weaver’s old spells. Adora’s hair spread out around her on their bed and the

glowing blue of her eyes seemed to create their own lightsource in her dim room, and Catra was mesmerized by the shine.

This time when Adora rolled her over again, she did so gently, cupping a hand behind Catra’s neck to keep their lips together as they repositioned themselves. With Adora above her, holding her face and stroking her ears, Catra pressed herself a bit more firmly against her and moved a hand to hold the side of her face. Catra snaked her other hand along Adora’s torso, beneath her bandeau and up over her breast, which pulled Adora’s crooked smile into a full grin.. Adora pressed into Catra’s palm and gripped her hip in return, pulling Catra's pelvis more firmly against hers while the other kneaded and stroked her breasts beneath elastic.

Adora sighed happily against Catra’s mouth when she started rubbing the tip of her middle finger over her hardened nipple, and Catra took the opportunity to gently nudge her lips apart with her own. Adora opened her mouth eagerly and Catra’s tongue delved in automatically to savor her taste.

She moved the hand on Adora’s face to the back of her head so that she could dig her fingers into Adora’s hair. It had always been much thinner than hers, but it was so silky smooth that it flowed between Catra’s fingers like water. She loved the feeling of it, and that it brought back memories of kindness and comforts that she could *finally* enjoy again. She’d been terrified that such precious memories had been forever ruined by how the war had gone, but now that they were back on the same side, so were her most treasured recollections of their youth together. And, now that they were together, it was a lot easier to shrug off the less pleasant memories of their youth as well.

Adora shifted so that she leaned over Catra and deepened their kiss. The new position gave Catra the angle she needed to pull Acora’s bandeau off and watch her breasts bounce free with supreme satisfaction. She brought her fingers back to Adora’s nipple and toyed with it lightly, watching Adora’s lashes flutter. Then she drew her other nipple between her lips into her mouth.

While Adora sighed and hummed, Catra ran her free hand over her back and waist, squeezing her flanks posessively before sliding her hand over her ass beneath her briefs. When she grabbed hold and pulled Adora's pelvis down ever harder against her own, Adora rolled her hips lightly, grinding on Catra with her eyes still lightly shut.

The light in the room grew dimmer as the evening waned, but Catra's underwear were soaked through before it was dark. She pulled her mouth away from Adora's and dragged in a breath before whispering a hurried,"I love you." Adora's mouth was red and swollen and so fucking beautiful that she dove back into their kiss immediately, cutting off the other's reply. While Adora filled her hands, lungs and heart, she also filled Catra's head. She was doing her best not to compare herself to Adora, nor her experiences, but how could she not? "You don't know how special you are, do you?" she breathed between kisses.

"Special?" Adora asked incredulously. "That's some Shadow Weaver nonsense."

"I mean it," Catra insisted, pulling away again. "You came from the Horde and ended up saving Etheria! You were willing to give it all for other people. That's special." Adora kept scowling with narrowed eyes. "For instance, *I* let the war make me bitter and cruel and numb." Only then did she realize her pur had disappeared.

Adora didn't move to kiss her again, but she tightened her grip slightly and leaned down toward her face. "You know, something that Lance recently said to me seems pretty relevant right now."

"Shoot."

"He said, "All wars that last long enough become childrens' wars." We were kids, Catra. We were just doing what we thought we should."

"Is that what we fought?" Catra asked her. "A children's war?"

Adora grimaced and Catra caught a sadness in her eyes that was older than both of them. “It didn’t feel like one, did it?”

Catra sighed and spoke at Adora’s ear, pink even in low light. “I know I’m young,” Catra began hesitantly. She knew what she wanted to say, but she wasn’t sure if voicing something so negative was the right thing to do. But then again, this was Adora. If she couldn’t tell Adora… “Like, way young. But I’m tired. I’m soul-deep tired, and I feel older than I ever want to be.” She choked up and turned her head away, swallowing several times to try and dispel the lump in her throat as Adora looked down at her.

“We’ve got time to fix that, though,” Adora insisted in a resolute whisper. Catra couldn’t meet her gaze. “We’re *so* young, we still have a chance at the lives we never got to live.”

Adora’s words rang hollow in Catra’s ears. “Maybe for some of us,” she replied quietly.

Adora didn’t answer her. After a long moment, she leaned forward and kissed Catra’s forehead. “I love you, Catra. Everything is overwhelming right now, I know. But we’re going to be okay. We’re going to feel better. It’s just a matter of time and healing.” Again, Adora’s words rang hollow. But she raised her thumb up and pressed it to Catra’s forehead, smoothing out the worry lines there.

They both smiled at each other and Catra said, “I love you, dummy.”

“I love you too, asshole. More than anything else in the whole world.”









Catra began to purr softly again and she felt her body relax into the mattress below her. After a while of silently gazing into Catra's eyes, Adora's mouth twisted into a scheming smirk and her eyes narrowed.

"What are you thinking?" Catra asked suspiciously.

Adora got out of bed and took a couple of steps back before planting her feet and crossing her arms. She looked Catra up and down several times and raised an eyebrow.

"Adora?"

"I'm deciding how I'm going to fuck you," Adora said in a clipped tone, as if Catra were distracting her from something important. And just like that, Catra was right back to feeling horny as fuck. "I think I feel like spoiling you tonight. I've been thinking about it all day."

Catra felt her own eyebrows raise and her ears perked forward. "Well maybe Adora doesn't get what she wants, have you thought about that?"

"Stop being a contrarian and have some fun."

Catra grinned and stopped teasing as Adora circled to the foot of the bed and ducked under the covers to crawl toward her. Catra let her tail and toes curl in anticipation when Adora grabbed her ankles and pulled her legs apart. Once Adora was fully under their blankets and there was no more draft on Catra, she let herself cozy up in the soft, expensive sheets, Adora's torso pressing between her knees. She kept her body slung low as she inched forward, nuzzling and mouthing at her inner thighs as she went. She ran her hands up and down Catra's legs, petting reverently.

A rush of blood brought even more heat to her throbbing center and Catra felt herself clench. As Adora showered her body with attention, Catra's purring grew louder and she heaved a contented sigh. When Adora nipped at her hip bone through her briefs, her

pelvis twitched forward reflexively. Adora's humm of approval vibrated just above the waistline of her underwear, and Catra let out another, louder sigh. Her mouth lingered just below her navel, kissing her again and again while she slowly stroked up the sides of Catra's hips and hooked into the top of her briefs.

"Catra?" she asked as she slid the fabric downward, keeping her movements agonizingly slow.

"What?" Catra replied breathlessly, breathing heavily through a mixture of anticipation and impatience.

She kissed down Catra's lower belly as she exposed it. "You're the most beautiful girl I've ever seen in my life."

If she'd said it at any other time, Catra would have teased her mercilessly for being so sappy. But here, as she guided her legs up over her shoulders and tucked their second pillow beneath her lower back, the simple yet earnest statement sent butterflies through Catra's stomach like they were fifteen again. She was so flustered that she even forgot to reply.

Catra's body jerked when felt a finger wipe a trickle of fluid from her slit and heard Adora chuckle. "Seriously Catra? You're *dripping* and you were really going to argue with me?"

She muttered in protest, blushing hard in the dark. "Adora-aaAH" Catra yelped loudly when Adora pressed two fingers firmly against the swelling outer lips on either side of Catra's clit. When Adora kissed her slick skin with an open mouth, Catra let out a tiny whine from between her clenched teeth. She could sense how focused Adora was and it was utterly thrilling.

Adora settled her mouth over Catra gently and began to work her tongue through her wet folds. She moved her hands up to hold the sides of Catra's waist and looked up at her from under the covers. Her face was in shadow, but the sight was still too much to process and Catra's heart thunked unevenly in her chest for a few beats. Adora was tender and loving in every move she made.

Catra reached down to twine her blonde hair between her fingers, running them through the golden silk over and over again. The pressure of Adora's fingers on Catra's core remained light, her pace leisurely as she caressed with her fingers and tongue

When Adora dipped her tongue into her and curled it backward to collect her fluid, Catra moaned and threw her head back into her pillow, her heavy breathing quickly turning into panting. Catra felt cool air rush under the covers as Adora leaned back to admire her handiwork for a moment, and Catra could hear she was breathing hard.

Once she was satisfied with whatever she'd been looking for, Adora gripped her hips and buried her face between Catra's thighs, working her tongue more fervently than ever. Soon Catra was moving her hips against her mouth, whimpering with lust and desperate for more of Adora as she nibbled and licked fervently. Soon Catra was whining beneath her ministrations, wishing she would quit with the sightseeing and get to her clit already, rather than making a day of her dripping folds.

Adora made Catra wait, however, using her fingertips to methodically rub the slick, flushed skin around her working tongue. When Catra finally did feel a finger circling the outer ring of her entrance, she moaned loudly and squeezed her legs over Adora's shoulders. The finger probed lightly, teasing her, and Catra gripped her hair tighter in one hand, the bedsheets in the other.

"Hold my hair back," Adora paused to tell her.

"Fuck yes," Catra choked as she gathered the other's hair at the back of her head.

When her hair was out of the way and Catra's hands were occupied, Adora finally slid a finger inside of her, feeling her out with gentle movements. Her tongue continued to lap at her and she used her free arm to hold Catra's hips in place as they both grew more excited. When she drew her finger out and reentered

with two, they both moaned, Adora's voice muffled between Catra's legs.

At the same time as she began to curl her fingers forward against the front wall of Catra's passage, she opened her mouth over Catra's swollen bud and *sucked* , tonguing her all the while. Adora moaned and gripped at Catra's hip where she braced her in place, moving her entire face against Catra as she worked.

When she tucked her chin to look down at Adora's face, Catra nearly choked at the sight, her breath catching as she panted. With Catra's hand extended and holding her gathered, messy hair, the lower half of her face was hidden from view. The upper half of her face, however, was contorted in an expression of rapture, eyebrows together and lifted, eyes shut tight, lashes fluttering with expression. Every now and then Catra felt rather than heard a tiny moan against her.

Just when Catra herself began the ascent toward climax, Adora pulled her mouth away and she crashed back down to reality. "Wha… bu…" she stammered, too devastated to form full words as she took in Adora's face, glistening with her slick.

"Sorry," Adora muttered, rubbing at where a shoulder met her neck. "I'm sore from the fight and this position is starting to hurt."

Catra barely suppressed a Mermista-worthy groan as she rolled over to make room for Adora. When she turned back, however, Adora pulled her in for a rougher, more passionate kiss. Her tongue pushed into Catra's mouth, flicking it over her fangs. Catra could taste herself in Adora's mouth and it thrilled her on a primal level, striking a possessive chord within her. She put her hands back into Adora's hair and felt her move her hands back down to Catra's hips. She indulged in groping at Catra's ass for a few moments before she slid her palms back up to her waist and began to pull her up.

"Not done yet," she explained breathlessly as she guided Catra up to straddle her chest and move toward her face.

Catra felt like she should be reciprocating, but she was too eager for Adora’s tongue to insist on a different arrangement. When Adora finally tugged her forward into place, Catra lost her balance and fell onto her hands over Adora’s head. While still on all fours, she screwed up her face against another fit of giggles threatening at her cool, utterly astounded at the situation in which she found herself. Adora didn’t wait however, gluing her mouth to Catra’s core so that she was already moaning when she right/ed herself. Adora guided the angle of her hips with one hand and fondled Catra’s breasts with the other, staring up at her with wide blue eyes and her familiar, determined expression.

Catra gripped Adora by the hair with one hand and covered the hand on her breast with the other, threading their fingers together. When Adora switched from licking to sucking again, Catra arched her back, curling into the stretch to release some of the electrifying tension in her body. Adora’s scent wafted strong as she did so, and when she opened her eyes, she was looking at Adora’s knees upside-down. She pulled her hands free of Adora’s grip and lifted Adora's knees so that she could brace her shoulders on them as she arched backward. Fighting Adora's merciless onslaught to maintain attention, Catra arched her back up with her shoulders braced, and stroked the soft flesh of Adora's thighs, following them up to the source of that enchanting smell.

Catra was still arched backward, but she groaned and closed her eyes when she felt how wet Adora was. “Speaking of dripping,” she gasped.

Adora only moaned in reply, completely lost in what she was doing. Catra slipped her fingers into Adora’s wet heat and started stroking. Adora’s hips began bucking and she whimpered into Catra, her mouth growing more erratic as Catra moved her fingers faster, sensing how close they were to finishing together.

They fed off each other’s high as they climbed toward their climaxes, consuming each other ravenously. Blood rushed into Catra’s head as it hung upside-down, making her feel giddy on top of it all. Feeling Adora’s thighs start to shake was enough to push

Catra over the edge. She rode Adora's face while still arched over backward, gripping her shaking legs with her free hand for support, growing weaker by the second, awashed in her own intense climax.

When they were both spent, whimpering and twitching in place, Catra collapsed flat on the bed between Adora's legs. They lay there for a while, letting their desperate breathing slow and staring at the white ceiling above them.

After their breathing had normalized and Catra felt she'd fully regained her faculties, Adora spoke in a small voice. "Hey Catra?"

"Hey Adora?" she replied with a small smile.

"Remember when you waited for Octavia to go to the bathroom last thing before curfew, then bridged backward and spider-crawled around a dark corner at her?" They both burst into raucous laughter. "I thought she was going to kill us both," she choked out before snorting like a pig, which made her laugh harder.

"Got her good, though," Catra wheezed, wiping her eyes.

They giggled themselves out slowly, not hurrying the blissful moment. Adora placed a hand over Catra's shin and stroked her thumb lightly along her calf. "I love you," Adora said softly.

She'd already said it so many times over the last few hours alone, but Catra wasn't annoyed at all. If anything, she felt like they had years' worth of 'I love yous' to make up for. "I love you too."

The datapad on the dresser chimed and they both groaned.

Catra She felt Adora look over at it and growled, "Whatever it is, it can wait until tomorrow."

"You're right," she replied airily and heaved a huge sigh. "You're right."

Catra sighed as well and rolled off the bed, stretching her back out and folding over to hug her legs. "Still going to work with Glimmer and Bow on the clones tomorrow?" she asked.

"Yeah, I want to be more familiar with what's going on with that whole thing so Bow feels better about putting his time toward tech stuff. And is it just me, or have he and Glimmer have gotten, like, weirdly protective over the clones? I feel like it's all they ever talk about."

Catra popped back upright and shrugged before she began to look around to gather their discarded clothing. "I get it. The clones are definitely the biggest issue on her plate, you know?"

"True," Adora said, reaching to pluck her underwear from where they'd landed on a coat hook.

"Plus, Bright Moon didn't take a ton of material damage in the war. You and Perfuma have already cleared up what you needed to, Scorpia and the other ex-horde can keep it clear for transport and travel -when she's not making best friends with all the clones who're willing, that is. Entrapta's on tech, she's nearly done with her kingdom portal shit, and pretty much ready to leave the terrestrial-level stuff to clone and etherian scientists. Glimmer's parents are handling missing people and money stuff, so she might as well focus on the clones. The better they do, the better the places that absorb them do, you know?"

Adora nodded enthusiastically in agreement. "I was thinking more, like, in terms of emotion. They seem caught up is all."

"Oh, yeah I can see where you're coming from on that." They threw their laundry in a corner.

"I guess I'm a little bit worried," Adora continued, though she kept her tone light.

"You *are* a worrier."

"Yeah, but…"

Catra grabbed their shirts from the table and they reluctantly pulled them on. Catra preferred to sleep in the nude if she had her druthers, but she suddenly found herself with many friends who cared very little for privacy. She noted the continuing silence and realized Adora never finished what she was saying. She looked up and saw that Adora was staring out the window, and seemed to have forgotten they were talking. "Adora?"

"Huh? Oh, right," she said, shaking her head and sighing. "It's just that Bow opened up to me about some of the stuff he's having trouble with, you know, with the clones."

"Yeah?" Catra asked seriously, crawling back into bed while watching Adora's body language. She didn't seem tense or stressed. A little dejected maybe.

"Yeah. And Glimmer's hinted that he's told her worse. But I think for the most part… I don't know… they've just been through… like I can't even imagine the kind of mind-fuck they've trying to live with."

Catra sighed as Adora climbed into bed beside her. "None of us can imagine it. At least, I hope we never do. I don't ever want to truly understand what they've been through."

Adora pushed Catra's shoulder, rolling her to face away. She slid an arm beneath her neck, slung the other over her waist, and tucked her cold fingers under Catra's left tit. Her contented sigh ruffled Catra's hair and she squeezed her affectionately for a moment.

As they lay in the warm bed, Catra reviewed her day. She'd had an outright semi-public breakdown, had bitched out on a massive responsibility, then fought a pretty gross monster. Yet now, somehow, she was still going to bed as happy as she'd ever been? Her. Catra. *Catra* Catra. And good luck? Together? No. No fucking way.

She should be beyond ecstatic to have suddenly become so fortunate. She knew she should. And, for what it was worth, she tried to truly enjoy what she had while she had it. But her gratitude was overshadowed by a creeping sense of dread. She was waiting for the other shoe to drop, for there to be a catch. She couldn't trust her luck. Hope had kicked her ass too many times to fall for that old scam again.

Adora murmured something and Catra stilled, waiting for her to continue. Then she realized she was already out, just muttering in her sleep. Catra laid her hand over Adora's hand on her chest, until Adora pulled it away to scratch lightly at her side in her sleep.

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